

# FP

SUMMER 2026



## *the* End of

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# FOREIGN POLICY

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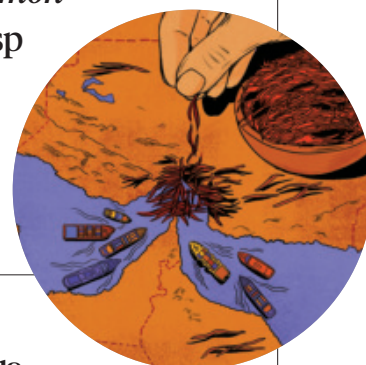
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**REMEMBER THE R.E.M. SONG** “It’s the End of the World as We Know It (And I Feel Fine)”? It’s been in my head recently. The track was released in November 1987, about a month before U.S. President Ronald Reagan and Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev signed an arms control treaty that set the stage for the end of the Cold War. Michael Stipe, the band’s frontman, has said the idea came to him after a deep sleep. But its resonance with listeners could have been because it came at the end of a worrying time for the world, right before a geopolitical dawn. It’s not so far from the “end of the world” to the “end of history,” a term this magazine’s readers know all too well.

Long after the fall of the Berlin Wall and the optimistic pop sounds of the ’90s that came with it, this particular R.E.M. song has endured as an earworm—and a recurring vibe. It made a brief comeback around December 2012, when people worldwide seized on the idea of a Maya-predicted apocalypse. And then the track reportedly saw a surge in streaming during the COVID-19 pandemic. Now, in 2026, I would wager that songs about the end of the world are once again back in vogue, neatly mirroring news of endless war and its accompanying crises of food, energy, inflation, migration, and much else.

Is this the end of the world as we know it? Is that a good thing or a bad thing? Will it eventually lead, as it did at least once before, to a more hopeful moment?

I can’t claim to have answers. But our Summer 2026 issue has plenty of food for thought. We’ve put together a collection of 10 essays that explore trends, ideas, and geopolitical cornerstones that are falling apart—slowly yet seemingly all at once (Page 41).

**Joshua Leifer** examines how the once unshakeable U.S.-Israel alliance has “entered a period of terminal decline.” **Nathalie Tocci** goes a step further, arguing that the relationship between the United States and Europe—the bedrock of a liberal international order—is gone. It won’t come back, Tocci says, no matter who takes U.S. President Donald Trump’s place in a few years. **James Traub** has long covered the United Nations and tells the story of that visibly shrunk global body, a fall accelerated by Washington and its changing priorities.

What will the world look like without these partnerships and organizations? Much will depend on how countries navigate the moment. **Anton Jäger** points out the declining role of political parties, which he sees as “increasingly anachronistic,” as one thing to keep an eye on. Parties and publics will need to reckon with where things went wrong, including with neoliberalism, **Branko Milanovic** writes. Young voters around the world will no doubt ask why they



have been left to navigate a climate disaster, a scenario that **Leah Aronowsky** grapples with as she looks at how Western elites failed to come up with a plan to deal with civilization’s greatest threat. The problem might be systemic: Collective action is tougher to come by given that international law is weaker than it has been in decades, according to **Rosa Brooks**, who calls this trend not just a moral loss but a “structural catastrophe.” Just consider how the right to asylum now feels like an artifact of a bygone era, as **Linda Kinstler** argues.

Some of the old engines of the global economy are petering out. China’s record double-digit growth rates, which powered a commodities boom around the world, are gone forever, FP’s **James Palmer** forecasts. But can we even predict the future anymore? **Jonathan White** isn’t so sure, pointing to how people now seem trapped in a sense of fatalism instead of optimism.

You’ll find more questions than answers in this package. Even so, if we hope for a new and better world, I feel we must engage fully with such provocations.

Lots more in this issue, as always, including a timely essay by **Hal Brands** exploring how the Iran war has left the United States overstretched—and an easier target for China (Page 33). Bracing reads all around, I know, but I hope you’ll enjoy this issue all the same. And for those in the Northern Hemisphere, with a dose of sunshine alongside it.

As ever,

A stylized, handwritten signature in dark ink, appearing to read 'Ravi Agrawal'.

Ravi Agrawal



FP

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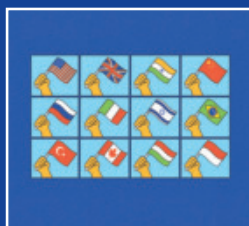
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# ARGUMENTS

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A billboard features late Iranian Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei in Tehran on May 5.

## War Has Handed Public Space Back to Iran's Regime

By Saeid Golkar

Iran has entered a critical moment in its postrevolutionary history. Many analyses of the U.S.-Israeli war have focused on the growing dominance of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC). This is correct, but it misses another important transformation, which is happening in Iran's public space.

From the beginning of the war, the Islamic Republic has actively mobilized

its supporters, including the Basij and networks close to the Guards, into the streets of Tehran and other major cities. They gather in groups, even small ones, and move across neighborhoods, chanting Islamic and anti-American slogans, reciting the Quran, and organizing mobile rallies. Using loudspeakers mounted on cars, they often shout, "Heydar, Heydar," referring to Imam Ali, the first Shiite imam.

These activities are not limited to one

area. They are spreading across public squares, main roads, and residential districts in large cities. Nor are they merely public displays. In these rallies, more akin to festivals, the IRGC showcases missiles described as ready for launch while large crowds gather around waving flags and, in some cases, even performing collective prayers near the missiles.

The events are a symbolic show of strength and defiance, but they also connect directly to a broader shift on the ground. Alongside these rallies, the Basij and police have set up checkpoints across cities, searching cars and—in many cases—people’s cellphones to identify any anti-regime messages or posts. In some cases, the security forces beat and detain individuals based on content found on their phones.

In this newly visible security environment, routine public movement has become controlled and uncertain, especially for regime critics. As a result, many ordinary Iranians prefer not to be outside, especially at night, when many of the IRGC rallies take place. Frustrated by these shows and the disruptions they create, and scared of the Basij patrols and checkpoints, Iranians are retreating to their homes as a safe space.

Together with Israeli and U.S. messaging that urges civilians to avoid the outdoors, the result is a clear shift in public behavior. As Iranians have withdrawn from the streets, pro-regime groups have moved in and filled the space. This is a reversal of a long-term social trend before the war in which Iranians were reclaiming public space they had lost since the revolution.

Since 1979, the Islamic Republic has tried to regulate public life by enforcing Islamic regulations. In the first decade after the revolution, even wearing jeans and short-sleeved shirts was challenging because of the regime’s moral policing on the streets.

But despite dominating the state, the Islamic Republic gradually lost control over public space in the ensuing decades. While the regime preserved its

coercive capacity—to regulate behavior, punish violations, and impose rules—it could not fully dominate social life, especially in urban areas. Without organization, leadership, or direct confrontation, Iranians began to reshape public space from below. This is where Asef Bayat’s concept of “quiet encroachment” becomes central. According to Bayat, social change can emerge through small, dispersed, everyday actions, rather than dramatic political acts. Such actions do not have to be coordinated to prove effective. And in Iran, the public shifted socially and culturally, becoming less ideological and more attuned to daily life than to revolutionary ideals.

Iranian women, for example, adjusted the boundaries of the compulsory hijab in subtle but noticeable ways. Despite the regime’s pressure to enforce the hijab in public, Iranian women defied the imposed dress code—first by wearing loose hijabs and later, especially after the 2022 Woman, Life, Freedom protests, by not wearing hijabs in public at all.

Other examples of social shifts in urban Iran included more mixed-gender gatherings in cafes, parks, and other public spaces, as well as young men and women interacting more openly despite formal restrictions. At the same time, the presence of pets, particularly dogs, became more visible in public. (Pets are heavily restricted and socially discouraged by the regime.) The change was gradual but real. Public space was no longer fully shaped by the Islamic Republic’s social vision as public defiance of the regime and its ideology grew.

Regime supporters and traditional religious people retreated and concentrated in more controlled environments, either in central Tehran neighborhoods such as Khayaban-e Iran and Hedayat or in new townships created by the regime. Across Iran, the Islamic Republic and its institutions developed these semi-closed townships and residential zones for loyalists, including Basij members, IRGC families, and conservative

religious groups. Areas such as Shah-rak-e Mahallati became safe spaces where ideological conformity was preserved. In addition to these townships, pro-regime groups created their own social environments, including schools, cafes, restaurants, hotels, and other gathering places shaped by strict norms of dress and behavior. Most Iranians have not been welcomed in these places, either because of legal constraints—as with the schools and townships—or because they feared the strict Islamic dress and conduct codes, as with the cafes and restaurants. Outside these zones, however, the broader urban space was more contested and, in many cases, increasingly shaped by ordinary Iranians defying regime norms.

With much of the population staying indoors, regime supporters have returned to the very spaces they had gradually lost over the years. Their chants, gatherings, public shows, and movement across neighborhoods are meant to signal presence, control, and a sense of domination over public space. By bringing its supporters back into the streets in a visible and organized way, the state is trying to reimpose a social order that had been gradually weakened.

In this sense, the war has created an unintended consequence. It has, at least temporarily, reversed years of quiet encroachment by ordinary Iranians and opened space for pro-regime forces to reclaim the urban landscape. This matters because control over the street is not only symbolic. Who occupies public space, who can gather, and who can project visibility all shape perceptions of authority and legitimacy.

Iran’s street-level shift is occurring alongside a deeper structural transformation within the state as the regime moves toward a more security-dominated order, with the IRGC at the center of power. The transformation of the state and the transformation of the street are connected. A regime that relies more on coercion, loyalty, and ideological discipline also needs a social presence.

For ordinary Iranians, this has clear implications, as already limited public space may shrink further. What was once a form of everyday resistance—occupying public space—is now constrained by war and has been replaced by organized displays of regime loyalty.

On the political level, this also complicates the idea of regime change. The regime's social base, although limited, is not disappearing. Under the current conditions, it is becoming more visible. What we are seeing is not the collapse of the Islamic Republic but rather the regime becoming more centralized, more insulated, and more dependent on a smaller but more active core of supporters. At the same time, it is trying to reassert control over society through institutions as well as through space itself.

The war, in this sense, is fought not only in the air or with missiles. It is also fought in the streets of Tehran and other cities. And—for now—those streets are changing hands. ■

**SAEID GOLKAR** is an associate professor of political science at the University of Tennessee at Chattanooga and a senior advisor at United Against Nuclear Iran.

## The Real Meaning of the UAE's OPEC Exit

By Amir Handjani

**W**hen the United Arab Emirates exited OPEC on May 1, it was not abandoning a club so much as declaring that

the club no longer served its interests. That distinction matters. Abu Dhabi's departure is not a reaction to a single grievance but the convergence of three forces: the Iran war, a deepening rivalry with Saudi Arabia, and a strategic realignment with Washington that has been years in the making.

The U.S.-Israel war on Iran has made the UAE a front-line state in ways it did not fully expect. Iran justified targeting Emirati territory by citing Abu Dhabi's decades-long strategic alignment with Washington, a designation formalized when the United States named the UAE a "major defense partner" in 2024. Iranian strikes hit Fujairah's industrial zone, rattled Jebel Ali's port, and sent smoke over Dubai's skyline. The UAE has absorbed this punishment largely alone. Its Gulf Cooperation Council partners offered solidarity, but, as Emirati presidential advisor Anwar Gargash pointedly noted in late April, their political and military response was "the weakest historically." That frustration, expressed publicly on the eve of the OPEC announcement, turned out to be ominous.

The Iran conflict has produced an energy shock of historic proportions. OPEC's total output collapsed by 27 percent to 20.79 million barrels per day in March, as Iranian strikes on Gulf infrastructure and threats to shipping

through the Strait of Hormuz severed supply chains. The resulting supply contraction, 7.88 million barrels per day in a single month, surpassed even the 1973 oil embargo and the 1991 Gulf War. The Strait of Hormuz, through which roughly a fifth of the world's crude and liquefied natural gas normally pass, has become a chokepoint under active siege. In this environment, the UAE, which keeps significant spare production capacity and has spent years investing in expanding it, finds itself holding an asset of extraordinary geopolitical value. Staying inside OPEC, with its production quotas and consensus-driven governance, would mean subordinating that asset to a collective framework that no longer adequately represents Abu Dhabi's interests. The logic of exit is, in that light, rational.

However, the timing and manner of the withdrawal also reflect something deeper: the consequences of a long-simmering rivalry with Saudi Arabia. The Riyadh-Abu Dhabi relationship, often described as the backbone of Gulf stability, has been quietly fracturing for years over the central question of who controls the oil.

The roots of the dispute trace to 2016, when the OPEC+ alliance was formed with Russia and the UAE began to sense that its allocated quotas failed to reflect its rapidly expanding production



A trader walks beneath a stock display board at the Dubai stock exchange on March 8, 2020.



capacity. The COVID-19 price war in 2020, which Saudi Arabia led by engineering deep cuts, widened the rift. Abu Dhabi viewed those reductions as an unfair burden while it had invested heavily in ramping up output. By 2021, the UAE was openly rejecting Saudi-backed production extensions, forcing a confrontation that was resolved only by granting Abu Dhabi a higher baseline quota of 3.65 million barrels per day. The compromise papered over the disagreement; it did not resolve it.

Since then, the tensions have grown more structural. Saudi Arabia, which needs Brent crude near \$80 per barrel to balance its budget and fund the ambitions of its Vision 2030 project, has an enduring interest in managed supply and elevated prices. The UAE—whose economy has diversified far more aggressively, with Dubai functioning as a global hub for finance, logistics, and aviation—is less dependent on the high oil price floor. What Abu Dhabi wants from its oil sector is not price management but maximum volume, a return on the billions of dollars invested in expanding the capacity of the Abu Dhabi National Oil Co. These are not simply different policy preferences; they are different economic models. Emirati Energy Minister Suhail Mohamed al-Mazrouei confirmed in April that Abu Dhabi did not even consult Riyadh before announcing its departure, a detail that says everything about the state of the relationship. Saudi Arabia, OPEC's unquestioned leader, learned of the exit from a press release.

The Washington part of this story is equally significant. The Abraham Accords, the deepening security partnerships with Israel, the positioning of Abu Dhabi as the indispensable Gulf ally—all is aimed at making U.S. disengagement from the UAE politically and strategically costly. That wager is now being tested, and Washington appears to have responded. U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent publicly backed an emergency dollar swap line for Abu Dhabi in

the days before the OPEC announcement. U.S. President Donald Trump, who has long criticized the OPEC cartel as exploitative of U.S. military protection, has effectively given Abu Dhabi diplomatic cover to defect. The alignment between an Emirati wish to produce freely and a Trump administration desire to see more oil on global markets at lower prices is not coincidental. It is, in structural terms, an alignment of interest between Washington and Abu Dhabi that has been underway for years.

The UAE has also been playing the China card with considerable sophistication. Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Khaled bin Mohamed Al Nahyan's recent visit to Beijing produced a raft of economic agreements, and Emirati officials have floated the possibility of pricing some oil transactions in yuan if dollar liquidity tightens—something like the Saudi maneuver in 2023 that prompted an acceleration of U.S. diplomatic engagement with Riyadh. Abu Dhabi is not pivoting to China; it is using China to extract better terms from Washington. Its sovereign wealth funds are still overwhelmingly oriented toward U.S. and European assets. The Beijing signals are best read as calibrated leverage and not a pivot, serving as a reminder to Washington that Abu Dhabi's partnership should not be taken for granted.

What does the exit mean for OPEC itself? The loss is severe and potentially existential in the medium term. The UAE was the cartel's third-largest producer, accounting for 12 percent of total OPEC supply before the conflict. Angola left in 2024 over quota disputes. Qatar left in 2019. Each exit was framed as idiosyncratic; the cumulative pattern is a cartel being hollowed out from within by the same forces of strategic divergence that have now claimed Abu Dhabi. Saudi Arabia keeps the institutional architecture of OPEC and the political will to lead it, but steering a smaller, less capable organization in a period of historic supply disruption will be challenging to say the least. Riyadh

will be leading a structurally weaker OPEC moving forward.

The Iran war has not unified the Gulf. It has instead fragmented it along preexisting fault lines: accelerating divergences visible in Yemen policy, economic competition, and differing calculations about how to manage relations with Washington and Tehran. That fragmentation is visible in the starkly different postures Gulf states have adopted toward Iran: Oman, which hosted the prewar U.S.-Iran nuclear negotiations and has been the region's most consistent mediator, has continued to call for diplomacy even as Iranian strikes hit its own territory. Qatar, which shares a vast gas field with Iran and has historically kept open lines to Tehran, has emphasized coexistence, with its foreign ministry noting in March that the two countries "will be neighbors for the future of humankind." Saudi Arabia, despite absorbing Iranian strikes, has similarly signaled a preference for de-escalation, wary of a war that threatens its own economic transformation agenda.

The UAE alone has staked out the hard line, demanding reparations, the unconditional reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, and a comprehensive rollback of Iranian power. The OPEC exit is the result of a geopolitical posture that now sets Abu Dhabi apart not just from Riyadh but from the Gulf consensus more broadly. The UAE has concluded that its interests are best served by acting as a sovereign actor rather than a cartel member. Whether that calculation proves correct depends on how the war ends and what regional architecture emerges from it. One thing the OPEC decision makes unmistakably clear is that the old Gulf compact, built on shared institutions and the fiction of unified interests, is over. ■

**AMIR HANDJANI** is a board member at the Quincy Institute for Responsible Statecraft and partner at the strategic advisory firm Karv.



# The Iran War Is Eroding Israel's Nuclear Ambiguity

By Yonatan Touval

On May 4, 30 House Democrats sent a letter to U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio urging the United States to publicly acknowledge Israel's nuclear weapons program. Led by Rep. Joaquin Castro, they called Washington's long-standing policy of silence indefensible amid the war with Iran and asked whether Israel had conveyed any "red lines" for nuclear use. Castro posed a question whose force lay in its simplicity: The United States openly discusses the nuclear programs of Britain, France, India, Pakistan, Russia, North Korea, and China. Why should Israel's be treated differently?

The letter would have been unthinkable a decade ago. Avner Cohen, a leading historian of Israel's nuclear program, called it a break with a half-century taboo in U.S. politics. For more than 50 years, Israel's policy of nuclear opacity survived wars, diplomatic crises, covert campaigns, and even direct strikes on Iran's nuclear infrastructure. Everyone knew Israel had a nuclear program, but Washington respected the country's official policy of never publicly acknowledging its existence. Instead, the conversation remained focused on what Iran was building, not on what Israel already possessed.

The latest war with Iran has changed that frame. Once nuclear weapons in the Middle East have become the stated subject of international war, Israel's

arsenal cannot stay outside the conversation. That 30 members of Congress are now saying so openly is itself a measure of how much has changed.

Prime Minister Levi Eshkol gave Israel's nuclear posture its canonical formula in 1966: Israel "has no atomic arms and will not be the first to introduce such weapons in the Middle East." Its unstated completion was always clear: Israel would not be the second, either. In this space between deterrence and declaration, a policy of *amimut*—the Hebrew term for opacity—took shape. Israel could possess the capability, rely on it, and still insist that it had not "introduced" nuclear weapons, so long as it neither declared nor tested nor openly brandished them.

Opacity was never mainly about deceiving adversaries. Iran, like every serious military establishment in the region, has long operated on the assumption that Israel possesses a nuclear deterrent. The value of opacity was political and diplomatic. It reduced pressure on Arab governments to acknowledge a permanent strategic inferiority. It muted pressures on neighboring states to answer with nuclear ambitions of their own, even if it never eliminated that incentive altogether. It gave Washington room to preserve Israel's strategic advantage without having to defend it explicitly in every nonproliferation forum.

Crucially, Israel's ambiguity was never merely an Israeli doctrine. It was also an effort to accommodate Washington. And it is the U.S. half of the arrangement that is now breaking down.

Israeli opacity both facilitated and depended on a U.S. willingness to focus the nuclear nonproliferation question exclusively on Iran. This meant that Israel could strike reactors, sabotage facilities, kill scientists, and wage a long campaign against Iran's nuclear program without bringing its own deterrent into explicit view. Even the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action did not fundamentally alter that logic. The 2015 agreement, which entered into force in 2016, put Iran's program under extraordinary inspection while leaving Israel's position undisturbed. When President Donald Trump withdrew the United States from the deal in 2018, he intensified the conflict around Iran's nuclear future but not around Israel's nuclear present.

The latest war has broken that frame by making nonproliferation part of the overt grammar of a large regional conflict. This time the issue is not covert, not limited, and not ambiguous. Iran's nuclear program is now at the center of a sustained, open conflict involving major powers—one that has disrupted global energy markets, threatened regional stability, and

Israel's Dimona nuclear facility, located in the Negev desert, on March 8, 2014.



produced daily international headlines. The war's stated purpose, repeated by U.S. and Israeli officials alike, has been to destroy Iran's nuclear capability and prevent it from obtaining a weapon. The strikes on Fordow, Natanz, and Isfahan were not isolated punitive measures. They were part of a campaign explicitly framed as eliminating Iran's nuclear infrastructure. Once a conflict of this scale and explicitness is waged over nuclear weapons in the Middle East, opacity becomes structurally difficult to sustain.

This does not mean that Israel is on the verge of abandoning opacity. No Israeli government is about to exchange a posture that has served the country for decades for the burdens of formal acknowledgment. But opacity can erode without ending. Its legal shell can remain in place while its diplomatic and strategic function weakens.

The consequences are playing out in two dimensions. The first is operational. A sustained conflict pushes Israel's strategic geography into public view. When Iranian missiles strike Israeli territory, and when those strikes occur in a conflict explicitly about nuclear capabilities, places such as Dimona—long meant to hover quietly in the background of deterrence—enter the ordinary terrain of war reporting. The crucial point is not simply whether the reactor itself was targeted. It is that Dimona is now part of the everyday map of the conflict. It is named in dispatches, discussed in relation to missile trajectories, and analyzed in the context of strategic vulnerability. That is a different kind of visibility from what earlier covert operations or limited strikes produced. It is the visibility that comes from being part of an active war zone.

The second dimension is discursive. The conflict has made nuclear questions a routine part of public discussion in ways opacity was designed to prevent. Iranian officials, regional analysts, and Western commentators are

increasingly folding Israel's deterrent into their accounts of the conflict.

The shift surfaced even at the highest levels in Washington. After David Sacks, a senior White House advisor, raised the possibility of Israeli nuclear use if the war escalated further, Trump was asked about it and replied: "Israel wouldn't do that. Israel would never do that." The exchange did not amount to formal acknowledgment. But the fact that a U.S. president was publicly responding to the question at all marked a change. What opacity once kept outside the bounds of ordinary official comment was now being managed in public through reassurance and denial. The congressional letter, in turn, represents something different in kind. The Sacks exchange was improvised, while the letter is deliberate. Indeed, the letter belongs to a broader Democratic reassessment of the U.S.-Israel relationship.

A further complication is that Israel may be losing its monopoly on strategic ambiguity. Iran's nuclear latency appears damaged but not eliminated. If Tehran advances further into the gray zone—achieving the capacity for nuclear weapons without openly crossing the threshold—the region will contain two states living in strategically consequential ambiguity. Amimut was built for a Middle East in which no adversary occupied the same twilight between capability and declaration.

Of course, if Iran were eventually to cross the threshold overtly, pressure on Israel's undeclared posture would intensify still further. It is one thing to preserve opacity when no regional adversary has an acknowledged arsenal. It is another to do so in a region where an adversary does.

Even under the strains of the latest war, neither the U.S. nor Israeli government is likely to abandon the old formula outright. Israel will almost certainly continue to say what it has long said: that it will not be the first to introduce nuclear weapons into the Middle East.

But opacity can survive as doctrine and still fail as diplomacy. Its power lay not in concealing what Israel possessed but in keeping that possession outside the ordinary language of politics. Once that language changes, the strategic benefits of ambiguity begin to erode—there will be more demands for U.S. oversight, more demands for Israeli red lines, and a more usable argument for Iran and others that would follow.

The danger is not that Israel will confess. It is that everyone else will begin acting as if the confession has already happened. What replaces the old silence may be more transparent. Whether it will be more stable is another question entirely. ■

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## Mali Is Key to Understanding Africa's Trajectory

*By Howard W. French*

**D**uring a lengthy career as a foreign correspondent, when human disasters, violence, and turmoil were common, I experienced two long-running stories that were positive in nature and left me feeling blessed to have been in the right job, in the right place, at the right time.

One was covering China during the first decade of this century, a time of mind-blowing growth and transformation. The other was reporting in West Africa during the mid-1990s, when a

quiet revolution that swept the political landscape seemed just as dramatic.

The continent's first big wave of hopeful political change had come in 1960, widely called the "Year of Africa," because 17 countries attained independence in rapid succession. The mid-1990s saw that era's echo. In 1996 alone, when 18 African countries held competitive elections, democracy seemed to be on the march after decades in which authoritarians and the one-party systems they built were the rule across most of the continent.

Back then, I spent a lot of time going from country to country covering meaningful, civil, and detailed debates about possible paths forward for nations that faced some of the world's most daunting development challenges. But one region drew me back time and again: the semi-arid belt to the south of the Sahara known as the Sahel.

One country in particular stood out for me as a kind of sentinel for much of Africa. In 1992, Mali pulled off a stunning transition to democratic rule that seemed to catalyze political change in countries near and far. At the time of Mali's breakthrough, it was a country of about 9 million people, with an annual per capita income of \$280 and a literacy rate of a mere 40 percent. Seeing that democracy could sprout in such unpromising soil lit a path for other African nations. Elections soon followed in Benin, Zambia, Ghana, and nearby Niger. Even authoritarian countries—such as Ivory Coast, where I was based—felt pressure to loosen controls on political speech and inject more life into their elections, if not free them up entirely.

Mali has been on my mind recently for far less encouraging news. In late April, its junta-led government was routed by the forces of a northern, ethnic insurgency that mounted a coordinated attack with an al Qaeda-affiliated radical religious group. In a broad-based assault that bore resemblance to the Vietnam War's Tet Offensive,

albeit on a smaller scale, fighters struck several cities in the country simultaneously with deadly force and killed Mali's No. 2 figure, Defense Minister Sadio Camara, and injured its intelligence chief. In a sign of how badly the government was rocked, Mali's president, Assimi Goïta, disappeared from view for several days.

Today, once again, Mali seems to be a sentinel for much of the continent, only this time an ominous one. Like Mali, two of its Sahelian neighbors—Burkina Faso and Niger—have recently traversed several years of shifting, but ultimately ineffectual, approaches to combating the spread of radical Islamism. They have all experienced military takeovers of national politics; rejected their former colonizer, France, as a security partner; and hired Russian mercenary forces to augment their armies. Meanwhile, they have each resorted to populist nationalism, forging an alliance among themselves and distancing their countries from many of their other neighbors, including by leaving the Economic Community of West African States.

As in Mali, the results for Burkina Faso and Niger have been slim to negative. Worse still, signs of insecurity and religious and other radicalism are spreading on the fringes of these three states. The north of Nigeria has long been beset with violence from both the Islamist movement Boko Haram and

other organized banditry. But in recent months, there has been increasing evidence that these kinds of destabilizing forces are penetrating stable West African democracies, such as Ghana and Benin, and a neighboring bastion of prosperity, Ivory Coast.

Looking back, I am struck by how clear it was already in the time of the African Spring in the '90s that Mali was a bulwark against radical Islam, insurgencies, and state disintegration in West Africa. It seemed evident to me that the future of democracy, at least in West Africa, reposed disproportionately on the success against long odds of the Malian experiment.

Although I felt real optimism in the moment, rereading my coverage the signs were already surprisingly bad. International support for a democratic transition in Africa was scant, and officials in Mali and elsewhere spoke starkly about the future implications of this.

The headline on an article I wrote in the *New York Times* in February 1995 could well stand today: "In Africa, West Can Pay Now, Or Later," it read in stark, telegraphic style. What this meant is that without both more substantial and much more effective help for Africa's newborn democracies—and Mali, in particular—the consequences of deepening poverty and eventual state failure would be felt far and wide.

A month later, I wrote a piece on



A motorcyclist rides past a monument in support of the Malian military in Bamako, Mali, on April 26.



fears about Western aid cuts, which quoted Mali's then-president, Alpha Oumar Konaré. "We are confronted with a series of grave inherited problems today, and if we do not receive the kind of help that we need, we will not make it," Konaré told me. The irony is that senior Western officials acknowledged this at the time as well. In the same article, I quoted Anthony Lake, U.S. President Bill Clinton's national security advisor, as saying, "Those of us who recognize the importance of continued active engagement and support for Africa are confronting the reality of shrinking resources and an honest skepticism about the return on our investments in peacekeeping and development."

One can debate the generosity of Western development assistance to Africa in the Clinton era, but a few hard truths seem beyond dispute. The first is that after centuries of rank exploitation, including the trans-Atlantic slave trade and the colonial era that stretched from the 1890s into the 1960s, the West took severe advantage of Africa with scant regard for its economic or human development.

The second is that few African countries have had the economic means, whether in terms of export income or domestic savings, to lift themselves to even modest prosperity. As Joe Studwell argues in his book *How Africa Works*, sustained economic growth is vanishingly rare on the continent, and the few countries that have achieved it did so under conditions that most African nations cannot hope to replicate.

The third stark truth is that Western economic assistance to Africa, already under pressure in the Clinton era, has declined further since. The United States, in particular, has grown stingier and steadily less engaged with the continent. U.S. President Donald Trump famously disparaged Africa as a land of "shithole" countries and, in his second term, quickly moved to kill off Washington's principal economic

assistance body, the U.S. Agency for International Development.

It is clearer now than ever that African state failure will inflict huge costs for the world. The least subtle way is through migration—chaotic, large-scale movements of people toward Europe and elsewhere. This specter alone captures the imaginations of the West for reasons of xenophobia, racism, and selfishness. For the time being, though, African out-migration is still relatively modest, and African countries bear the overwhelming share of the burden in hosting one another's economic and political refugees.

The deeper cost, though less viscerally felt in Western capitals so far, is potentially far greater. By century's end, Africa will be home to more than a third of humanity. By then, African brains, African labor, and African consumption will be central, not peripheral, to global prosperity. A world in which that population is trapped in failing or stagnant states is not a world that prospers. The West can choose to engage seriously with Africa's development now, or it can pay a far higher price later.

None of this is to say the responsibility falls on the outside world alone. What is wrong with the African side in this equation is painfully obvious in Mali. It is no accident that the country cannot field an effective army. Since the collapse of Mali's democracy in 2021, a phenomenon common to many postcolonial African states has deepened in the country, whereby those who govern have ceased their primary role of delivering vital goods to their citizens, meaning education, health care, agricultural extension services, and infrastructure improvements.

What replaces these is what economists call rent seeking, in which the principal business of government is to deliver benefits to those who govern, along with their families and patronage networks. Countries that are ruled this way slowly rot. A failure to develop and invest in a professionalized army

is but one of the symptoms, and as leadership cliques become ever more preoccupied with their own privileges and survival, the military forces that remain see little reason to die protecting them.

Governments that become alienated from their people then resort to cheap tricks in order to stay in power. To a nation under siege from insurgents, this usually means mercenaries, as with the Russian forces in Mali. They exact high costs but almost never get the job done, fleeing battle, as Ukrainian mercenaries did during the collapsing rule of Mobutu Sese Seko in Zaire (now the Democratic Republic of the Congo) in the 1990s. Mali's Russians-for-hire did the same in April.

Another cheap trick is facile nationalism. Mali and its Sahel allies, Burkina Faso and Niger, have fetishized France's past misdeeds of exploitation and intervention. But as much as their citizens have a right to be unhappy about erstwhile French domination, this is no policy menu.

Things seem bound to get much worse in the Sahel before they get any better. The road ahead, if there is one, will require institution-building national leaders who are obsessively driven to meet the real needs of their people and international partners who understand it is in their own deep interest to help them do so. Mali's president warned in 1995 that without serious help, his country would not make it. The West was already running short of will then. It has even less now. ■

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## AMERICAS



# Why No President Before Trump Authorized War With Iran

By Dalia Dassa Kaye

For nearly half a century, U.S. leaders, and perhaps Americans themselves, have viewed Iran as the “ultimate rogue.” Tehran’s unchanging anti-American ideology and religiously dogmatic leadership have set it apart in the American imagination from other difficult enemies.

Just two weeks before U.S. President Donald Trump launched his war against Iran, Secretary of State Marco Rubio expressed a long-standing view of the regime’s leaders, arguing: “These people make policy decisions on the basis of pure theology. That’s how they make their decisions. So it’s hard to do a deal with Iran.”

The rhetoric was such a staple of Washington talk about Iran that hardly anyone noticed. But this profoundly ingrained anti-Iran sentiment in Washington helped set the stage for Trump taking the United States to war. It is a set of attitudes fueled in part by

decades of hostile Iranian actions, from the original sin of taking U.S. diplomats hostage during the 1979 revolution to decades of support for militant groups across the region and acts of terrorism globally, all of which were supercharged by a nuclear standoff beginning in the early 2000s.

Yet Trump’s war cannot be seen as merely a natural progression of U.S.-Iranian hostility. Despite a deep well of animosity, previous U.S. presidents never went so far. U.S. policy largely defaulted to containment, drawing on policies short of war such as economic sanctions, diplomatic isolation, and military deterrence. Successive administrations, Democratic and Republican, even attempted diplomacy to resolve U.S. differences with Iran, though domestic politics, in both Washington and Tehran, repeatedly stifled any chance of sustainable breakthroughs. U.S. officials debated military options in previous administrations but ultimately ruled them out, viewing the risks as too high and the outcomes as too uncertain. Until now.

Trump’s decision to choose war over diplomacy continues a well-trodden path of confrontational attitudes and policies, but more importantly, it also marks a radical departure, taking the United States on a path that is unlikely to “solve” Iran. Trump claims that he has done what no previous president “had the guts” to do. But his overreach

will bring infamy rather than glory, with dire regional and global consequences that will outlive his presidency.

It seems unlikely that, in the months leading up to this U.S.-Israeli attack on Iran, Trump’s envoy Steve Witkoff and son-in-law Jared Kushner were engaged in genuine attempts to strike a diplomatic deal to stave off war. The track record of U.S. attacks in the midst of diplomacy, as occurred last June during the 12-day war, did not bode well for dealmaking. Then there were the wide gaps in positions on the nuclear and missile issues as well as Washington’s maximalist demands, premised on a belief that Iran was so weakened after the June war that it would capitulate on previously unattainable concessions, such as zero nuclear enrichment.

Trump’s tepid commitment to diplomacy with Iran was not unprecedented. It followed a long history of U.S. ambivalence about engaging Iranians and a mindset that one cannot deal with the Islamic Republic as a “normal” state. Indeed, the narrative of Iran as an abnormal state—and rhetoric labeling the country as “evil” and “fanatical”—set the stage for how Trump and his top officials viewed the country. Rubio was not alone in his rhetoric. U.S. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth expressed similar skepticism in previous speeches and writings toward diplomacy and the notion that any Iranian leaders could be considered moderates. Demonstrat-



U.S. President Barack Obama holds a collection of statements in support of the Iran nuclear deal during a conference in Baltimore on Jan. 28, 2016.

ing just how little has changed in U.S. policymakers' view of Iran over 40 years, Caspar Weinberger, President Ronald Reagan's defense secretary, once remarked that "the only moderates in Iran ... are in the cemetery."

Not everyone in the U.S. government has viewed Iran as an irrational state driven solely by Islamic ideology; many intelligence assessments over the years have offered sober analyses to explain Iranian behavior as that of a rational, albeit dangerous and extremist, state actor. But the public conversation, often reflected in policy debates, circles around Iranian irrationality and fanaticism. Given such views, why would U.S. leaders expend the political capital to test diplomacy? Such widespread perceptions of Iran illuminate why Trump could move the United States toward war in January and February with so little domestic debate or significant push-back even from Democratic leaders.

Unfortunately, it's precisely this political climate that helps explain why diplomacy has often fallen short. Multiple U.S. presidents were tempted by the possibility of striking a diplomatic opening with Iran, a "Nixon goes to China" moment. But that moment never came, not only because of Iran's hostile posture toward the United States and militant policies that undermined diplomacy but also because Washington's own domestic constraints limited the space for testing openings. The domestic toxicity associated with Iran began with the hostage crisis and the Carter administration's failed rescue attempt but deepened after the exposure of the Iran-Contra scandal in Reagan's second term. The political fallout of the scandal cast a shadow over future dealings with Iran.

The Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), the 2015 nuclear deal agreed under President Barack Obama, went furthest in breaking the mold in U.S.-Iran relations. But that agreement, which was so contested within the U.S. political system that some referred to it

as the "Obamacare" of U.S. foreign policy, did not succeed in setting relations on a new footing. Even Democrats who supported the deal felt the need to keep up a "tough on Iran" posture, supporting continued pressure on Iran that ultimately limited the sanctions relief benefits Iranians had been expecting.

Trump's approach to Iran in his first term did not substantially depart from long-standing U.S. positions. To be sure, his exit from the JCPOA to fulfill his campaign promise to leave what he called the "worst deal ever"—against even the advice of some of his own advisors—was a disruptive decision that triggered the beginning of the end of a diplomatic resolution to Iran's nuclear program. His "maximum pressure" policies went further than his predecessors' in curtailing Iran's ability to export oil due to stringent enforcement of secondary sanctions. Yet Trump, like his predecessors, was enamored with the idea that he could strike a deal with Iran. His motivations may have been more personal and political than previous U.S. presidents, with him constantly suggesting he could strike a "better" deal than Obama. But in the end, his interest in a deal resulted in no more than talk of talks and the reality of an advancing Iranian nuclear program.

Trump did cross the first red line in the U.S. confrontation with Iran with the 2020 killing of Qassem Soleimani, the commander of Iran's elite Quds Force, though it's notable that the strike was conducted while Soleimani was in Iraq, not on Iranian soil. In that sense, Trump's first-term policies largely resembled the reluctance of previous administrations to attack Iranian territory directly, continuing a well-established mix of containment and military deterrence measures. In other words, the more transformative goals of either regime change or raprochement were not in the cards.

President Joe Biden similarly continued long-standing U.S. containment

policies, despite expectations early in his presidency that he would reverse Trump's withdrawal from the JCPOA. Domestic priorities overshadowed resetting diplomacy with Iran, and when U.S. officials did turn to negotiations, they held unrealistic expectations about how much leverage they held to push a new deal forward on better terms, particularly when facing a harder-line Iranian president after Iran's June 2021 elections. With the onset of Russia's war in Ukraine and the "Woman, Life, Freedom" protests in Iran, the political appetite for diplomacy only further diminished. The Israel-Hamas war also disrupted limited U.S.-Iran de-escalation talks and moved the United States and Iran into direct confrontation with the tit-for-tat Israeli-Iranian missile attacks in April and October 2024. However, the U.S. involvement in those exchanges was limited to the defense of Israel; the Biden administration was not interested in launching an offensive war against Iran.

All that changed with the second Trump administration. Instead of restoring factory settings in U.S. Iran policy, Trump broke precedent when he joined Israel in attacking Iranian nuclear sites first in June 2025 and then in the joint U.S.-Israeli attack on Iran on Feb. 28, triggering the recent war with open-ended and ill-defined goals. With the killing of Iranian Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and top Iranian officials in the first salvo of the war, along with Trump's own early messaging, regime change was for the first time explicit U.S. policy. Even the hawkish neo-conservatives in the George W. Bush administration declined to take on such an ambitious goal.

Trump has been trying to achieve what was previously deemed unattainable: the toppling of the Islamic Republic through external military intervention. He has repeatedly invoked the Venezuela model as a possible endgame with Iran—that is, a low-cost



war bringing about subservient leaders, whether or not they are democratic. But it is clear that this model will not work with a country like Iran, with a far more entrenched leadership and military forces committed to the regime's survival and no unified opposition ready to replace it. All that is certain is that Trump has fundamentally broken with long-standing U.S. avoidance of war with Iran.

Every U.S. president would have liked to see the demise of the Islamic Republic, but there is a reason no previous president authorized a war against Iran, certainly not a war that would be read in Tehran as an attempt to bring down the regime. If the Iranian people could topple their own government, that would be another story. But there is wide consensus—among previous U.S. officials and the expert community—that overthrowing a regime through external military force, and certainly by airpower alone, is unlikely to work and risks unleashing dangerous consequences.

The risks were well known and have been written about and discussed for decades. More hard-line leadership could rise to power. Regime collapse could lead to civil strife and armed conflict that would spill over Iran's borders. Iran's retaliation could threaten the entire region and disrupt global oil supplies. The escalation could lead to humanitarian disaster, and U.S. adversaries could benefit from the turmoil. But Trump and his senior advisors chose to ignore these risks, believing that Iran was a paper tiger, weakened and disoriented after Israel's relentless assault on Tehran and its partners since Hamas's Oct. 7, 2023, attack. Iran's unprecedented popular protests calling for the end of the regime, and its brutal slaughter of the protesters, were read as further evidence that the Iranian regime was on the ropes, only needing a push from the outside to achieve a knockout punch.

The high costs of Trump's war,

unpopular among the U.S. public and creating resentment across the region and globally, indicate dangerous overreach. Trump may find himself back where previous presidents did—learning to live with and mitigate the negative impacts of a conflictual relationship with a difficult country, probably now even more dangerous if its current leaders survive. Tragically, reaching either a rapprochement or a decisive end to an adversarial regime seems as unattainable as ever. ■

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## Beijing's Malacca Dilemma, After Hormuz

By Chee Meng Tan

**B**lockading the Strait of Hormuz, the narrow exit from the Persian Gulf that normally carries a fifth of the world's oil and natural gas, was not just a physical act but also a financial one. War risk premiums for ships transiting the strait soared

overnight as private insurers repriced coverage beyond what any shipping company could absorb or refused to write it at all.

China was among the nations caught in the squeeze, despite years of courting Iran and receiving guarantees that Chinese ships would be allowed through in the event of a blockade. Roughly half of China's oil imports come from the Middle East. If Beijing cannot keep its oil flowing when a friendly power controls a critical choke point, then what happens when an adversary, such as the United States, controls the next one?

That question should haunt Chinese President Xi Jinping. China has built the world's largest fleet of electric vehicles, solar panels, and wind turbines. But its factories, trucks, ships, and fighter jets still run on oil. Roughly 11 million of the 15 million to 16 million barrels that it burns per day travel by sea through waters that Beijing does not control.

Although nearly 40 percent transits the Strait of Hormuz, that is not the choke point that matters most. That distinction goes to the Strait of Malacca, the long, narrow sea-lane co-managed by Malaysia, Indonesia, and Singapore. Its narrowest stretch, the Phillips Channel, is less than 3 kilometers wide. (Hormuz's narrowest navigable channel is about 4 kilometers.) Some 23.2 million oil barrels cross Malacca every day, even more than Hormuz. About 80 percent of China's oil imports pass through Malacca via tanker.

Beijing has long seen China's heavy dependency on Malacca as a vulnerability. In 2003, then-President Hu Jintao warned of the "Malacca dilemma": the concern that any hostile power controlling the strait could hold China's energy supply hostage. Hu feared a physical blockade where Chinese tankers were turned back by force. The Iran crisis revealed something more insidious: In a conflict over Taiwan, China's petroleum pathways could be shut without a naval blockade at all.

The Iran war made brutally clear

that shipping runs on insurance; without cover, ships stay in port. When fighting began, war risk premiums for ships transiting Hormuz jumped from about 0.25 percent of hull value to between 3 and 10 percent. Even at the lower end of that range, the insurance premium for an average-size \$250 million tanker exploded from \$625,000 to \$7.5 million per voyage, making transit commercially unviable.

What stopped traffic was, in effect, a new high risk designation from Lloyd's Market Association's Joint War Committee (JWC), a panel of Western underwriters whose guidance the global market, including China's own maritime insurers, routinely follows.

Besides the lack of Chinese representation on the panel, what troubles Beijing is how far the JWC's reach extends. When the Iran war began, a single circular added Bahrain, Kuwait, and Oman to its list of perilous areas—and also Djibouti, where no shots were fired, because it sits on the Bab el-Mandeb, which Iran's Houthi allies threatened to close. Just the threat of an attack was enough to send premiums there soaring twentyfold.

Apply that to a Taiwan crisis. All that would be required to threaten Malacca's viability is a persuasive case that the conflict could spill into the South China

Sea and from there into Asia's main oil corridor.

To China's detriment, the bar for Malacca to appear on the JWC's list may not be that high. In 2005, the JWC added the strait to its war risk list based on a disputed, later discredited report about terrorism threats to regional shipping. Yet premiums still rose to 0.4 percent of hull and machinery value for more than a year. Against this precedent, it is easy to imagine the committee treating a war over Taiwan as a direct threat to Malacca. The signing in April of a major defense pact between Jakarta and Washington, which expands U.S. access to Indonesian waters and airspace, only raises the likelihood that the strait would be swept into any conflict over Taiwan.

Beijing is trying to bypass the Malacca dilemma. It has a strategic stockpile of nearly 1.4 billion barrels of oil. It has built overland alternatives—oil pipelines from Myanmar, Kazakhstan, and Russia—with a combined capacity of roughly 1.5 million barrels per day, though hardly comparable to the 7.9 million barrels flowing through the strait to China daily. And it can also reroute tankers through the Sunda or Lombok Strait, bypassing Malacca entirely.

Those workarounds could help avoid a Malacca-specific meltdown, but they

fail to address an even larger, if under-acknowledged, threat to China's oil security. War destination premiums follow a ship to its port of call, not the waters that it transits.

The Ukraine war sets a precedent for how to block oil bound for China, no matter the route that it takes. The JWC added some Russian and Ukrainian waters, including the Black Sea, to the high-risk list nine days before the full-scale Russian invasion began in 2022. By that April, it had listed all Russian territorial waters, including every Russian port. War risk premiums for Russian Black Sea ports peaked at 1-1.2 percent.

If China invaded Taiwan, its major oil terminals in Ningbo, Shanghai, and Qingdao could face the same insurance logic. War risk premiums on a \$300 million tanker could jump from a peacetime baseline of \$150,000 a year to \$3 million, following the Ukraine precedent of 1 percent of hull value.

One obvious response would be for China to build its own war risk insurance capacity to bypass Lloyd's entirely. That's why Beijing is expanding the China P&I Club, a state-backed maritime liability insurer, and supporting the launch of a dedicated Hong Kong war risk pool to cover Chinese vessels in the Gulf.

But the scale of these efforts is not large enough to matter yet. When the Iran war began, Hong Kong's entire war risk pool, backed by five insurers, covered only 10 ships with an underwriting capacity of 1 billion Hong Kong dollars (about \$130 million) per policy. That could not fully cover the hull value of a single modern oil tanker, which costs between \$200 million and \$300 million to replace.

That leaves China's shadow fleet, believed to include some 1,300 aging tankers flying flags of convenience and insured outside the Lloyd's system. Adept at mid-ocean ship-to-ship transfers that disguise cargo origins, this fleet is the primary channel through



Cargo ships anchor off the coast of Singapore just southeast of the Strait of Malacca on April 7, 2025.

MOHD RASFAN/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

which Russian, Iranian, and Venezuelan crude reaches Chinese refineries. In 2025, it carried an estimated 22 percent of China's total oil imports. In a Taiwan conflict, Beijing would almost certainly try to scale it up.

But the shadow fleet is not a solution as much as a vulnerability with extra steps. Washington is picking apart the inspectors, brokers, flag registries, and banks that keep sanctioned tankers moving. In May 2025, the United States sanctioned CCIC Singapore, a Beijing-linked inspection firm caught falsifying paperwork to disguise Iranian oil bound for Chinese refineries; local banks froze its accounts within days.

In peacetime, China's state oil majors have often protected their global operations rather than chased discounted barrels. When Washington sanctioned Rosneft and Lukoil in October 2025, Chinese oil companies Sinopec, CNOOC, and PetroChina halted seaborne Russian crude within weeks, wary of being sanctioned themselves. A U.S. designation does not just stop one cargo; it signals to banks, insurers, and traders that continued business could cost them access to the dollar-based clearing system.

In the case of war, Beijing could order its oil giants to ignore those warnings and keep taking sanctioned cargo, but that would likely earn those firms U.S. sanctions themselves. This would make even routine imports from non-sanctioned suppliers, such as Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, harder to finance and insure because major banks, shipowners, and insurers would risk violating sanctions by dealing with them.

That would force Beijing to lean harder on the shadow fleet, a work-around that only functions if foreign shipowners, brokers, and banks are still willing to move those barrels under sustained sanctions pressure. Washington is betting that few will.

China has built the world's most ambitious green economy while

remaining hostage to an old geopolitical vulnerability: the need to move oil across water that someone else controls. Hu worried about warships blocking tankers. What should worry Xi is a Western spreadsheet repricing the risk of moving oil to China at all. ■

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## Chinese Hegemony Might Be Happening

By Stephen M. Walt

**C**ould China become a hegemon in Asia? Back in 2023, I wrote a column arguing that fears of Chinese regional hegemony were overstated, though not entirely fanciful. A longer version of that argument was subsequently published in the Spring 2025 issue of *International Security*. I argued that not only had most modern bids for regional hegemony failed (the United States being the sole exception due to some unusually favorable circumstances) but the prospects for a strong balancing coalition in Asia were good. Most of China's neighbors did not want it to dominate the region, and neither did the United States. Given the propensity of major powers to balance threats, I concluded that an overt Chinese bid for hegemony was likely to fail and that Beijing would be unwise to attempt it.

I still find the logic of this argument convincing, but I gave insufficient weight to the possibility that U.S.

President Donald Trump would be as impulsive, misguided, and incompetent a steward of foreign policy as he has proved to be, including at his summit with Chinese President Xi Jinping in May. I assumed that the presence of vocal China hawks such as Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Undersecretary of Defense for Policy Elbridge Colby, aided by a bipartisan consensus on Capitol Hill, would keep U.S. power sufficiently focused on helping the United States' Asian allies keep China in check.

Instead, since 2025, Trump has done just about everything someone would do if he consciously wanted China to supplant the United States and establish a dominant position in its immediate region. He has gone after the pillars of the U.S. scientific establishment: cutting National Science Foundation funding, purging its advisory board, dismissing experienced scientists in dozens of government agencies, and waging a destructive war against the United States' leading universities. In an era where scientific prowess is the key to economic productivity and military power, this is an act of unilateral disarmament, at a moment when China is doing the exact opposite.

Relatedly, Trump has conceded to China the commanding heights of emerging green technologies—solar and wind power, advanced batteries, electric vehicles, etc.—while doubling down on 20th-century technologies: fossil fuels and the internal combustion engine. It's mind-boggling: As data centers proliferate and human existence requires ever-larger amounts of electricity, his administration is spending tax dollars to prevent wind farms from being built. The world is being reminded daily that it needs to reduce fossil fuel use and rely more on clean electric power, and Trump is doing everything he can to ensure that China—not the United States—owns that future.

Third, he imposed a poorly designed



and seemingly random set of tariffs on China (and others), only to back off when Beijing cut off exports of the refined rare-earth minerals on which many advanced technologies (such as the laptop on which I'm writing this) depend. Turns out his tariffs were also illegal, which made them even less likely to achieve any of the goals he claimed they'd bring (such as bringing manufacturing jobs back to the United States).

Even worse, he used the tariff bludgeon to bully some of the United States' most important partners in Asia, forcing them to pledge to invest in the U.S. economy whether they wanted to or not. Apart from generating resentment, damaging allies' economies makes it harder for them to spend more on defense, something the United States has long wanted them to do. Trump and his team are also doing little to nurture warmer ties with Asian countries: Trump indulged in a pointless spat with Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi last year, and there are currently no serving U.S. ambassadors in Australia, Cambodia, Fiji, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, the Marshall Islands, Papua New Guinea, Samoa, the Solomon Islands, or Vietnam. Most of these posts don't even have anyone nominated.

Trump and Rubio have also pulled the United States out of dozens of international organizations—another arena where China is increasingly active and effective—which means Washington won't be in the room when the rules and institutions that shape various aspects of international intercourse get written. I know, I know: Some international institutions aren't that important, and powerful states can flout them when they wish, but a decreasing diplomatic presence at these forums signals to the rest of the world that the United States isn't interested in working with others. It also means that in the years ahead, U.S. businesses are going to have to navigate global regulatory environments whose

rules were written by others. Even a country as powerful as the United States may find this awkward and inefficient.

And then there's the war with Iran. For starters, the conflict is a giant distraction, burning up Trump's limited attention span as well as the time and energy of his advisors. How do you formulate an effective strategy for Asia when you and your team are busy trying to figure out some way to get the Strait of Hormuz open? Trump is the fourth U.S. president who took office vowing to focus on China's rising power in Asia, and like all his predecessors, he ended up in a quagmire in the Middle East instead. And like George W. Bush in 2003, he has no one to blame but himself (and maybe Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu).

The war has also undermined the U.S. military posture in Asia, raising legitimate questions about how effectively the United States could respond if trouble were to erupt there. The U.S. Navy has three aircraft carrier battle groups in the Middle East and only one in East Asia right now, and those carriers in the Gulf have been on station for months and will need some port time when this is all over. The Defense Department has been using up Tomahawks, Patriot missiles, and

other advanced systems at a rapid rate, leaving U.S. allies in Asia less protected. I don't think China or North Korea is about to take advantage of this situation, but it can't be making U.S. allies in Asia very happy.

Moreover, the entire way the war was "planned" (if that word even applies) and executed must be giving longtime allies considerable pause. None of them were consulted in advance, and no one in the Trump administration seems to have given the slightest thought to how attacking Iran again might affect U.S. partners around the world. The effects have been severe: Gas prices are up sharply in the Philippines, Japan, South Korea, and elsewhere, and overall growth forecasts have been lowered. Add to that the economic and human consequences of fertilizer shortages and reduced crop yields due to the war, and you have a recipe for real anger at the cavalier way that Washington went to war.

To repeat a point I've made in the past: The Trump administration's shambolic handling of the war can only raise serious doubts about U.S. judgment and competence. In world politics, influence and credibility stem in part from strength, shared interests, and shows of resolve, but they also depend on others' confidence that a country's leaders have some idea of what they are doing. Given the administration's performance so far, should any U.S. allies in Asia (or anywhere else, for that matter) take their advice or believe any pledge they might make? Meanwhile, China gets to portray itself as a benign power (it isn't, really) or at least one that isn't in the business of bombing foreign countries, assassinating their leaders, or sending the world economy into a tailspin. A Gallup poll recently reported that China is now more popular around the world than the United States, a remarkable development that ought to worry all of us.

All of which makes me wonder if I was too sanguine about the stability of



U.S. President Donald Trump gestures to Chinese President Xi Jinping during a visit to the gardens at Zhongnanhai in Beijing on May 15.

the United States' Asian alliances and the prospects for preventing Chinese dominance there. Although there are powerful structural reasons why a coalition to balance China should be pretty durable, it could still fail if key alliance members—and especially the putative alliance leader—are sufficiently inept. Although most Asian countries do not want to distance themselves from the United States and accommodate China, the possibility may not be as remote as I once believed. The United States' recent blunders are the main reason.

I'm reluctant to say all this because defeatism can be self-fulfilling and I don't want to imply that the jig is up and Chinese dominance is likely. Even now, I would much rather play the U.S. hand than the one that China has been dealt because Washington still holds more high cards than Beijing does. But I wish that hand was being played by someone who understood the rules of the game and knew what each card was worth. ■

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## China Doesn't Want Spheres of Influence

*By Aaron Glasserman*

**I**n recent months, a growing consensus has emerged that the liberal international order is being replaced by a club of great powers, each entitled to supremacy over its own sphere of influence. In this view, as the Trump administration asserts U.S. control over the Americas, it appears content to stand by as

Russia pushes westward into Europe and as China extends its influence across Asia and the Pacific.

Like the United States and Russia, China wants to increase its power and decrease that of its competitors, and it has concerns about foreign powers acting within or around its territory. However, it is a mistake to think that China shares these states' desires or would even tolerate a world divided into spheres.

Such a view overstates and understates the scope of Beijing's interests, which are primarily economic rather than militaristic and global rather than regional. Worse, the assumption makes it harder to recognize a potentially destabilizing source of risk: attempts to exclude China from the global economy.

Officially, Beijing has rejected "blocs" and "hegemony" for decades. Although Mao Zedong initially positioned China as a member of Soviet camp during the Cold War, rising tensions with Moscow and the geopolitical benefits of engaging with nonaligned countries—and later, the United States—shifted China's foreign policy toward flexibility and opportunism. As China's reach has grown, so has its insistence that great powers should not carve up the world into spheres. Of course, official rhetoric cannot be taken at face value—China has supported Russia's invasion of Ukraine, for example—but neither can it be dismissed, especially when Chinese strategy documents do not depict spheres of influence as legitimate or desirable.

Those who argue that China welcomes a world divided into spheres often point to Beijing's aggression toward Taiwan. Indeed, China routinely engages in intelligence operations, military exercises, gray-zone tactics, and cyberwarfare toward Taiwan, and it has punished countries that defy Beijing's interpretation of the "One China" policy. But Beijing regards Taiwan—and the South China

Sea and East China Sea—as matters of sovereignty, not as part of its sphere of influence, and condemns the "internationalization" of these issues.

The key issue is whether China extends this monopolistic logic to neighbors whose sovereignty it recognizes. Evidence suggests that it does not. Afghanistan, for instance, could be an excellent candidate for Chinese vassalage: weak, politically fragmented, rich in strategic resources, and bordering China. It also bears directly on Chinese domestic security because of the presence of Chinese-designated Uyghur terrorists as well as the Islamic State-Khorasan, which has killed multiple Chinese nationals in recent years.

Nevertheless, Beijing has been cautious. It has withheld economic investment rather than taken direct military action, even expressing concern about the consequences of the U.S. withdrawal for regional security. Beijing was mostly happy to have Washington take the lead in providing security and fighting terrorism there—hardly the behavior that we would expect from a government seeking a sphere of influence.

A similar pattern appears in continental Southeast Asia, where China is the largest trading partner, an aggressive party to territorial disputes, and a key player in regional diplomacy, security provision, and military cooperation.

Yet even here, China has accepted hedging rather than demanded exclusive alignment. Apart from its 1979 invasion of Vietnam, China has not invaded or overthrown rival-aligned regimes in Southeast Asia as the United States has done in Latin America and Russia has done in Eastern Europe. Even as Beijing publicly protests Thai-U.S. military cooperation, it quietly benefits from it because it makes Thailand and its access to the Indian Ocean more stable and secure.

In response to Washington's inroads in Vietnam, Beijing has strengthened

bilateral ties with Hanoi rather than resorted to punishment. China certainly does not welcome foreign influence, but it has not shown a willingness to bear the costs required to exclude rival powers from its neighborhood. It might accept a sphere of influence for free, but it doesn't want to pay for one.

Projecting a desire for spheres of influence onto China also underestimates the scope of its interests and influence farther afield. China trumpets itself as a global power. It has invested heavily in its ability to shape established international organizations and created a new generation of China-centered international forums and global initiatives. Beijing's recent claims to leadership in the global south are also quite telling: This vague and geographically flexible category is useful precisely because it enables China to expand its ties with developing countries around the world.

Chinese leaders see integration with and influence over the international system as indispensable to their country's development and their regime's legitimacy. China needs to export vast quantities of products around the world to sustain economic growth, and it has invested huge sums to develop foreign markets that can consume what Chinese consumers cannot.

Its impressive domestic production notwithstanding, China is also a net importer of food and hydrocarbons and has diversified its supply chains to shore up its energy and food security—meaning that it needs influence in different regions, not just in its own backyard.

In short, China would not accept a world divided into spheres of influence because global economic integration is its core strategy for survival.

Today, geopolitical risk cannot be mitigated by drawing lines on a map because the two strongest players—the United States and China—both operate on a genuinely global scale: in the interests they pursue, the strategies

by which they pursue them, and the weapons that they deploy when those strategies are frustrated.

While the U.S. approach to power has been clear for decades, China's arsenal is newer and more limited. China is viewed more unfavorably than favorably, particularly in developed countries and the Asia-Pacific region, and it has struggled to cultivate enduring soft power. Formidable efforts at military modernization still have not given Beijing anything close to Washington's reach, though its diplomatic capital has improved in light of the Trump administration's unpredictability.

Where China has a powerful, recently tested weapon with global reach is in the economic realm: its control over refined critical minerals. Beijing made a show of this last October, when it announced sweeping export controls on certain rare earths, forcing the Trump administration to the negotiating table. Beijing's actions were interpreted as a sign that China was now a peer competitor with the United States, able and willing to act on a global scale—not through military action but through supply chain dominance.

These export controls defied the logic of spheres of influence, both in the extent of their impact and in what motivated them in the first place. This

demonstration was diplomatically costly for China, which had previously cultivated an image as a responsible defender of free trade. Rather than a “global supply chain power grab,” as U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer characterized the measures, they were a calculated response to a specific U.S. action.

It wasn't because the United States was threatening China's neighborhood; it was because the United States was jeopardizing China's global interests. The weeks prior saw two developments that deeply concerned Beijing.

First, the U.S. Commerce Department announced an expansion of its Entity List to include subsidiaries of Chinese parent companies, massively increasing the number of firms blocked from accessing advanced semiconductors. From Beijing's point of view, this was a major escalation in Washington's so-called “technological containment” of China.

Second, in what was widely understood to be a response to this new compliance risk, the Dutch government seized control of the semiconductor manufacturer Nexperia. The company is based in the Netherlands but has been owned since 2018 by a Chinese firm partially backed by Chinese state-owned enterprises. Beijing lodged a formal protest with the Netherlands,



Visitors walk across a world map carved in stone, with China highlighted in dark red, in the Chinese municipality of Chongqing on May 19, 2010.



condemning, among other things, alleged “coercion”—implicitly, by the United States. Not long after, Beijing announced the sweeping new export controls.

The Nexperia affair demonstrates the sort of action that can trigger a globally devastating Chinese response. In contrast to Russia, which has resorted to wars of conquest when it feels threatened by NATO and pro-Western governments on its borders, China hasn’t sought to push the United States out of Japan, the Philippines, South Korea, or Thailand—or Russia out of Kazakhstan, Mongolia, or North Korea, for that matter. Rather, China struck back when it believed that the United States was enlisting countries against it in a global trade war and technological competition.

Those who hope that a world divided into spheres will bring stability are likely to be disappointed. Both the United States and China see the ability to pursue their global interests as central to their self-image and economic security. China has shown itself to be far less willing than the United States to use military force abroad, but it is equally willing to weaponize its economic power when its global economic integration is threatened.

This is worrying because for all U.S. President Donald Trump’s talk of deal-making, his administration has repeatedly attempted to exclude China from key nodes of the global economy and enlist third countries in these efforts, whether in the Netherlands, Panama, Peru, or Syria. Beijing has made it clear how it will respond to such exclusion: massive escalation of export controls and restrictions on strategic supply chains. The result, then, may not be a new global order but a more fragmented and unpredictable one. ■

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## China Is Winning the Global AI Race

By *Agathe Demarais*

**T**hese days, which artificial intelligence model is the most popular? Ask anyone in the United States or Europe, and you’ll probably hear about the respective merits of OpenAI’s ChatGPT, Anthropic’s Claude, or Google’s Gemini. All wrong. As of May, the most widely used AI in the world was one that few Westerners had ever heard of: Kimi K2.6, an open-source Chinese model that topped the OpenRouter leaderboard.

This ranking highlights how Western policymakers and CEOs could be fixating on the wrong race as they focus on semiconductor benchmarks and the question of which AI model is the most advanced. China, meanwhile, is quietly building something different: an ecosystem of open-source models that are both cheap and good enough for most use cases. By the time Western capitals notice, Chinese AI models may well have become global standards and prove hard to displace—even by more advanced technology.

The mainstream Western narrative is that U.S. export controls are preventing China from getting access to cutting-edge processor chips, slowing down the development of Chinese AI firms. This is true but eclipses a key part of the story: If Beijing’s AI pitch centers on universal access and cost-effectiveness, then Chinese AI firms do not need the latest chips to win the global AI race.

Take Kimi K2.6, the open-source flagship model of Beijing-based Moonshot

AI. On industry benchmarks, the model sits within touching distance of cutting-edge Western ones such as Anthropic’s Claude Opus 4.7 and OpenAI’s GPT-5.5. On price, it is in a different universe: Kimi costs roughly \$4 per million output tokens, about six to eight times cheaper than Opus 4.7 and GPT-5.5. (A token is a unit measuring the input and output of AI models.) For a casual user, this cost difference may not matter much. For a company running hundreds of AI agents, it can be decisive.

Kimi is not an outlier. While the Moonshot model tops the charts for usage through an interface, another Chinese model, Alibaba’s Qwen, is fast becoming the default ecosystem for self-hosted AI models. Two data points help illustrate this. First, by March, Qwen had captured more than 50 percent of global open-source model downloads, having overtaken its biggest Western competitor, Meta’s Llama, in late 2025. Second, Qwen has been downloaded around 1 billion times. Interest in Qwen is not confined to cost-minded firms. Last November, the Singaporean government announced that it would ditch Llama and build its sovereign AI model with Qwen instead.

With its open-source AI strategy, Beijing is revamping the logic of its Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)—but with a twist. BRI entailed Chinese firms delivering fully financed infrastructure projects in a bid to lock third countries into China’s orbit. The rollout of Chinese open-source AI models follows the same logic, but this time, the infrastructure is both invisible and free. The marginal cost of AI diffusion is near zero (the main costs—servers and the electricity to power them—are borne by the hosting country), which makes the AI rollout a far cheaper investment for Beijing than building ports, railways, or power plants. What’s more, BRI created highly visible, Chinese-owned infrastructure that sometimes proved unpopular. By contrast, AI dependency

is invisible to both policymakers and the population, limiting pushback.

China's AI bet is a long-term one with a clear end goal: ensuring that Chinese AI models become (and thus shape) global standards. The underlying logic is that a default AI tool could quickly become a de facto industry standard. Once developers and firms build on China-made architectures, they use Chinese technical assumptions and standards—thus giving Beijing long-term influence. It's part of a larger strategy; in its Standards 2035 blueprint, Beijing sets itself the goal of seeing Chinese products become global defaults in a bid to shape standards for next-generation technologies. As a precedent, China has been granting access to its Logink shipping software for free in recent years. The platform quickly became a household name in the shipping sector after being deployed in at least 86 ports across 24 countries.

The battle to set global AI standards will mostly be waged in the global south. Western economies are locked into U.S. models, while China runs on Chinese ones. The swing states are everywhere else, and three factors make Chinese models well-placed to make headway there. First, U.S.-made AI is too expensive for broad rollout in cost-sensitive developing economies. Second, U.S. models are typically trained with Western data, making them ill-suited to grasp local contexts in global south countries. By contrast, open-source Chinese models can be downloaded and fine-tuned with country-specific data. Exhibit A is AfriqueQwen-14B, a Qwen-based AI that was adapted to 20 African languages through training on African data. The flagship Western open-source model, Llama, offers only patchy coverage of global south languages.

Third, growing global resentment against the United States is reinforcing China's strategy. To make the most of this, Beijing does not even have to lift a finger. Washington frames global AI competition as a national security race

to be won against China, with no offerings to third countries needing cost-effective, good-enough tools.

The outcomes of two major AI summits for global south economies illustrate this point. Last April in Kigali, Rwanda, the Global AI Summit on Africa and resulting Africa Declaration on AI called for AI governance built around ethics, sustainability, and responsibility—something that would probably sound alien to Silicon Valley tech executives.

At the India AI Impact Summit in February, global south policymakers doubled down. New Delhi anchored the conference's agenda in a "People, Planet, and Progress" framework emphasizing social empowerment, development, and inclusion. As Amitabh Kant, India's former G-20 sherpa, put it on the sidelines of the conference: "We are providing more data to OpenAI than the U.S. Data from [the] global south is helping refine models. These will sell you high-cost products. So India needs to build models on its own data."

The obvious objection to this narrative—that global south countries could reject Chinese AI on security grounds—appears shaky. Global south governments did not reject Chinese ports, railways, or power plants on security grounds under BRI. With no cheap Western AI offerings on the horizon (U.S. AI firms are cash-strapped and thus unlikely to cut prices), there is even

less reason to expect a different pattern this time. Besides, the Chinese AI offer is harder to refuse. It helps that open-source models have no single vendor; they are distributed quietly through public websites, not via state-to-state contracts that can grab headlines.

Skeptics could also flag that Beijing's models come with Chinese Communist Party censorship baked in. Even when it is self-hosted, China's DeepSeek sometimes refuses to answer sensitive questions. But such censorship has been squarely aimed at China-sensitive topics such as Taiwan, Tiananmen, Tibet, and Xinjiang, making it mostly irrelevant to local needs in the global south. Yes, Beijing could always threaten to pull the plug on its AI models, for instance by tightening access to updates in countries pursuing relations with Taiwan. Yet as Washington has become erratic and unpredictable under U.S. President Donald Trump, global south leaders have plenty of reason to think that relying on Chinese AI could be safer in the long term than dependency on U.S. technology.

The real AI competition may not be a hardware arms race won by access to the most cutting-edge chips. Instead, the global AI race may well be a contest to decide which models and standards become the default infrastructure in countries that remain up for grabs. China does not need to dominate the most advanced models to win the AI



A poster depicts humanoid robots at the International AI Application and Robotics Innovation Exhibition in Beijing on March 18.

race. If Chinese models become the affordable, good-enough default across emerging markets, Beijing will have built durable influence for decades.

Instead of fixating on the AI horse race between ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini, Western policymakers may want to ponder how they can make an AI offer of their own to the global south before the defaults are set. Meanwhile, developers across Asia, Africa, and Latin America will continue to fine-tune their Kimi, Qwen, and DeepSeek agents. ■

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## How to Rebuild Hungarian Democracy

By David Koranyi

When Peter Magyar defeated Prime Minister Viktor Orban in Hungary's April election, he inherited something unprecedented in modern European history: a constitutional supermajority and a mandate to dismantle a competitive authoritarian system 16 years in the making. The scale of Magyar's electoral victory—winning 141 of 199 parliamentary seats with a 79.5 percent turnout—was extraordinary, but it was only the opening act. The question that will define Hungary's next parliamentary term, and resonate far beyond its borders, is one political scientists have barely begun to answer: How do you rebuild a democracy from within the ruins of one hollowed out by design?

The scale of illiberal inheritance is vast. Orban rebuilt the state around a single party, entrenching Fidesz's power by replacing the country's 1949 constitution with the 2011 Fundamental Law. The judiciary was systematically captured through packed courts and an untouchable prosecutor general. Public media became a state-controlled propaganda apparatus, reinforced by the surveillance of journalists, civil servants, and opposition figures. Civil society faced legal constraints and regulatory harassment, while Central European University was forced to relocate to Vienna. State contracts were funneled to regime-allied oligarchs, and the bureaucracy, diplomatic corps, and intelligence services were hollowed out through purges of career professionals and the installation of party loyalists.

Magyar's supermajority gives him the constitutional power to undo all of this. The electoral system engineered by Orban to entrench his own rule has now been turned against him; the same mechanism that supercharged Fidesz's slim pluralities into supermajorities has handed Magyar the tools to dismantle the entire edifice. But there are numerous traps ahead, and how the

prime minister navigates them will determine whether Hungary's transition produces durable democratic institutions or merely replaces one form of majoritarian excess with another.

Magyar's government must resist the temptation of speed without process in three critical areas: judicial reconstitution, public media governance, and anti-corruption enforcement. Meanwhile, the European Union must unfreeze Hungary's funds to assist with the transition—but only once institutional milestones are verified.

The central challenge for Magyar's administration is to find the balance between speed and legitimacy. The new government must act quickly and decisively, using the momentum of the revolutionary moment before it fades. But speed creates its own risks: After taking power in 2023, Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk's government moved to dismantle the previous Law and Justice (PiS) party's control over public media, leading critics—including some sympathetic to the democratic project—to accuse him of replicating PiS's methods, creating a legitimacy deficit that Tusk is still managing today. Magyar must learn from this: Every institutional reform must be anchored in a transparent process.

This is especially true for the judiciary, to which Orban appointed loyalists with long-term mandates. Magyar has called on these officials to resign. For those who refuse, the temptation will be to legislate their immediate removal. But any process that looks like a political purge will be weaponized by Fidesz, challenged in European courts, and cited by illiberal governments as proof that "the other side does it, too." Instead, Magyar's government must establish a transparent, consistently applied appointment process grounded in Council of Europe standards and accept that full reconstitution may take years. Judges who enabled institutional abuse should be held accountable, but those who



served honorably should not be subject to blanket purges based solely on their appointment under Orbán. Hungary must demonstrate that the rule of law it seeks to restore applies equally to the restoration process itself.

Another task for Magyar's government is to restore the independence of public media. Hungary's state broadcaster, MTVA, was structurally designed as a government instrument under Orbán, with Fidesz controlling roughly 80 percent of Hungary's media resources. In 2018, the Central European Press and Media Foundation (KESMA) consolidated hundreds of private television, radio, and wire services into one conglomerate. Led by a board of regime loyalists, KESMA produced content indistinguishable from Fidesz campaign material and routinely aired stories subsequently ruled defamatory by courts.

Here, Magyar must innovate. Simply replacing the KESMA board would replicate the problem with different beneficiaries; instead, Hungary needs an entirely new governance model. Germany's public broadcasting councils, which include representatives from civil society, trade unions, and cultural institutions alongside political appointees, offer one possibility; the BBC's former trust structure, which separated editorial decisions from government and commercial pressures, is another. While neither model maps perfectly onto Hungary, the principle is clear: Public media governance must be designed for perpetuity, not optimized for the current regime. Meanwhile, investigations into whether the original consolidation of independent media companies violated EU state aid rules can begin.

Finally, Magyar's government must confront corruption, the organizing principle of Orbán's system. For 16 years, public procurement was weaponized to enrich a small circle of regime-allied oligarchs, while billions in EU funds were diverted through rigged tenders. The

regime's beneficiaries still control vast economic resources and will use them to sabotage the transition. Oligarchs who owe their fortunes to Fidesz have every incentive to fund obstruction, bankroll Orbán's comeback, and spotlight any prosecutorial overreach as evidence of political vengeance.

Magyar has already announced the creation of a National Asset Recovery and Protection Office tasked with reviewing questionable real estate transactions, examining lucrative concession deals, and retroactively auditing major public procurements. He has also pledged to join the European Public Prosecutor's Office (EPPO), the EU body that investigates fraud involving European funds. Membership would embed independent European prosecutors within Hungary's legal system—precisely the level of oversight Orbán spent years blocking.

But prosecution alone will not unwind 16 years of systemic looting. Hungary should consider a time-limited, voluntary disclosure and asset recovery program offering amnesty in exchange for full public disclosure so that individuals and companies that voluntarily return illicitly obtained assets receive reduced penalties. Hungary must also reclaim public assets—media outlets, real estate, and infrastructure concessions—that were transferred to regime allies through legally dubious mechanisms by launch-

ing transparent competition law and state aid investigations.

The EU is well positioned to help Magyar's government with the transition, but it must be measured in its approach. Once again, Poland offers a cautionary tale: Within weeks of taking office, Tusk's government presented Brussels with a rule-of-law action plan, joined the EPPO, and fulfilled two "super milestones" on judicial independence, prompting the almost immediate release by the European Commission of 137 billion euros (about \$148 billion) in frozen recovery and cohesion funds.

But these funds were released based on political commitments rather than verified institutional change, and when PiS-backed candidate Karol Nawrocki won the presidential election in June 2025, many of the deeper judicial reforms Tusk had pledged remained unfinished and threatened by the new president's veto power. The early release of Brussels's primary leverage left the EU with fewer tools to support Tusk's reform agenda when he needed them most. Now, the approximately 32 billion euros (about \$37 billion) at stake for Hungary in recovery funds, cohesion money, and defense loans represents roughly 15 percent of its GDP, an enormous incentive. Used wisely, that leverage has the potential to sustain reform momentum—but the August deadline for unlocking EU recovery funds is swiftly approaching.



Prime Minister-elect Peter Magyar holds a news conference in Budapest on April 13, following his victory in Hungary's parliamentary election.

Given that legitimacy must temper speed, how long will all of this take? Poland has not completed its democratic restoration process after almost three years, despite a shorter and less entrenched capture than Fidesz's. For Hungary, full judicial reconstitution will take years; rewiring the information ecosystem will take even longer. Sixteen years of institutional capture cannot be reversed in a single parliamentary term, but legal frameworks can make restoration irreversible: a new constitution shaped by civic participation, independent judicial appointment mechanisms, a politically insulated public media charter, and accountability structures without vengeance.

Civil society should be the guarantor of this process. Surviving independent organizations, investigative journalists, and civic movements must be watchdogs with the same intensity they brought to Orbán's regime. Democratic restoration fails when the forces that fought for it become co-opted by the government they helped elect. Hungary's civil society must hold the new majority accountable, insist that checks on executive power be restored, and resist the seductive assumption that having the "right" people in power means the work is done.

Hungary is attempting a feat rarely tried at this scale: the systematic, constitutional dismantling of a competitive authoritarian state from within, by democratic means, under democratic constraints. If it can avoid the traps along the long road ahead, it may offer the world something more valuable than a dramatic election night: a model for how democracies can confront illiberalism without abandoning the rule of law. ■

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## Europe Shrugs Off Trump's Threats

By Rachel Rizzo

Last year, when U.S. President Donald Trump reentered office, European leaders felt that familiar sense of dread. And indeed, Trump launched back into his first-term habit of harping on Europe for defense spending, trade imbalances, and more. Vice President J.D. Vance turned the knife even deeper with a speech at the 2025 Munich Security Conference blaming Europe for its own demise as he went on about government impingement on free speech and uncontrolled immigration.

European leaders, for their part, initially responded to these provocations with a mix of panic, unease, and warnings that the trans-Atlantic relationship was doomed. But increasingly, Trump's threats against European countries—due to their refusal to go all-in on Washington's war with Iran—aren't eliciting the same response as before.

For example, Trump's plan, announced in May, to withdraw 5,000 of the roughly 36,000 U.S. troops in Germany was met with a shrug by German leaders. German Defense Minister Boris Pistorius said the decision was "foreseeable." Compare that with 2020, when the U.S. threat to withdraw 12,000 troops from Germany (admittedly, a higher number) caused a near-meltdown among European policymakers and analysts alike.

Even the threats to remove troops from Spain and Italy haven't landed with the same oomph. Italian Prime

Minister Giorgia Meloni said it was not a decision that she would support but didn't seem too alarmed about it, likely because she and the U.S. president have had a relatively strong relationship thus far. And Spanish Defense Minister Margarita Robles said in response that the European pillar of NATO must be strengthened and that Spain doesn't support illegal wars. That hardly sounds like panic.

Why does Europe suddenly seem so chill? Two things seem to be happening simultaneously. First, Trump's threats have begun to lose their shock value. Second, European leaders have actually started bolstering their own capabilities, meaning that, if nothing else, they have a plan if Trump makes good on his threats.

The first Trump administration was a real earthquake for the continent. European policymakers had spent decades operating inside the safe assumption that NATO was sacrosanct, that the United States had its own interests in keeping its high troop levels in Europe, and that the institutional foundations built since World War II would hold. During Trump's first term, Europeans started openly questioning those assumptions, while his second term has further confirmed their breakdown.

But after a decade, European leaders are now used to being on the receiving end of U.S. ire. After all this time, they certainly don't think Trump's threats are hollow, but they don't necessarily expect the worst anymore, either.

On the tariff and trade front, Trump's threats have certainly come to pass. The sweeping tariffs imposed on European goods in 2025, part of a broader global trade offensive, made clear that the administration was ready to hit Europe where it hurt. But on security and defense, Trump's threats haven't yet resulted in any meaningful reduction of the U.S. footprint in Europe, at least not yet. Various institutional mechanisms all work together to slow or stop the most dramatic moves. And



French President Emmanuel Macron delivers a speech during the Orion 26 military exercises in Suippes, France, on April 30.

today, instead of reacting with panic at every announcement, Europeans are sitting back to see what actually happens.

At the same time, to a degree not fully appreciated in Washington, Europe has actually launched a meaningful response to its ally's mercurial policy. The continent is now putting its money where its mouth is in the quest for strategic autonomy. This allows it to display a degree of flexibility and sangfroid not possible during Trump's first term.

Germany has abandoned years of fiscal restraint, suspending its constitutional debt brake to unlock hundreds of billions of euros in defense and infrastructure spending. France and the United Kingdom have deepened bilateral defense cooperation. The European Union launched its Readiness 2030 initiative, which commits 800 billion euros (about \$841 billion) toward defense capacity. Poland is now spending more than 4 percent of its GDP on defense, and the Nordic states—notably Finland and Sweden—have joined NATO, creating, with the Baltics, an arc of military coherence across Northern Europe.

None of this means that Europe is ready to go it alone. The continent is still highly dependent on U.S. strategic enablers such as intelligence and surveillance, logistics and airlift, and

nuclear deterrence, to name a few. The muted responses from European leaders don't necessarily come from a place of total confidence. Instead, they come from a place of exhaustion, a desire to avoid playing into Trump's hope of public panic, and a belief that the continent is already taking the key practical steps necessary to respond with clear actions rather than words. As a result, Europe's new strategy seems to be to acknowledge the threat, disagree with it, point to Europe's growth in capabilities, and then move on.

That said, there are moves that Trump could take that would still upend Europe's composure. If the United States started reconsidering its nuclear umbrella over Europe or openly stated that it wouldn't stand by its Article 5 commitments, those decisions would send shock waves that the continent couldn't easily absorb. Similarly, if the United States decided to begin a major troop drawdown in Europe, it would strain Europe's logistics and command structures to a point that would leave it dangerously exposed.

Here, the 2026 National Defense Authorization Act could provide some comfort. Among other guardrails it puts around U.S. military decisions in Europe, it requires the Defense Department to consult NATO allies and submit a report to Congress before

reducing troop levels on the continent below 76,000 for more than 45 days. Of course, this law does not offer an iron-clad guarantee against Trump's reckless impulses, but it could certainly help check them.

Ultimately, whether Europe can sustain its position of relative calm will depend on its ability to convert rhetorical resolve into lasting military power. It's one thing to shrug off threats to deny Trump the reaction he has been hoping for. It's quite another to shrug off threats because panic is no longer necessary and Europe has the military backbone to prove it. Europe is on the right track; it just needs to make sure it keeps going in the right direction. Time will tell how this strategy plays out. ■

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## ASIA & THE PACIFIC



# The World Needs Indian Diplomacy

By Shivshankar Menon

**L**ike most of Asia, India is adjusting to a disordered world, in which conflict is rising, international and particularly multinational institutions are increasingly



ineffective, and existing mechanisms for stability such as the international trading system and the nonproliferation regime are being dismantled. With some of the greatest powers displaying contempt for norms and international law, there is no longer a world order or even a pretense of one. An international system remains—international flights continue, and your cellphone will work around the world—but there are no rules or institutions or inhibitions that prevent powerful countries from attacking another, despite commitments in the United Nations Charter and elsewhere.

The changes in the international system make much harder the fundamental task of Indian foreign and security policy, which is to enable the transformation of India into a modern, prosperous, and secure country. A disordered world is not likely to give India the peace, predictability, and security that its development needs. Yet these challenging circumstances also represent a chance to change what it does.

Rather than getting involved in others' quarrels or engaging in mediation, the greatest contribution that India can make at this time is to continue to manage its own development and security well. By working with its partners and neighbors, it should aim to provide stability in the subcontinent, the Indian Ocean littoral, and Southeast and West Asia. In addition, where circumstances permit, India should work to strengthen predictability and stability on international issues critical to its and others' future.

If this sounds selfish, it is not necessarily so because there is a clear coincidence of interest between India and most other countries in its extended neighborhood. Besides, none of us, no matter how powerful, can mitigate or profit from international disorder entirely on our own.

In some ways, India, with its tradition of strategic autonomy, is not badly placed to work the new international

environment. Now that the post-World War II institutional architecture is defunct, power has become much more evenly distributed. The two most powerful states, the United States and China, together account for less than 50 percent of world GDP and military power today. Amid this flatter distribution of power, there are gains to be had for non-status-quo powers that wish to improve, not overthrow, the present international system.

An absence of order, or world order, does not necessarily mean the absence of an international system but its fragmentation. The possibilities that open up in such a situation go beyond the opportunistic pursuit of individual agendas that we see all around us: Russia in Ukraine, Rwanda in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Israel and the United States in West Asia, China in the South China Sea, Azerbaijan in Nagorno-Karabakh and Armenia, and so on.

In the midst of disorder, each country will have to instead be much clearer in prioritizing its interests and concentrating on creating good outcomes rather than seeking narrative dominance, status, glory, revenge for history, or other such ephemeral goals.

For India, what this would mean in practice is the building and working of coalitions on issues that matter and

that will affect the lives of its people in the future. These issues include renewable energy, maritime security, and the international trading system. Those who are willing and able to contribute will vary from area to area. Such a variable geometry is essential when we cannot rely on the traditional multilateral system for solutions. It does not appear sensible to expect institutions composed of member states to be effective when those states are quarrelling with one another.

Excluding its western reaches, Asia has enjoyed peace for several decades. The result has been historically unprecedented economic development and growth in most of the region's economies, improving people's lives. But after the globalization era, not just political and territorial disputes and flash points within Asia but great-power rivalry and behavior beyond it threaten regional growth and peace.

Consider how the globalized trading system of which Asia was the greatest beneficiary has been ruptured due to U.S. President Donald Trump's unilateral tariffs. Consider, also, the manner in which the nonproliferation regime is unraveling in northeastern Asia, West Asia, and even in Europe. The waning credibility of U.S. extended deterrence; the experience of states such as Libya, Ukraine, and Iran, which gave up

German Chancellor Friedrich Merz (left) and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi attend a kite festival in Ahmedabad, India, on Jan. 12.



or lacked nuclear weapons or options; and the nuclear arms race among the greatest nuclear weapon states have led to opinions shifting in Scandinavia, South Korea, Japan, and other countries toward the prospect of acquiring or gaining access to nuclear weapons. There is a common interest among the nuclear weapon states—including India—in preventing further horizontal proliferation.

India has begun adjusting policy by attempting to mend difficult bilateral relations with China. Its government is also working with neighbors in the subcontinent to mitigate the disruption in energy, fertilizer, and other markets caused by the United States and Israel attacking Iran. Most of India's neighbors are going through complex social and political transformations, renegotiating their social and political contracts. India is and can be an island of stability and can help them manage these changes successfully and peacefully; improved connectivity and economic integration, for instance, would benefit the entire region.

If Asia is to continue to develop in peace, it is clear that it will have to find new ways of minimizing the harm that the rest of the world does to Asia's peace and security. We have seen the self-centered and erratic policies of major players in the international system for more than a decade now, as well as how badly they have affected the security and economic prospects of the world, particularly in Asia and Africa. There has not been a binding international agreement on an issue of significance for well over a decade. Diplomacy of the highest quality is more essential than ever. And this is where India, the Association of Southeast Asian Nations, and Asia generally, working across international fault lines and frontiers since the Cold War, can play a role. India's strategic autonomy has been an active choice.

Rather than neutrality, the disordered world demands the opposite: the application of mind to issues to

establish what is in India's enlightened and common international interest and to act accordingly. With its tradition of avoiding the constraints of blocs and alliances, India can work with other actors in the international system to build the plurilateral and bilateral links and agreements that are needed to continue the march of progress amid chaos. ■

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## Japan and China Are Dangerously Close to Conflict

By Deng Yuwen

**O**n April 17, the Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force destroyer *Ikazuchi* transited the Taiwan Strait. It was the second such passage by a Japanese warship in 10 months, yet Beijing's response was far harsher this time. Relations between

Beijing and Tokyo have degenerated sharply since Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi's comments last November that Japan could come to Taiwan's defense if China attacked.

China's Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Ministry of National Defense, and Eastern Theater Command all put out statements condemning Japan after the April transit, telling it to "step back from the brink" and warning it to "return from the wrong path," while Jun Zhengping, a People's Liberation Army-linked social media account, warned that Japan was playing with fire. At the same time, the Eastern Theater Command launched combat readiness patrols in the East China Sea and sent warships near Okinawa.

China does not intend to let Japan off lightly. It is using the incident to push the crisis one step further. If this continues, then the possibility of a limited air or naval clash within the next year or two, or even a small-scale exchange of fire, cannot be dismissed as alarmism.

Why did Beijing react so strongly to the *Ikazuchi* incident? One reason is the timing. April 17 is the anniversary of the Treaty of Shimonoseki, signed after Japan's victory in the first Sino-Japanese War—a date China regards as a symbol of national humiliation. Tokyo may well have been unaware of the symbolism of the date, but Beijing is unlikely to believe that.

But that is not enough to explain China's reaction. A more immediate backdrop is the unresolved anger over the incident in March when a Japan Ground Self-Defense Force junior officer broke into the Chinese Embassy in Tokyo, allegedly at one point carrying a knife. Beijing remains deeply dissatisfied with Tokyo's handling of that episode, believing Japan has neither adequately responded to China's anger and concerns nor offered an apology. With those feelings still raw, Japan then sent a warship through the Taiwan Strait. In Beijing's eyes, this was not an

isolated act but a direct provocation directed at Chinese security concerns and diplomatic dignity.

At a deeper level, however, what has truly alarmed China is the change in Japan's stance on Taiwan. There are plenty of long-standing disputes between Japan and China, from the territorial dispute over the Diaoyu/Senkaku Islands to the controversy over the Yasukuni shrine and museum and Japan's strong ties to Taiwan. By describing an invasion of Taiwan as a potentially critical situation for Japan that could, under the country's constitution, justify military action, Takaichi pushed the latter issue to the forefront of the relationship.

China has repeatedly singled out Takaichi not because it sees the boundaries of Japan's China policy being pushed forward. Her remarks were not an isolated episode. Since she took office, Japan's diplomatic language, political positioning, and military deployments have all moved in the same direction. The new diplomatic bluebook lowers China's standing, signaling a political cooling of the relationship. Japan is accelerating the deployment of long-range strike capabilities on its own territory that could reach China.

Japan is also deepening security support for the Philippines and taking part in joint exercises with the United States and the Philippines, embedding itself more deeply in the regional architecture aimed at constraining China. Any one of these steps could be described as defensive. Together, however, they point to a clear strategic intention: Within the U.S.-led Indo-Pacific framework, Japan is preparing to play a more active role in balancing against China.

There is no question that the U.S.-China rivalry remains Beijing's primary focus. But in terms of immediate security, Japan may be a larger risk. Precisely because the U.S.-China conflict's scope is so large, both sides know the cost of losing control would

be enormous, which makes them more cautious. China and Japan are different. They are geographically much closer and burdened by far heavier historical memories. The Diaoyu/Senkaku waters, the Taiwan Strait, Okinawa, and the waterways among Japan's southwestern islands are all high-risk zones.

Hostility between China and Japan is far more easily amplified by history and nationalist emotion than hostility between China and the United States. De-escalating in these circumstances is increasingly difficult. The old model of cooperation mixed with friction will be hard to return to.

China's threshold for restraint toward the United States and toward Japan will not be the same, either. With the United States, Beijing must weigh global finance, technology and supply chains, nuclear deterrence, and alliance dynamics. With Japan, Beijing is likewise unwilling to trigger war immediately, but its threshold for conflict may be lower. China believes that, economically or militarily, it holds greater, closer, and more usable advantages over Japan than it does over the United States, especially in the East China Sea, nearby waters, and gray-zone competition. As a result, Beijing may be more inclined in dealing with Japan to test boundaries with harder moves rather than leaving itself the wider margin it

usually seeks in managing crises with Washington.

And that is where the danger lies. Neither side wants a war, but both are moving closer to conflict. Japan believes it is strengthening deterrence; China believes Japan is preparing to intervene in Taiwan. China believes it is warning and countering; Japan sees military pressure. Both call their own actions defensive yet view the other's as offensive.

A growing number of uncertainties could drive the crisis out of control. A dangerous close encounter, a miscalculation, a fire-control radar lock, or an overreaction by a lower-level commander could all push both sides across the threshold of a conflict they want to avoid.

In the short term, both will still try to avoid war. But that does not mean the risk of war is falling. On the contrary, if Takaichi remains in power in the years ahead and continues her nationalist, openly hostile-to-China line, the strategic confrontation between China and Japan will only deepen. If that trajectory holds, a serious clash—whether in the East China Sea, the Diaoyu/Senkaku Islands, or even around Okinawa itself—is increasingly difficult to rule out. ■

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A sailor raises the Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force ensign on board a *Hyuga*-class helicopter destroyer as it docks in Manila, Philippines, on June 21, 2025.









# WRUNG OUT

THE WAR IN IRAN HAS  
DEPLETED THE PENTAGON  
AS CHINA'S MILITARY  
BUILDUP MATURES.

BY HAL BRANDS

T

he war in the Persian Gulf has created global shock waves—by roiling the world economy, unsettling U.S. alliances, creating epic disruptions to freedom of navigation, and bringing the nuclear nonproliferation order to a tipping point. But one of the most important and potentially destabilizing implications of this conflict has been to throw U.S. strategic insolvency into harsh relief.

The war has featured impressive tactical feats by the United States and Israel, such as the killing of dozens of high-ranking Iranian officials in the opening hours of the fight. The capabilities on display over Tehran—and U.S. President Donald Trump's penchant for military risk-taking—have surely been sobering for Washington's adversaries in Moscow and Beijing. Yet the war has had more ambiguous, sometimes damaging, strategic outcomes. It has also caused an alarming depletion of key U.S. weapons stockpiles while ripping capabilities away from other dangerous theaters. In short, the conflict has badly strained a military that has been trying to do too much with too little for far too long.

There's a saying in the Defense Department that every U.S. war plan is an existential threat to all the other war plans. A draining conflict in the Middle East may make it harder for Washington to deter a far more devastating fight in the Western Pacific—and usher in a dangerous period in which an overtaxed U.S. military struggles to respond to surging global risks.

Danger doesn't have to bring disaster: It's possible that the United States will navigate the coming years without a catastrophic failure of deterrence. Crises can have silver linings: If this crisis catalyzes greater, sustained urgency in closing the gap between the Pentagon's sprawling commitments and its all-too-finite capabilities, it may have a

salutary strategic effect. But the period immediately ahead looks menacing. The world is getting more violent and more disordered—just as Trump's war has made Washington's chronic overstretch more acute.

**TRUMP DIDN'T CREATE THE PROBLEM** of U.S. military and strategic overstretch. It has been building across multiple presidencies.

Over the past two decades, the global threat environment has gotten uglier and more crowded. A country that once towered over adversaries now faces challenges from revisionist great powers, angry rogue states, and tenacious nonstate foes. Looming above all other dangers is a new cold war—with the risk of a catastrophic hot war—against a relentlessly arming China. Yet the United States has sought to handle what increasingly looks like a perilous prewar situation with a post-Cold War approach to military spending. U.S. defense budgets, typically between 3 and 4 percent of GDP, have remained low by historical standards. Fatigue from long wars in Iraq and Afghanistan after 9/11 made the politics of defense more difficult. The predictable result has been a growing mismatch between Washington's global commitments and its military resources—a mismatch that one nonpartisan expert commission after another has identified and that one administration after another has tried and failed to fix.

The seemingly perpetual pattern is one in which each new administration promises to better apportion scarce resources through stricter prioritization—only to end up intervening



The world is getting more violent and more disordered—just as Trump's war has made Washington's chronic overstretch more acute.



in precisely those places it aimed to avoid. Barack Obama promised a pivot to the Pacific but ended up mired back in the Middle East. The first Trump administration touted the return of great-power rivalry but was then consumed by crises with North Korea and Iran. Joe Biden sought to stabilize relations with Moscow and Tehran so that the Pentagon could finally gear up for China. But then Russia launched a full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022, and the Middle East exploded a year later. The desire for focus and the divestment of lesser problems has consistently collided with the realities of a messy world in which Washington still has global interests. Trump's second term was supposed to fix this problem but made it much worse.

Trump initially filled the Pentagon with “prioritizers” who wanted to emphasize Asia and “restrainers” who wanted out of the Middle East. His administration pushed European and East Asian allies to take greater responsibility for their own defense. His new National Security Strategy and National Defense Strategy proclaimed that the era of costly Middle Eastern wars was over. Trump 2.0 promised discipline after decades of distraction. Instead, it brought omnidirectional, almost hyperactive, intervention.

To wage a short but fierce war against the Houthis in early 2025, Trump surged aircraft carriers, precision-strike capabilities, and other assets into the Middle East. He then struck Iran while sending precious air and missile defense capabilities to protect Israel during the countries' 12-day war in June. The administration carried out counterterrorism operations in Nigeria, Somalia, and elsewhere, including one of the largest bombing raids in the history of the U.S. Navy. In December 2025 and January 2026, U.S. forces blockaded Venezuela and smashed their way into Caracas to seize President Nicolás Maduro. Washington continued to provide scarce weapons, including Patriot missile interceptors, to Ukraine.

Each of these initiatives served a compelling U.S. interest, including defending freedom of navigation, rolling back Iran's nuclear program, and reasserting the Monroe Doctrine. Some of them, such as the bombing raid on Iran's nuclear facilities in June 2025 and the snatching of Maduro, were strikingly successful. But each of these interventions increased the strain on an overextended military. The corrosive effects were becoming obvious even as this year's Iran crisis began.

Trump was initially inclined to strike in January, after the Iranian regime defied his warnings by massacring thousands of protesters. But he couldn't start the war then because the necessary resources were nowhere near the Middle East. Strike aircraft, air and missile defense, and other capabilities had to be assembled from distant regions. The USS *Gerald R. Ford* aircraft carrier, for example, had been pulled from the Mediterranean to the Caribbean to support



operations in Venezuela—and now had to race back to the Middle East. The U.S. military was out of position for a crisis because limited capabilities were being stretched across a seemingly endless set of missions. The course of the subsequent war revealed both the lethal proficiency and perilous inadequacy of U.S. arms.

**THE LETHAL PROFICIENCY** is undeniable. In important respects, Operation Epic Fury was a striking display of military strength. The United States and Israel started with a surprise attack that decimated Iran's leadership. Within days, they eviscerated the country's air defenses and largely claimed control of the skies. The coalition then sank Iran's navy and struck its defense industry; it degraded the missile arsenal that Tehran uses to menace the Middle East (although the level of damage may initially have been overstated).

In addition, the United States and Israel dramatically accelerated the process of finding and striking targets with the help of artificial intelligence. One of the most intense, concentrated air campaigns in modern history saw the use of nearly 5,200 munitions in just the first 96 hours. Michael Brown, a former director of the Pentagon's Defense Innovation Unit, called the conflict the “first AI war”—the first time a global superpower used AI-enabled capabilities at scale in sustained, high-intensity combat. The war advertised an unmatched ability to fuse precision strikes with pinpoint intelligence. In the force-on-force contest, the United States and Israel savaged an enemy armed, in part, with Russian and Chinese weapons.

This performance, however, didn't demolish a resilient Iranian regime. It didn't prevent Iran from using drones and missiles to strike U.S. bases in the region and inflict painful punishment on other Gulf countries. It also did not keep Tehran from putting a hammerlock on the Strait of Hormuz. As of this writing, the war's strategic results were notably ambiguous: Iran was pummeled and empowered all at once.

**THE WAR DID, HOWEVER,** carry an unambiguously heavy price tag in sophisticated, finite U.S. weapons.

The size of most critical U.S. military stockpiles is classified, and the Defense Department hasn't said precisely how many munitions were used. But according to published estimates by the Center for Strategic and International Studies, based on publicly available data, U.S. forces fired more than 1,000 long-range Tomahawk cruise missiles, or roughly one-third of the entire stockpile, during the phase of intense fighting from late February until early April. That phase also consumed roughly one-quarter of the military's JASSM stockpile (another long-range cruise missile), along with smaller shares of other standoff munitions that allow U.S. forces to deliver destruction from a distance. Similarly, shielding U.S. forces and regional partners from Iranian drone and missile salvos required large numbers of high-end weapons that are mainstays of U.S. air and missile defense—for example, somewhere between 30 and 60 percent of the Pentagon's SM-3 ballistic missile interceptors, the majority of its THAAD missiles, and around half of its Patriots.

These systems are central to U.S. contingency plans in multiple theaters, and there aren't nearly enough to go around. Tomahawk and JASSM missiles and THAAD, Patriot, and SM-3 interceptors would be at the heart of U.S. contingency plans in the Western Pacific, whether to strike Chinese targets from a safer distance or to protect bases and allies from Chinese strikes. These weapons were already in short supply before this war: Think tank studies and war-games have repeatedly shown that U.S. forces don't have the magazine depth for a protracted great-power fight. Replenishment could be a lengthy process. At current production rates, it could take up to four years just to replace the weapons used against Iran.

That's not the only way this war required robbing the future to pay the present—or robbing other regions to fortify the Middle East. The saga of the *Gerald R. Ford*, whose exhausting back-to-back-to-back deployments in the Mediterranean, the Caribbean, and once more in the Middle East constituted the longest stretch at sea for an aircraft carrier since the Cold War, is instructive. It's part of a larger pattern of heavy naval deployments in the Middle East since Hamas's Oct. 7, 2023, attack on Israel, which have run the

U.S. surface fleet ragged and may limit the availability of key assets in the future. The Pentagon stripped East Asia of key resources—including THAAD missiles and marine amphibious units—not long after issuing a National Defense Strategy that called that region the priority theater for the United States. More broadly, any war of such intensity stresses innumerable elements of the force—aircraft, ships, submarines, and personnel—that perform an array of vital missions. The stress may persist for some time to come.

The initial phase of the war lasted six weeks, from late February to early April. Yet it was followed by a resource-intensive U.S. naval blockade and preparations for a potential renewal of the fighting. At one point, there were three U.S. carrier strike groups in the Middle East, roughly the number that are typically deployed *globally* at any given time. Even in a relatively optimistic scenario, it seems likely that the United States will be engaged in long-term containment of a wounded but vengeful Iran, akin to the containment of Saddam Hussein's Iraq after the 1991 Gulf War. That mission will continue to demand significant U.S. resources—and create gaping vulnerabilities for a superpower that was already overstretched.

**THE GRAVEST DANGER** is that one globally disruptive war in the Gulf will raise the likelihood of a much nastier fight. A conflict in the Taiwan Strait, pitting the United States against China, would be a lethal, high-intensity nightmare. It would blow apart sensitive supply chains that bring high-end microchips to market and could sever the busiest, most lucrative maritime trade routes in the world. A war between Beijing and Washington might well spread throughout the Western Pacific and into other regions as the two sides sought allies and leverage. There would be serious prospects of escalation in a showdown between nuclear-armed foes. The chances of such a war have been rising; even before the most recent Gulf flare-up, the military balance in the Western Pacific was shifting in ominous ways.

For decades, a determined Chinese buildup has been

The danger is that continuing conflict in the Gulf will deplete and distract the U.S. military just as China is becoming stronger and more assertive.



changing the strategic landscape of the region, by making it more difficult for Taiwan to resist an assault—and harder for the United States to come to its aid. More recently, Beijing has embarked on rapid-fire expansion of its nuclear arsenal, which could provide coercive leverage in a crisis. Indeed, Chinese President Xi Jinping is putting the pedal to the metal: People's Liberation Army watcher Sam Roggeveen called 2025 a “red banner year” as the Chinese military rolled out many new programs and capabilities, from additional aircraft carriers to sixth-generation fighters.

Xi has instructed his generals to be ready for a Taiwan operation as early as 2027. An invasion isn't the only option, of course: The Chinese military regularly conducts exercises—U.S. officials call them “rehearsals”—for a no-notice quarantine or blockade meant to strangle Taiwan into submission. Beijing's gray-zone coercion of Taiwan and other East Asian neighbors is only getting bolder over time. The danger, then, is that continuing conflict in the Gulf will deplete and distract the U.S. military just as China is becoming stronger and more assertive.

This problem isn't entirely new: In 2022, Michael Beckley and I warned that the United States would enter a “danger zone” in the late 2020s. At that point, China's military buildup would be maturing, while U.S. power temporarily dipped as the Pentagon retired older ships, planes, and submarines—and newer U.S. and allied investments would only gradually change the balance for the better. With the Iran war reducing U.S. stockpiles to even more glaring levels of insufficiency—and considering the many years it may take to replenish them—that danger zone could get longer and more severe.

It's important not to overstate this point—or ignore the possibility that the war could have positive impacts on global perceptions of U.S. strength. The Pentagon's performance against Iran might bolster deterrence by dramatizing the qualitative superiority of the U.S. military, as well as Trump's willingness to lash out against hostile states that earn his wrath. The war has also demonstrated how damaging drones and missiles can be to ill-defended surface ships—a problem for Xi if he sends an armada of



troop and equipment transports across the Taiwan Strait. Trump's counterblockade of Hormuz made real one of the great Chinese strategic anxieties of the last few decades by showing how readily the U.S. Navy could choke off China's oil imports in a crisis. Deterrence is a psychological phenomenon, and aspects of the recent crisis surely give Xi pause about launching a military adventure of his own.

Also bear in mind that Washington isn't the only great power with readiness problems. Xi's serial purges have effectively lobotomized the top ranks of the Chinese military. "We're running out of munitions, but they're running out of generals," one well-informed U.S. observer told me. And don't make the mistake of thinking that Xi's decision to attack would simply be a matter of missile arithmetic. Such an epic, legacy-defining decision would surely flow from a more complex assessment of costs and risks.

Yet none of this can be particularly comforting to China hawks in the Trump administration who spent the Biden years scoffing at the idea that looking strong while spending down key assets in Ukraine or the Middle East would strengthen the U.S. hand in the Western Pacific. Even if conflict with Iran could fortify the psychological pillars of U.S. deterrence, it has weakened the material foundations of that deterrence. And whatever the complexity of Xi's calculations, U.S. military weakness creates greater risk that China could choose to test the status quo more aggressively—or that deterrence could fail if an unanticipated crisis sends tensions soaring and brings the cross-strait standoff to a head.

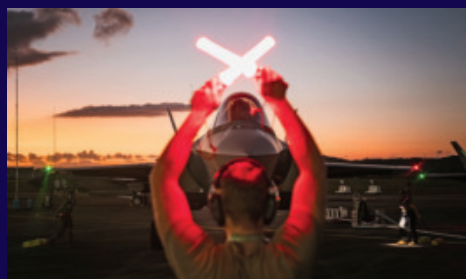
If a war does occur in the Western Pacific, a degraded and globally scattered U.S. military would face higher chances of grievous losses, an indecisive outcome, or an outright defeat. Remember: Concerns about the U.S. military simply not having enough to prosecute a protracted fight with China were rising well before Trump's latest battle with Iran. Even short of that horrific eventuality, acute overstretch could incur serious strategic costs.

**MILITARY VULNERABILITY** can bring diplomatic timidity by giving the Trump team strong incentive to avoid friction with China. It could lock in the emerging pattern of the last 18 months, in which Trump pushes around weaker powers like Iran and Venezuela while being more accommodating of mighty rivals in Russia and China. A Beijing that doesn't go for broke with a full-on invasion or blockade could find other ways of exploiting a more tenuous U.S. position—for example, by conducting periodic "customs quarantines" that simply advertise an ability to squeeze Taipei or by intensifying below-the-threshold coercion in the Taiwan Strait or elsewhere in the region. This may not be a hypothetical: This spring, following a yearslong respite, Beijing restarted

major island-building efforts in the South China Sea. The balance of military power inevitably shapes risk-taking and decision-making in a tense peace as well as during war. And if a shifting balance encourages greater Chinese risk-taking at the margin, it could also demoralize U.S. allies that feel isolated and exposed.

Some of these dynamics are already discernible. Chinese propagandists have pointed to a decrease in U.S. patrol flights in the South China Sea as evidence that Washington is forever mired in the Middle East. Regarding U.S. force repositioning, one Chinese expert noted that "any weakening of its presence in the Asia-Pacific will inevitably work to someone's advantage—and you can imagine who that is."

Former Japanese Defense Minister Gen Nakatani has warned that the recent removal of U.S. marine units and other capabilities from the Western Pacific could "destabilize the balance of power around Japan." The United States also removed THAAD interceptors from South Korea, even though Seoul had paid a heavy price for the original deployment of those interceptors in the form of economic punishment imposed by Beijing. South Korean President Lee Jae-myung said in March that the war compels greater self-reliance because "you always have to think about what you're going to do if there's no external support." But self-reliance could also get harder because the war is delaying U.S. arms sales to allies: In April, reports emerged that U.S. officials had notified Japan that delivery of some 400 Tomahawk missiles would be postponed.



A superpower that became accustomed to outright military supremacy in the post-Cold War era will now have to grapple with the dilemmas its weakened position brings.

To be sure, day-to-day military cooperation in most of Washington's Pacific alliances is excellent. No one thinks the United States is leaving the region anytime soon. But another costly intervention in the Middle East is producing fears that Washington has once again failed to pivot its attention and resources to the Pacific—just as the military peril is becoming more acute.

Beyond alliance challenges in East Asia, there will be other global ramifications. Ukraine will be a winner of this war, in the sense that the world now realizes it desperately needs the cost-effective drone defenses that Kyiv makes at scale. But it will also be a loser, in the sense that the war has made it harder for Washington to sell its European allies key weapons, above all missile defense interceptors, for provision to Ukraine. More broadly, the war raises the odds of a repeat of Washington's problem in January. The situation in which the Pentagon found itself as the Iran crisis unfolded—fatigued, out of position, unable to respond promptly—may become more the rule than the exception in the years ahead.

Overstretch brings heightened risk of catastrophes such as deterrence failure and military defeat, along with everyday costs such as strained alliances and loss of diplomatic leverage. A superpower that became accustomed to outright military supremacy in the post-Cold War era will now have to grapple with the dilemmas its weakened position brings.

**IT IS TEMPTING**, of course, to hope that the United States can solve its problem of overstretch just by doing less and swearing off dumb wars. Yet whatever one thinks of *this* Iran war, the United States remains a superpower with global interests—which is precisely why the strategy of stricter prioritization and selective retrenchment has failed so many times before. Fortunately, periods of danger don't have to lead to disaster. When addressed with the requisite urgency, they can have rejuvenating effects.

The United States faced an earlier danger zone in the late 1940s and early 1950s, when the Soviet acquisition of nuclear weapons and then the Korean War revealed how tenuous the Pentagon's global position was. That crisis spurred a massive military buildup that bolstered an emerging U.S. alliance network and gave the free world tremendous leverage and strength. During the 1970s, a relentless Soviet buildup threatened to tilt the balance back in Moscow's favor—until the United States and its allies responded, after the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in 1979, with a multiyear program of military enhancements that helped the West win the Cold War. These crises were useful catalysts. Could Washington's current military insolvency have a similarly invigorating effect?

There are some encouraging signs. The Trump administration has proposed historic increases in the defense

budget, which would raise military spending to between 4 and 5 percent of GDP. It is seeking to dramatically accelerate the production of crucial weapons, including many of those used so heavily against Iran. Precisely because the war has elicited such deep concerns about U.S. presence and power, it will probably give Washington's allies in Europe and the Pacific even greater incentive to augment their own strengths. It could impel creative efforts to forge a more integrated defense industrial base among the democracies, in which key U.S. allies help produce capabilities, such as Patriot or SM-3 missiles (a variant of the latter is already a joint Raytheon-Mitsubishi effort), or ease the U.S. shipbuilding crisis by constructing vessels for the U.S. Navy in their own yards.

Not least, the Iran conflict has revealed how emerging technologies, above all AI, can be a force multiplier for Washington and its allies—and served as proof of concept for potential uses in other theaters. The war should drive investment in smaller, less exquisite capabilities—such as one-way attack drones—that can deliver firepower in ferocious volumes, as well as in tools that can defeat incoming drone attacks without devouring scarce, expensive air defenses. So much of the fallout from the Iran war depends on what the United States and its allies do next. Perhaps now will be the moment when Washington recognizes and comes to grips with the dangers that its long-accumulating, now acute overstretch can bring.

Or perhaps not. The United States mostly squandered a prior crisis—the Russia-Ukraine war—that showcased the debility of its defense industrial base and the limits of its stockpiles. That industrial base is shot through with fragilities and chokepoints that make it hard to radically and quickly expand production, even if the money is there. It's still not clear that the money *will* be there over the medium and long term: Washington's frail fiscal position makes sustaining high defense spending politically and economically arduous. And a problem that develops over decades can't be solved overnight: Even if the United States summoned all the urgency and resources needed to return to strategic health, it could be years before some capabilities materialize in numbers that meaningfully affect the balance.

One way or another, the result of another draining war in the Middle East is likely to be a period of greater U.S. strategic vulnerability. The choices Washington and its allies make now will determine how long, and perhaps how deadly, that moment of peril will be. ■

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THE  
END  
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# How

ow does a world end? The American poet Robert Frost suggested there were two possibilities, by means of fire or ice. This was bad science, of course, but a plausible metaphor. Fire captures all the apocalyptic scenarios—climate catastrophe, nuclear war, an asteroid strike—that portend a volatile, and conclusive, end. As for ice—well, not all endings are explosive. Sometimes, a world ends gradually and quietly, before you realize what’s happening and before you can begin imagining what might come next. An end can be marked less by disruption than by disorientation, a loss of what one took for granted. There are times a world ends—*our* world ends—without *the* world ending.

That’s the animating thought behind these 10 essays. It’s no secret that international politics has been deeply transformed over the last several years, sparked by long-term trends such as the rise of China, short-term shocks such as the COVID-19 pandemic, and political idiosyncrasies such as the election (and reelection) of Donald Trump.

At FOREIGN POLICY, we’ve responded to these sudden shifts in several ways. We’ve tried to closely chronicle the various violations of the existing global order as they’ve happened, in the belief that each instance deserves its own moment of witness. We’ve also regularly taken a step back to consider what sort of new equilibrium international politics might arrive at next.

In this package, we want to traverse the middle ground between indignation and hopefulness by soberly surveying the extent of damage. What does it mean when the rules that had quietly structured political life until now are rendered obsolete? Our answer comes in the form of a series of obituaries for various ideas that have recently been overtaken, or obliterated, by the chaotic cascade of world events.

Some of these essays are elegiac in tone; some are in a broader “valedictory” mode—that is, backward-looking but not openly celebratory. What they have in common is the sense that the rupture in our politics is, in some ways, permanent.

The collection includes Branko Milanovic’s analysis of how the once ubiquitous pro-market ideology of neoliberalism produced its own demise and Rosa Brooks’s Agatha Christie-style analysis of the multiple parties responsible for the death of international law. Nathalie Tocci argues it’s time to move past trans-Atlanticism once and for all, and Anton Jäger considers whether political parties now exist in name only.

James Traub offers a reflection on the precipitous decline of the effectiveness of the United Nations, while Leah Aronowsky contemplates how climate politics, as traditionally understood, has recently faded from relevance. Linda Kinstler looks back on the meaning of the once universal idea of asylum, and Jonathan White analyzes what has been lost now that visions of the future seem to have disappeared from politics.

The ideas and institutions that we are bidding farewell to in these essays may yet return in some form; resurrection is a possibility in political, if not biological, life. What’s clear is that, before they pass from memory—before fire or ice or any other forces of destruction complete their work—it’s worth reflecting on what they meant in the first place.

—Cameron Abadi, deputy editor

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# The Not-So-Special Alliance

Most Americans no longer view U.S. and Israeli interests as inherently compatible.

By Joshua Leifer

**IT WOULD SEEM** that Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has accomplished what his predecessors could only have dreamed of: U.S. and Israeli fighter jets flying tandem over Tehran, Israeli officers ensconced in U.S. Central Command's Florida headquarters. Since the days of David Ben-Gurion, Israel's leaders have sought backing from the world's preeminent superpower, which they hoped would guarantee their state's survival into perpetuity. None could have imagined the level of cooperation currently on display. If one were to wake up the Old Man, as Ben-Gurion was known, from his otherworldly slumber in the sands of Sde Boker, he would surely delight in the news.

Appearances, however, can be deceiving. In one sense, the U.S.-Israel relationship is at its apogee. Viewed from another angle, it has already entered a period of terminal decline. The political, ideological, and sociological pillars on which the so-called special alliance rested for most of the last half-century have begun to collapse. The Israel-advocacy complex—the network of lobbying groups such as the American Israel Public Affairs Committee (AIPAC), Jewish communal organizations such as the Anti-Defamation League, and Christian Zionist groups such as Christians United for Israel—was once a juggernaut on Capitol Hill. In today's climate of hyperpolarization, it has started to falter, challenged first by the progressive flank of the Democratic Party and now increasingly by the neoisolationist faction of the MAGA coalition.

Public opinion has shifted dramatically. Less than half of Americans now say U.S. support for Israel is in the national interest; for the first time, Americans also view Palestinians more sympathetically than they do Israelis. Nor is it any longer a given that Americans and Israelis hold a common set of cultural and religious values. As the United States has become less Christian and more diverse, Israeli society has become more traditionalist, its public culture more insular. On both the U.S. right and left, antisemitism has also begun to seep from the margins into the political mainstream, seen by growing numbers of people, especially among the young and disaffected, as a marker of anti-establishment bona fides in populist times.

These shifts were well underway before the Hamas attack of Oct. 7, 2023. But Israel's subsequent destruction of Gaza,

its blockade and starvation of the devastated territory, and spiraling settler violence in the occupied West Bank—all livestreamed over social media for more than two years—greatly accelerated them, generating an anti-Israel backlash that has become a ubiquitous feature of contemporary U.S. politics. If indeed the joint U.S.-Israeli war on Iran constitutes the apex of the special alliance, what follows will be the fall.

The special alliance was not always so special. While it was U.S. President Harry Truman who recognized Israel, his successor Dwight D. Eisenhower was notably chilly toward the state, wary of upsetting the U.S. strategic calculus in the early Cold War. John F. Kennedy broke with Ike's arms embargo and was the first to supply Israel with U.S. arms; Richard Nixon, or rather his advisor Henry Kissinger, rescued Israel in 1973, engineering the crucial airlift of military aid that staved off defeat in the Arab-Israeli war. Still, the relationship had its limits. Jimmy Carter, Ronald Reagan, and George H.W. Bush all knew how to say no to Israel's leaders—sometimes forcefully in terms that today would shock, sometimes with the threat of material consequences—and little feared the Israel-advocacy complex, which was a relative welterweight compared with the heft it would throw around by the mid-1990s.

The end of the Cold War brought the United States and Israel into closer alignment. The relationship was no longer tempered by broader U.S. considerations of global great-power equilibrium. There developed what international relations scholars call a "community of strategic interests." Israel assumed the role of enforcer of the new U.S.-led international order in the Middle East. With the launch of the global war on terrorism, U.S. and Israeli interests seemed to converge even further. In terms the pliant U.S. media reflexively echoed, U.S. and Israeli leaders framed their countries' interests as identical and their foes, whether Osama bin Laden and al Qaeda or Yasser Arafat and the PLO, two sides of the same radical, terrorist coin.

That overlap of strategic interests was, in turn, bolstered by a widespread sense of shared values. At the very moment the United States embarked on democracy promotion abroad, Israeli leaders boasted of the country's uniqueness as the region's sole democratic state. For those who saw the war on terrorism in civilizationist terms, Israel was the front-line defender in the struggle between the Judeo-Christian West and its Islamist enemies. American liberals, meanwhile, were inclined to see in Israel an exemplary open society amid a black sea of authoritarian Arab regimes, conservative theocracies, and Islamist militants. From Bill Clinton through George W. Bush, U.S. policy in the Middle East was dominated alternately by Atlanticist liberal interventionists and their more sharp-elbowed cousins, the neoconservatives.

For the growing Israel-advocacy complex, this was favorable ground for maneuvering. AIPAC could marshal

near-unanimous support for Israel across both parties, while its aligned think tanks maintained a revolving door between Republican and Democratic administrations. Advocates for Palestinian rights, for their part, lacked any comparable apparatus, and few Palestinian writers were being published in mainstream outlets, unlike today. Meanwhile, complaints about the Israel lobby's power were, for the most part, relegated to the conspiratorial fringes where the boundaries of the far left blurred with the far right. And with Holocaust memorial culture at its peak—the U.S. Holocaust Memorial Museum opened in 1993—an accusation of antisemitism still carried its career-ending severity.

It was the pro-Israel right, not the pro-Palestinian left, that shattered the bipartisan consensus in Washington. The pivotal year was 2015. Then, as now, the issue was Iran. As the Obama administration pushed for a nuclear deal, the Israel-advocacy complex went to war against the widely popular Democratic president. AIPAC dumped roughly \$40 million into lobbying against the nuclear deal. Republican House Speaker John Boehner invited Netanyahu to address a joint session of Congress without first notifying the president, a move widely seen as a politicized breach of procedure and basic decorum. Behind the lectern, Netanyahu lambasted the Obama administration's deal-in-the-making that would "only change the Middle East for the worse."

The Israel-advocacy complex's blitz failed to stop the nuclear deal. Instead, it demolished its own vestigial facade of bipartisanship. Pro-Israel groups soon began to function openly as a wing of the Republican Party, especially

as Jewish communal organizations shed the pretense of representing the views of most American Jews in favor of the priorities of right-wing megadonors. Trump's first term deepened this process of partisan polarization on Israel even further. He embraced a hawkish pro-Israel line far to the right of any previous administration: shuttering the PLO's office in Washington, moving the U.S. Embassy to Jerusalem, and recognizing Israeli sovereignty over the Golan Heights. Trump has arguably done more to push rank-and-file Democrats away from Israel than any pro-Palestinian activist.

2015 also marked a turning point in Israel's trajectory. Over the course of a bruising election campaign, Netanyahu appeared to radicalize. He eschewed the image of the Israeli right's responsible adult and embraced the style of authoritarian populism ascendant around the globe. Whereas Netanyahu had previously given lip service to a negotiated settlement with the Palestinians, he pivoted toward open territorial maximalism. After his 2019 indictment on corruption charges, Netanyahu grew ever more desperate in his attempts to remain in power. He forged electoral alliances with the most extreme forces in Israeli political life, not only normalizing the followers of the quasi-fascist rabbi Meir Kahane and hard-line messianic settlers but empowering them as ministers in his government.

Against the backdrop of democratic backsliding within Israel proper and the deepening occupation of the West Bank and siege of Gaza, vanishingly few American liberals could claim to share values with their Israeli counterparts. Meanwhile, a new generation of progressives came

of age having known only the Israel of Netanyahu. That generational cohort was more diverse than any before it, comprising, to a significant degree, the children of immigrants from South and Southeast Asia and the Middle East. Many of them rejected the U.S. tradition of pro-Israel politics, were inclined to view Israel with antipathy, and felt no fealty to the Holocaust meta-narrative that had become an anchor of U.S. political culture. An increasing number of young American Jews also began to challenge support for Israel as a pillar of American Jewish identity; some would become prominent leaders of a resurgent anti-Zionist movement.

During these same years, between the killings of Michael Brown in Ferguson, Missouri, and George Floyd





in Minneapolis, U.S. progressives underwent a “racial reckoning” that dramatically reshaped their understanding of identity and power—a shift that would have significant ramifications for the debate about Israel within the left wing of the Democratic Party. In 2016, long before Oct. 7, the Movement for Black Lives published its policy platform in which it labeled Israel’s policies toward the Palestinians a genocide.

More recently, a segment of the MAGA right has joined the progressive left in its rejection of the U.S.-Israel relationship. The terms of critique are different. Beyond the swamp of antisemitic conspiracism that has engulfed parts of the young and online right, those who identify with the “restraint”-oriented faction of the MAGA coalition have begun to call for a reevaluation of U.S. support for Israel. They charge that there is not, or no longer is, a community of interest between the two allies and that Israel and its advocates exert an out-sized and undue influence on U.S. foreign-policy making. They advocate for slashing U.S. aid to erstwhile allies as part of what they hope will be Washington’s withdrawal from imperial management and see no reason why the relationship with Israel should remain an exception.

If the old bipartisan pro-Israel consensus has collapsed, a new anti-Israel consensus is taking shape on the edges of both the Democratic and Republican parties. For Democrats, the primaries ahead of the 2028 election will almost certainly be a referendum on Israel. Already, activists have made significant strides in pressuring candidates to distance themselves from AIPAC and other groups associated with the Israel-advocacy complex. Universal healthcare was the watchword of the 2020 primaries; conditioning, or ending, U.S. military aid to Israel will likely fill the same role in 2028. On the left, hostility to Israel—the more strident, the better—is fast becoming a litmus test as an indicator of reliability on other matters of progressive concern.

Among Republicans, much will depend on the aftermath of the Iran war. If the economic and diplomatic pain suffered by Americans sticks, Israel and its advocates will take the blame. That scenario will likely empower the neoisolationists and restrainers, whose champion, at least for the moment, is Vice President J.D. Vance. But if he is sullied by the Iran debacle, there are other figures waiting in the wings, including conservative pundit Tucker Carlson, whose presidential ambitions are only whispered for now. On the right, too, military aid to Israel will be on the chopping block regardless as a baseline position much of MAGA can embrace.

Where, then, does this all leave Netanyahu? The Israeli prime minister has already begun to spin the eventual reduction in U.S. military aid as his own proposal, rather than face a political fight over a new aid package that Israel is not in a position to win. Netanyahu has pledged to wean Israel off U.S. assistance entirely over the next decade. The Heritage

Foundation has drafted a proposal that outlines how that might work, substituting the current model of providing discounts to Israel for buying U.S. materiel with joint weapons technology efforts—hardly a return to the U.S. arms embargo on Israel of the early Cold War years.

Yet Netanyahu may be too sanguine about a future for Israel after the end of the special alliance. Having taken it for granted, he is perhaps more responsible than anyone else for its precipitous decline. When he departs the scene, he will leave Israel worse off for it. ■

**JOSHUA LEIFER** is a columnist for *Haaretz* and the author of *Tablets Shattered: The End of an American Jewish Century and the Future of Jewish Life*.

## Where Neoliberalism Went Wrong

Its virtues led to its demise.

By **Branko Milanovic**

**IF ONE WERE TO DEFINE** neoliberal globalization during the 40-year period from the early 1980s to around 2020, one could say it was driven by two ideas: cosmopolitanism and competition. One could also say these same features have now led to neoliberalism’s undoing.

Cosmopolitanism was an essential neoliberal idea going back to the meetings of the Walter Lippmann Colloquium in 1930s Paris and the early Mont Pèlerin Society. Cosmopolitanism meant that every individual in the world was to be thought of as equally important and equally capable of economic improvement if they faced optimal economic conditions—which implied security of private property, free trade, low taxes, and a “tolerable administration of justice.” Very little else, in the words of economist Adam Smith, was needed to fulfill the universal desire of all persons to “better their own condition” and for the world to attain unimaginable levels of prosperity.

Cosmopolitanism was also the political idea underpinning a neoliberal world where national government as such would be out of sight and would leave individuals free to pursue their self-interest. This was, ideally, a world of small or almost invisible government. In the language of early advocates of neoliberalism, “imperium”—that is, flags, anthems, languages, and other paraphernalia of nationhood—would



be left to politicians (and to voters, if citizens insisted on voting), and the more consequential world of “dominium” would consist of the movement of goods, capital, technology, and people.

For cosmopolitanism to create global wealth and prosperity, the world also had to be competitive. Not only would people be allowed to compete with (or against) one another regardless of national borders, but they also needed to be stimulated to compete by the display of all the goods that could be theirs and by the societal approval they would command if they won in that competition.

Competition produced global growth: Between 1980 and 2020-21, the average world GDP per capita more than doubled, jumping from \$7,700 (in 2005 international dollars, adjusted for purchasing power parity) to almost \$17,000. This makes the worldwide yearly average growth rate 2.1 percent per capita, an extraordinarily high rate for a period of 40 years. (And this despite the increase of the world population from 4.4 billion in 1980 to 8.3 billion now.) The more than doubling of per capita income combined with an almost doubling of the world population means that the total amount of goods and services produced in the world quadrupled during the era of neoliberal globalization.

But this “anonymous” growth rate, realized principally thanks to the high growth rates of Asian countries and notably China, did not help neoliberals’ case in rich countries. What was politically salient was not the 2.1 percent global rate but the fact that in the United States and in most rich Western countries, much of the population registered real (adjusted for inflation) growth rates of approximately 1 percent per year, while incomes of the rich grew two to three times faster.

Moreover, the neoliberal period (dated from Ronald Reagan’s presidency onward) was not only pro-rich, in the sense that incomes of the rich increased faster than those of the middle class and the poor. It also represented a slow-down in across-the-board growth compared with the preceding period. In fact, at every point of U.S. income distribution—except at the very top—growth was slower during the neoliberal era than during the previous decade and a half.

The world, at least for a while, seemed to become uniform, divided not by borders of nation-states, race, or gender but by differences in people’s abilities, skills, and effort. It was approaching the neoliberal ideal of a borderless world full of intensively competitive individuals whose competitive juices were additionally stimulated by the ability to communicate with

any part of the globe and to learn what potential competitors may do—and then to try to outdo them.

But cosmopolitanism and competition, however attractive in themselves, were an unstable combination.

Cosmopolitanism crashed against national political borders. Excessive competition created a world of greed, amorality, and commercialization of all activities, even those that used to be the most private ones. Fundamentally, it threatened to make family superfluous.

The winners of neoliberal globalization in rich countries—inspired precisely by their cosmopolitanism, which they regarded as a moral virtue (being free of poisonous nationalism)—were quick not only to treat their less fortunate compatriots’ welfare as of no greater importance as the welfare of a foreigner or a stranger but also to believe that their compatriots’ failure in such an open competition was indicative of some moral flaw. Economic success meant being virtuous, or as Chinese leader Deng Xiaoping, whose rise to power coincided almost perfectly with those of Reagan and Margaret Thatcher in the United Kingdom, did not deny: “To be rich is glorious.”

The political system however is organized within nation-states. The less fortunate compatriots felt forgotten and ignored, and they were resentful of the way in which they were treated. They saw the readiness, even eagerness, of the rich to invest in faraway places as callousness toward domestic workers. Promises of new jobs that would replace those lost due to cheaper imports or online work elsewhere were hard to materialize.

The resulting discontent created political turbulence in the richest democracies. The 2007-08 global financial crisis made obvious what had previously only been implicit.

The rich did not care for those left behind, and when the costs of the crisis had to be paid, they made sure that the bill was not sent to them.

The malcontents who in previous times would equally replenish extreme left-wing and extreme right-wing parties, as they did during the Great Depression in the 1930s, had now much less choice. The left-wing parties were either discredited by the failure of the “real-existing socialism” or, through their accommodative third-way policies, seen as accomplices of the center-right parties in promoting the type of neoliberal globalization that so disenchanted Western working and middle classes. Indeed, the peak of neoliberal globalization was achieved under the notionally left-wing governments of Bill Clinton in the United States, Tony Blair in the U.K., and François Mitterrand in France.

So the disappointed masses turned toward the right-wing parties that promoted national solidarity, an end to the (economically) equal treatment of the domestic population and foreigners, and even a return of industrial jobs. In the international arena, neoliberal globalization thus became increasingly replaced by neomercantilism, which used economic coercion, the seizure of foreign assets, import bans, and extravagant tariff policies to cut, or at least control, the free flow of goods and services. Free flow of labor was even easier to cut because its political popularity, even at the peak of neoliberal globalization, was small.

The second part of the neoliberal equation—competition within society and across borders and time zones—created, with the assistance of technical advances, a world where the upkeep of one’s homes and cars and even domestic chores, from cooking to elder- and childcare, were shifted precisely to the people who no longer had steady jobs and were part of the class of malcontents. The moral norms that previously held societies and families together and would have forestalled such outsourcing had become effaced by a desire to be “glorious”—that is, to be rich. That perceived amorality also helped the rise of anti-systemic right-wing parties. They grew on the promise of a restoration not only of lost jobs but of self-respect among malcontents and a return to allegedly traditional values for society as a whole.

In short, neoliberalism has succumbed to its own substitution by a combination of protective barriers for foreign goods and foreign people and vain attempts to return to a more traditional world at home. As in a Greek tragedy, the very features that ensured neoliberal globalization’s success for decades produced its inevitable demise. ■

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# Trans-Atlanticism Couldn’t Survive This

The breach of trust is more than mere disagreement.

By **Nathalie Tocci**

**THE CURRENT CRISIS** between Europe and the United States marks the end of an era—regardless of who follows Donald Trump. The trans-Atlantic bond rested on specific features at the global level as well as within the United States and Europe. All are now gone.

The international context in which the bond bloomed—first in the postwar period and then in the era after the fall of the Berlin Wall—was one in which the United States was a liberal leviathan. It had fought and won two global wars—World War II and the Cold War—standing for liberal values. Those victories enabled it to spread those norms, first across Western Europe and parts of Asia and then throughout the world. The order that rested on U.S. power, including international organizations and laws, was imbued with a liberal ethos.

Trans-Atlanticism was embedded in this global context; it represented its inner core. This was true both of the international institutions that the United States was pivotal in establishing and leading—including the United Nations, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank, and NATO—and of those it supported from the outside, foremost among them the European Union, whose deepening and expansion it backed over the years. It was an order in which laws and norms were often violated, including, and at times especially, by the United States as well as Europe. Yet they were recognized and shared on both shores of the Atlantic. It was also a time in which the United States and Europe frequently disagreed over policy, sometimes profoundly. But those divergences never fundamentally shook a deep sense of mutual belonging or a shared belief in the values of freedom, democracy, and international cooperation.

That liberal order is now gone. Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney broke the spell at the World Economic Forum in January. Over successive crises—beginning with 9/11, through the global financial crisis, the crisis of liberal democracy, the COVID-19 pandemic, and the wars that have ravaged Europe and the Middle East—the international liberal order has been fraying for a quarter century. But while, for years, its most ardent believers continued to pay lip service to it, now even they are publicly acknowledging it is over.



The United States is no longer a leviathan or a liberal one. By acting as a predatory power and exploiting what remains of its privileged position, it is simply accelerating its own relative decline, especially with respect to an illiberal China. This is crystal clear in areas such as trade, energy, and even diplomacy. Beijing's ascendancy is only being propelled by Washington's self-inflicted wounds: tariffs, a stubborn reluctance to embrace the energy transition, and a catastrophic war in Iran.

In the United States, illiberalism and authoritarianism are on the rise. There are still strong forces pushing in the opposite direction, and one has good reason to believe—and to hope—that they will eventually prevail. But even if this were to happen, there is little to suggest that Washington will simply revert to the past. This is not only because it will take immense time and effort to undo the damage the Trump administration has inflicted on domestic norms and institutions. As countries such as Poland and, as we are about to witness, Hungary demonstrate, there is no easy or

It is also because the United States has been changing profoundly as an economy, a polity, and a society and will continue to do so. The sense of belonging it felt toward Europe had particular roots, grounded in history and in the heritage of large parts of society—and especially of the elites who governed the country for many decades. That is changing as the societal and generational makeup of the country shifts.

In Europe, the change is rooted less in sociology and more in psychology. Trans-Atlanticism was never free of policy disagreements. Precisely because the economic, societal, political, and defense bonds were so deep, there were plenty of occasions for profound divergences—as often happens within families. There were also moments when disagreements led to a temporary distancing between the two shores, as with the 2003 invasion of Iraq.

notably its competition with China. This became a common refrain during Barack Obama's presidency and grew louder and starker during Trump's first term. But this was not necessarily a bad thing. It simply meant redesigning the social contract between the two sides of the Atlantic. A Europe highly dependent on the United States for its defense—one that knew Washington had its back—was counterbalanced by the U.S. defense industry's open access to the lucrative European market as well as by the use of joint military bases on European soil. As each war in the Middle East has shown, particularly the bases in southern Europe are crucial to U.S. power projection southward. Europeans



generally followed the United States, even when they disagreed with the choices it made, as in Iraq.

What has unfolded over the past year and a half is qualitatively different. It is not a redefinition of the trans-Atlantic social contract for reasons that are both inevitable and perhaps even desirable. It is a fundamental breach of trust that cannot be undone. This is manifested not only in the profound disdain that Trump and members of his administration display toward Europe and in the tariffs the United States has piled onto European goods, threatening more at every unrelated disagreement that arises. Nor is it merely the sway that Russian President Vladimir Putin—Europe’s archenemy—holds over Trump. It is above all the U.S. threats to annex Greenland, an integral part of Denmark and therefore of Europe, that have proved most damaging. Never before has the United States so brazenly threatened the independence, sovereignty, and territorial integrity of a European country.

Whatever happens next, that breach of trust has occurred, and what is broken will not be restored to its earlier condition. European dependence on the United States will be slow to diminish, and there will remain many issues on which Europeans and Americans share mutual interests and will work together. But just as Latin American countries have ingrained in their political DNA the understanding that the United States cannot be fully trusted and may turn against them, that same awareness has now been implanted in Europe. No matter the closeness and cooperation that may be rebuilt in future, the recent past will remain inscribed in European political consciousness in ways that simply did not exist before. It will be a gene that, in good trans-Atlantic times, may lie dormant—but will spring back to life when the trans-Atlantic relationship comes under strain once again. Europe’s immune system, psychologically as well as materially, is changing.

Does the end of trans-Atlanticism mean all is lost? Does it necessarily imply that Europe and the United States cannot be close again? No, it does not. The world has changed, and so have the United States and Europe. But mutual interests and a common foundation will continue to make the trans-Atlantic relationship important in future. Trans-Atlanticism as a liberal ideology inscribed in a specific historical period is over. But the trans-Atlantic relationship is not. And just as a couple, having gone through a painful separation or even divorce, can with time and effort become good friends again—so, too, can Europe and the United States. ■

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## Post-Paris

Technocratic governance proved limited in addressing climate change.

By **Leah Aronowsky**

**IN MANHATTAN’S UNION SQUARE**, mounted on a building home to a Best Buy and \$8,000-a-month one-bedroom apartments, is a public art installation known as the Climate Clock. Between flashes of “Stop Fossil Fuels” and “Protect Earth,” the clock counts down—to the second—until the world is committed irreversibly to 1.5 degrees Celsius of warming. When the clock was first unveiled in September 2020, the world had about seven years and 100-odd days to act. When I visited this February, the countdown stood at three years and 156 days.

Yet even before the clock reaches zero, it has already become something of a relic. Even beyond the Republican-led assault on climate—part of the broader ideological war on environmental, social, and governance standards and “woke capitalism”—the past few years have seen a stunning retreat from target-based climate goals as climate elites have walked back their previously hawkish positions. Bill Gates, for whom climate change has long been a signature issue, published a memo last October in the lead-up to the U.N. Climate Change Conference in Brazil, or COP30, criticizing the “doomsday outlook” of the climate community.

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney, who as governor of the Bank of England described climate change as a “defining issue for financial stability” and who in 2021 championed a series of landmark net-zero financial agreements during COP26 in Scotland, is now aggressively fast-tracking permits for liquefied natural gas export terminals. The same banks that once promised to no longer provide financing for new coal projects or drilling in the Arctic in the name of supporting net-zero goals have recently begun issuing forecasts about the business opportunities that 3 degrees of warming could bring.

Even the European Union—long the world’s self-styled leader on climate—has recently retreated from its most ambitious policies, abandoning a planned ban on new internal combustion engine vehicles and watering down its emissions reductions targets in the name of maintaining economic competitiveness. The consensus that long informed climate politics is fracturing: Whether because of political backlash, economic concerns, or elite resignation, a climate politics organized around global temperature targets appears increasingly unviable.



In the meantime, China has surged ahead in the clean energy sector, acting unilaterally to become the solar panel, lithium-ion battery, and electric vehicle supplier to the world. While China's emissions reductions have fallen short of its own targets, there is no denying that it has cornered the market to become the world's first clean energy superpower. It is a remarkable change in political tides for those who once believed the Western-designed framework of target-based international climate treaties would save the planet. It's worth asking what, precisely, this framework was and what it got so wrong.

When climate change first appeared on the international agenda in the late 1980s, it was framed as a problem with a self-evident solution. Coming on the heels of the successful U.N.-led negotiations to phase out ozone-depleting chemicals known as CFCs, climate change seemed poised to mark another triumph for a distinct genre of international environmental diplomacy: Western-led, science-based, and oriented toward preventing environmental problems rather than reacting to them once they occurred.

The extent to which the ozone treaty, known as the Montreal Protocol, informed climate politics cannot be overstated. Like climate change, ozone depletion was a problem identified by the scientific community as a looming threat rather than an already unfolding environmental crisis; like climate, it was a collective action problem that required buy-in from the entire international community

to be solved (even though it was a problem overwhelmingly caused by industrialized countries). Many of the diplomats, negotiators, U.N. officials, and NGOs involved in climate change had first cut their teeth on the ozone issue.

Expectations were thus high that climate would be solved using the ozone model: establish a scientific consensus about the nature of the threat, cultivate international political concern, and then negotiate a treaty organized around binding targets and timetables that included carve-outs for the developing world. The crucial distinctions between ozone and climate—such as the fact that ozone depletion was caused by a single class of chemicals rather than industrial society as a whole and that, in the

case of ozone, chemical substitutes were quickly identified that made it lucrative for industry leaders, such as U.S. giant DuPont, to get behind calls for a CFC phaseout—were typically downplayed in the name of cultivating a sense of hope and possibility.

Climate change's framing as a collective action problem meant that there was remarkably little by way of meaningful debate about competing political visions for responding to it. Instead, Western elites assumed that the tools for preventing climate change would come from within the prevailing international economic order.

And so, for the first two decades or so of climate politics, the global north's strategies for mitigating climate change consisted almost entirely of international cap-and-trade emissions markets and carbon offset credit schemes—quintessentially apolitical mechanisms designed to gently ease the world into a lower-carbon future without disrupting the industrial economy. By the 2010s, they were also proving largely impotent. The Kyoto Protocol, in which industrialized nations committed to binding emissions targets and timetables, was adopted in 1997—although, crucially, the United States refused to ratify the treaty because of its insistence on preserving economic sovereignty.

It was an early indication that technocratic governance would prove limited when it came to addressing climate. The EU duly forged on, launching the world's first carbon market in 2005, but overall, the world barely made a dent



in emissions. By 2015, global average carbon dioxide concentrations reached a record high of 399.4 parts per million.

2015 was also the year that the Paris Agreement was signed. After years of climate gridlock—the nadir coming in 2009, when the COP talks in Copenhagen collapsed—Paris was hailed as a historic breakthrough, a sign that collective action on climate remained possible.

Signed by 195 countries, the treaty attempted to remedy some of the political failures of Kyoto—swapping out binding country pledges in favor of voluntary ones—while adopting an ambitious goal of restricting global average temperature rise to below 2 degrees. The treaty was widely acknowledged as most likely inadequate. But, in theory, the international community had signaled its willingness to transcend conventional geopolitics in the name of a common goal of protecting the climate.

In one sense, climate politics after Paris seemed to expand and intensify, as scientific studies were published that portrayed climate change mitigation as, at once, increasingly urgent and increasingly out of reach. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change’s 2018 Special Report on 1.5 degrees of warming—which found that, given emission rates at the time, the world was on track to reach 1.5 degrees between 2030 and 2052—was widely interpreted to mean that humanity had a 12-year, Climate Clock-style “deadline” to prevent catastrophic global warming. The report sparked a new wave of mass climate activism, with Greta Thunberg’s Fridays for Future school strikes and Extinction Rebellion both launching that year.

But, in another sense, this period was merely an acceleration of the same technocratic regime. While successful in mobilizing millions of people around the world, these activist movements were fundamentally concerned with infusing the target-based climate framework with a sense of urgency and momentum. (Flags at Extinction Rebellion protests, for example, featured a stylized hourglass to symbolize that time was running out.)

Climate change became increasingly construed as an all-powerful, apocalyptic force, with temperature targets framed as humanity’s only hope for survival. Rather than advocating for new political frameworks or approaches, the need for urgent action itself became a kind of political demand. “Either we prevent a 1.5 degree of warming or we don’t. ... There are no gray areas when it comes to survival,” Thunberg put it ominously to an audience at the World Economic Forum in 2019. “We are playing Russian roulette with our planet. ... The battle for 1.5 degrees will be won or lost in the 2020s,” U.N. Secretary-General António Guterres warned in 2024.

If the post-Paris landscape *did* mark a new chapter in the history of climate politics, it was through a turn to green

industrial policy: state-led efforts to structurally transform the economy toward lower-carbon energy systems. Some of the first proposals for a Green New Deal date to 2007, when economist Thomas Friedman argued for a state-directed, economywide energy transition in the name of U.S. revitalization. But in the late 2010s, talk of a Green New Deal became more closely associated with leftist programs for public provisioning and redressing economic inequality. The centrality of a Green New Deal to U.S. Sen. Bernie Sanders’s 2020 presidential campaign was no accident.

With this expansion into the realm of green industrial policy, climate became inscribed within a domain of political contestation that had been effectively foreclosed when it was confined to the realm of international treaties. Suddenly, climate was subjected to classical political economy questions about coalition building and distributional politics. But it also meant that any climate policy successes would be hard-won and subject to the constraints of electoral politics, whose timescales were fundamentally incompatible with the urgency message of the mainstream climate movement.

Meanwhile, as the West was debating what a green energy future could look like, China was simply building it. One of the first indications that China was positioning itself as a major clean energy player came in 2006, when the 11th Five-Year Plan identified clean energy as a strategic industrial priority. In the EV sector, this translated to generous subsidies for Chinese-made vehicles and Chinese suppliers of lithium-ion batteries, combined with stiff tariffs on imported EVs. Within a decade, China successfully jump-started a domestic EV industry: In 2015 alone, Chinese plug-in EV sales jumped 343 percent; by the end of that year, BYD had become the world’s leading plug-in EV producer. A decade later, it was the world’s largest EV manufacturer by volume.

A similar story can be told about any number of Chinese-made green technologies: As of 2024, Chinese-made solar panels and battery cells accounted for 80 percent of the world market, and China accounted for about 60 percent of global wind capacity additions. The green transition is happening, just not on Western terms, under Western leadership, or for Western reasons.

China’s rise upended a central assumption about the nature of climate politics: When it came to climate action, the West would lead, and the rest would follow. The assumption was built into the original U.N. treaty architecture itself, which divided the world into the developed countries responsible for causing the problem and developing nations that would need to be cajoled and incentivized to adopt lower-carbon energy systems. Yet China’s turn to clean energy was not motivated by the normative framework of Western climate

politics of net-zero pledges, carbon markets, or the moral imperative of 1.5 degrees.

In fact, China had long complained that the international treaty process was merely a pretext for constraining the global south from developing and famously derailed the COP negotiations in Copenhagen. Instead, it pursued clean energy entirely on its own terms. What's more, China's model of state capitalism—insulated from electoral cycles and unconstrained by the need to negotiate with private capital—had structural advantages that Western democracies could not easily replicate. Even the hard-won 2022 Inflation Reduction Act (IRA)—the most ambitious climate legislation in U.S. history, with \$369 billion dedicated to onshore the various clean energy supply chains that China had come to dominate and to stimulate consumer-side demand—looked like a rounding error compared with China's state-directed industrial behemoth, which at the time of the IRA's passage was already producing 85 percent of the world's solar cells and three-quarters of all lithium-ion batteries.

Some have suggested that China's emergence as the decisive agent of change in the global energy transition signals a need to fundamentally rethink Western philosophies of history. But it would be more apt to say China's rise merely exemplifies some of the paradoxes that have always been at the heart of climate politics. Favoring the survival of future generations, for example, has always been perfectly compatible with an abysmal human rights record in the present (as when BYD was accused of maintaining “slavery-like conditions” during construction of its EV factory in Brazil).

Meanwhile, even as it became evident that averting climate change would require a structural overhaul of the world economy, the West insisted that the problem could somehow be solved without threatening the prevailing global economic order. And even as climate change was framed as an existential emergency, it was met with political mechanisms—international negotiations, domestic legislation, corporate commitments—that were necessarily slow, deliberative, and subject to shifting political winds.

If there is an irony to China's rise as a clean energy manufacturing powerhouse, it is this: The West spent three decades building the political, institutional, and financial architecture and popular demand for an energy transition. It dedicated enormous intellectual, political, diplomatic, and fiscal resources to the problem of mitigating climate change. Yet it is China that is now reaping the material benefits. It turns out, in other words, that the West was merely inventing a market for the products China now sells to the world. ■

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# What the U.N. Meant

In the great questions of war and peace, its role has visibly shrunk.

By James Traub

**AN OBITUARY FOR THE UNITED NATIONS** is bound to be premature. The U.N. may never actually die, if only because it is worth more alive than dead to its most powerful members—or rather, member. A case in point: Last November, Donald Trump, who has heaped more contempt on the U.N. than any other U.S. president since its founding, sought the blessing of the Security Council for his personal bid to end the Israel-Hamas war. The council agreed to his Comprehensive Plan to End the Gaza Conflict, 13 votes to none. (China and Russia abstained.) Trump can now claim—and apparently wished to claim—that his Board of Peace, which will direct this ill-fated plan, enjoys U.N. legitimacy even though no other permanent member of the Security Council has agreed to join it.

But just how alive does that make the U.N. and its chief diplomatic instrument today? The Security Council agreed to remove itself from a grave Middle East conflict in favor of a privatized body concocted by a world leader who regularly makes a mockery of the U.N. guiding principles. The plan to which it gave its imprimatur offers no role to Palestinian bodies and no long-term solution Palestinians can accept. It does, however, provide many veto points to Israel, whose actions in Gaza, according to an independent U.N. inquiry, constitute genocide. Only the United States and Israel regarded the plan's terms as just. Why, then, the vote? Because there was no better choice. As one intensely critical report on the decision noted, “Trump's plan constituted the only available mechanism for ending the suffering and stabilizing the situation on the ground.”

That was a new low. But the U.N. has been bumping downhill for a long time now. When I went looking for articles commemorating the organization's 80th anniversary last year, I was struck by how few I found. The U.N. no longer qualifies as newsworthy. The *New York Times* did run a story. Its headline read: “U.N. Gathers Amid Its 80th Anniversary and a ‘Free Fall.’” The author noted that the organization had been helpless to stop Russia's war in Ukraine or Israel's in Gaza—though, to be fair, the U.N. has rarely been able to end wars involving great powers.

What was new was that Trump had brought the world body's work on climate change to a standstill and devastated its humanitarian efforts through budget cuts. And then he

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beat up on the U.N. some more. Addressing the General Assembly in September, Trump complained that the U.N. brought nothing save “empty words” to global conflicts, leaving the hard work of peacemaking to him, Donald Trump.

The U.N. is not just the Security Council, of course. It is a norm-setting body that establishes rules around issues of human rights, common goods such as space and the seabed, and global problems such as climate and disease. It sends peacekeepers and political officers to hot spots around the world. Many poor nations depend on the U.N. bodies that offer humanitarian assistance and development aid. Yet in these functions, too, the U.N. cannot function without the funding and the active engagement of the big members, above all the United States. Only rarely over the last eight decades has it enjoyed that support, since the great powers have often been at odds with one another. The attitude of the United States isn’t the only variable; it is, however, the biggest one.

In his book *Mixed Messages*, international relations scholar Edward Luck wrote that the United States had been profoundly ambivalent about global organizations from the first debates over the League of Nations. If the United States was, as virtually all of its statesmen believed, an “exceptional nation,” global bodies offered the means to internationalize its domestic values and thus produce a global order in its own liberal image. Yet how could such a nation bind itself to the will of lesser, self-aggrandizing states? And why should a great power protected by two oceans limit its freedom of action by submitting to that will?

Joining the League of Nations, said U.S. Sen. Henry Cabot Lodge, its most relentless adversary, “would only cripple us in the good work we seek to do.” The body went down to defeat; the U.N. won Senate approval only after a second, and even more catastrophic, war had demonstrated that the United States could not stand apart from the world. But fears over loss of sovereignty, and over foreign entanglements, only went underground.

The U.N. had been constructed on the hope, barely plausible even in 1945, that the world’s great powers would act out of shared interest in preserving peace and stability. The organization was to enforce the international will through its own military, raised from members, and to lead a global campaign of disarmament. But the Cold War paralyzed the Security Council almost from birth. The founding vision lived on only through strange vestiges. One of the legends of Turtle Bay—perhaps it’s even true—is that the military attachés of the permanent members, as remnants of that dream, ritually convene every month and then immediately adjourn and go off to lunch.

Yet even though for its first 40-odd years the U.N. couldn’t do very much, it nevertheless occupied a cherished place in the liberal American imagination. The big newspapers

assigned their best reporters to the beat. The secretary-general was a prize get at the showiest New York parties. What mattered most about the U.N. was that it was there, the beating heart of the liberal order in New York City, the beating heart of the world. Somehow, scholar John Ruggie wrote, Presidents Franklin D. Roosevelt, Harry Truman, and Dwight D. Eisenhower had built a “conceptual bridge” between American exceptionalism and the idea of a global order.

The U.N. was that bridge. Even Presidents Gerald Ford and Ronald Reagan, both vexed by a U.N. dominated by the voices of the “emerging world,” cared enough about defending the U.S. reputation there that they appointed leading intellectual figures—Daniel Patrick Moynihan and Jeane Kirkpatrick, respectively—to do so.

Then the Soviet Union collapsed with shocking speed. Suddenly, both China and Russia wanted access to Western capital, know-how, and goodies. The impediments to Security Council action vanished. When Iraqi leader Saddam Hussein invaded Kuwait, violating Article 2 of the U.N. Charter, which guarantees state sovereignty against external aggression, President George H.W. Bush, a former U.S. ambassador to the U.N., won council approval to lead a global coalition to right that wrong. Soon, with very uncharacteristic euphoria, Bush was prophesying the rise of a “new world order” with the U.N. at its very heart.

Everything seemed possible in that new dawn. The Security Council authorized ambitious state-building missions in Cambodia, Haiti, and Timor-Leste. Peacekeeping expanded dramatically, in scale and scope, in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Sierra Leone, and Sudan. The world looked to the U.N. to “deliver us from evil,” to quote the title of William Shawcross’s 2000 book on the institution. But that was too much to ask; the U.N. had neither the military force nor the political standing its new role required. Peacekeepers proved helpless to stop a genocide in Rwanda and mass killings in Bosnia. Technocrats and rule-of-law experts couldn’t put Haiti back together again. It was precisely because so much was expected of the organization that its failures seemed so damning.

This was the moment—glamorous, melodramatic, pregnant with great hopes and great fear—when I showed up to the Secretariat Building. In early 1998, I was assigned to follow Secretary-General Kofi Annan to Iraq as he tried to persuade Saddam to give U.N. inspectors access to suspected weapons sites. The Clinton administration had asked him not to go; President Bill Clinton was prepared to bomb Iraq into submission. But so many—heads of state, religious leaders, New York socialites—implored Annan to do so. I described at the time the “moral romance” of this soft-spoken, solitary man of peace confronting the Iraqi lion in his den. Annan emerged victorious—“the most dramatic achievement by



a Secretary General since the era of Dag Hammarskjöld,” I wrote in the *New York Times* in March 1998. Then Annan returned to the United States to hear himself denounced as an appeaser by Senate Majority Leader Trent Lott.

The Annan era was a time of nonstop crisis for the U.N.—which is to say, an era when the U.N. still mattered very much. Liberal idealists looked to the world body to deliver us from evil, while right-wing cranks, some in the U.S. Congress, imagined a secret army of globalists plotting world domination from their black helicopters. The crackpots, as always, were more intensely mobilized than the liberals, and soon it was open season on the U.N. in Congress. In 2000, I watched U.N. Ambassador Richard Holbrooke cajole and seduce hardliners to pay back dues of \$1 billion. The General Assembly was threatening to revoke the U.S. vote. The prospect of that humiliation moved very few of them; what finally carried the day was Holbrooke’s argument that U.N. peacekeepers kept the lid on hot spots for a low price and zero U.S. casualties.

Yet even President George W. Bush and his team of bellicose unilateralists found that they couldn’t get along without the U.N. When British Prime Minister Tony Blair told Bush that he couldn’t join him in a war in Iraq without the blessing of the Security Council, Bush sought that blessing. Bush ultimately went ahead without a clear mandate, yet he turned to the U.N. again when the Iraqis refused to cooperate with their U.S. occupiers. Annan’s very reluctant acquiescence, like the council’s deference to the Board of Peace, made the U.N. seem simultaneously indispensable and ineffectual. The failure of that mission came very close to destroying Annan’s tenure.

That era of turbulence and tragedy is a distant memory. The U.N. continues to play an important norm-setting role—for example, through the Sustainable Development Goals, first issued in 2015—but to Western publics, which tend to measure the organization by its role in the great questions of war and peace, it has visibly shrunk. The U.N. did itself no favors by choosing the colorless and painfully cautious Ban Ki-moon to replace Annan in 2007, but Ban’s successor, Guterres, the more telegenic former Portuguese prime minister, has not restored the organization’s luster. It isn’t really the secretary-general’s fault: We seem to have returned, after a century’s interval, to a world in which great powers are prepared to wage war in pursuit of national interest. Article 2 of the U.N. Charter, sacrosanct in 1990, is in danger of becoming a dead letter. Financially, of course, the place is running on fumes.

So long as Americans thought of themselves as exceptional, the U.N. remained an instrument to be both used and abused. That once appeared to be a fixed part of the cosmos; now we know it’s not. Trump believes neither in binding global rules, as the liberal idealists did, nor in the transformative effects of U.S. power, as the neoconservatives did. He simply believes in power. The U.N. Charter treats sovereign equality as a sacred principle, but in Trump’s mind, nations have only as much sovereignty as they can force others to respect. Iran, not so much; Venezuela, none. Denmark is being captious in resisting his demand for Greenland. The president wishes to uphold neither global norms nor U.S. ones.

It’s true that Trump’s vanity is flattered when the Security Council bows before the Board of Peace. He even accepts the usefulness of some peacekeeping missions; according to U.N. figures, the United States has paid \$684 million for peacekeeping this year, leaving it only \$2.2 billion in arrears. On the other hand, Trump admits he’s still mad that the U.N. didn’t let him do the work on its renovation 20 years ago. He seems to think that the organization should be paying him instead of the other way around. Trump has plunged the U.N. into a fiscal crisis by paying only \$160 million of the United States’ assessed dues to the regular U.N. budget, for a total shortfall of more than \$4 billion. He has said he wants to see “reform,” but that appears to mean reducing the U.N. to a subsidiary of the Board of Peace.



Many of the most important U.N. members do, of course, continue to care about it very much: countries in Europe as well as middle powers such as India and Brazil. China hopes to inherit from the United States the role of protector of the world order, albeit a very different order from the one Washington created. Yet none has volunteered to help make up the shortfall created by the United States; China, in fact, has delayed paying its own dues. Everyone has fiscal problems of their own, but it is also clear that the long habit of permitting Washington to take disproportionate responsibility for the world order in exchange for exercising disproportionate control over it has now created a void that no one is likely to fill.

The U.N. was built to protect and perpetuate a liberal Western order that is now fading away. Perhaps it can be repurposed for a different order in which nonliberal, undemocratic states hold far more sway. In that case, however, it would be the U.N. in name only. I feel lucky to have been present at the last moment when the organization really mattered. We shouldn't expect that era to return. ■

**JAMES TRAUB** is the author of books including *The Best Intentions* and, most recently, *The Cradle of Citizenship*.

## Seek No More

The right to asylum as an artifact of a bygone era.

By **Linda Kinstler**

**ON THE FIRST DAY** of his second term in office, President Donald Trump issued a proclamation prohibiting all refugees arriving at the U.S. southern border from applying for asylum. Claiming that the “situation at the southern border qualifies as an invasion,” the order meant that all individuals attempting to come to the United States would be categorically refused entry, even if they risked being tortured or persecuted upon return to their home countries—a blatant violation of U.S. immigration law. Accompanying guidance distributed to U.S. asylum officers instructed them not to “ask specific fear questions” required to assess whether individuals had fled their nations out of a credible fear of harm. Only those who demonstrated fear without prompting, either verbally or otherwise, through “hysteria, trembling, shaking, unusual behavior, changes in tone of voice, incoherent speech patterns, panic attacks, or an unusual level of silence”—according to language from guidance issued by the Biden administration—could be granted further

assessment, but their petitions would also almost always ultimately be denied.

The proclamation was a bald-faced attempt to close the border to asylum-seekers writ large, effectively a death certificate for the right to seek asylum in the United States. That right has been in decline for many years around the globe, its force and meaning gravely diminished alongside the worldwide retrenchment of human rights. But over the past year, states across the global north have taken further steps to permanently degrade asylum protections, hardening borders and revising immigration policies to curtail the already meager affordances that imperiled groups have relied on for decades. If their efforts are successful, the right to seek asylum—a fundamental freedom and a critical element of the postwar system—will become an artifact of a bygone era, one of many casualties of the emerging anti-liberal global order.

Protections for refugees fleeing religious, political, racial, or national persecution were enshrined in international law in the wake of World War II. The 1951 U.N. Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees prohibited signatories from returning refugees to states where their “life or freedom would be threatened.” The 1984 U.N. Convention Against Torture further solidified state obligations never to deport individuals to countries where their lives would be endangered. The European Convention on Human Rights (ECHR), first signed in 1950, binds its constituent nations to guarantee any person inside European borders the right to a “private and family life,” allowing refugees to seek reunification with their kin inside the European Union.

These international agreements led to the creation of a robust bureaucratic infrastructure dedicated to ensuring that the right to seek asylum—an individual right possessed by every person, irrespective of origin or citizenship—had real force. Yet they did not establish a corresponding right to *receive* asylum, leaving it up to states to determine which peoples can receive permanent protections inside their borders. As a result, there is a “gap between the individual’s right to seek asylum and the state’s discretion in providing it,” as the U.N. Refugee Agency presciently pointed out in 1993.

Today, that gap has grown into a veritable abyss. In 2024, the most recent year for which U.N. data is available, the number of international migrants hit a record 304 million at the same moment when nations all over the world were closing their doors and war, natural disasters, authoritarianism, and gang violence were on the rise. More than half had traveled from their home countries to reach Europe and North America. That these two phenomena are occurring simultaneously is not a coincidence: The turn away from humane border policies is a direct response to rising demand for protections. In the United States, immigration



officers have for several years declined to give new arrivals “credible fear” interviews that would establish their claim to protection from abuse back home. If this trend continues, asylum risks becoming something that can only be responsibly referred to in the past tense.

Every week brings new stories of the Trump administration’s brutal crackdown on immigration and its depredations: a Bolivian asylum-seeker jailed for 17 months before ultimately being deported to the Democratic Republic of the Congo; Nicaraguan activists turned away by officials who refused to even look at their documents; Russians and West Africans sent back to countries where they will almost certainly be jailed or tortured.

Yet ongoing international efforts to significantly curtail asylum claims have not received commensurate attention. Pakistan and Iran have each pursued the mass expulsion of millions of Afghans who had sought safety inside their borders, creating what the United Nations has called a “multi-layered human rights crisis.” Last year, India threw around 40 Rohingya refugees into the sea. In Canada, a new law requiring asylum-seekers to petition for protection within a year of entering the country has left thousands of individuals facing the threat of deportation. After the retroactive measure went into force this spring, asylum-seekers who had not yet filed applications for relief received letters from the Canadian government directing them to “leave Canada as soon as possible.”

U.K. Prime Minister Keir Starmer recently revised his country’s asylum policy to remove guarantees of indefinite protection and housing for asylum-seekers in an apparent effort to appease his conservative constituents. With Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen, he has called for

the ECHR—to which Britain is still a party—to be revised to make it easier for European nations to deport individuals back to their home countries and to raise barriers to family reunifications. “The current asylum framework was created for another era,” the two leaders wrote in a joint *Guardian* op-ed last December. “We will always protect those fleeing war and terror—but the world has changed and asylum systems must change with it.”

Their message seemed to be that it is time to move on from the post-World War II settlement and the protections it established because they have become out of step with political realities. After all, the preamble to the

ECHR states that the convention’s fundamental freedoms are “best maintained on the one hand by an effective political democracy and on the other by a common understanding and observance of the Human Rights upon which they depend.” Both preconditions for the convention’s successful application—effective democracy and observance of human rights—have been significantly diminished across the continent over the last decade. Midcentury idealism, Starmer and Frederiksen implied, has no place in a world where right-wing politics are ascendant and the will to enforce international law has all but vanished.

Underscoring that point, Denmark and eight other European nations, including the Baltic states, Italy, and Poland, have also petitioned the European Court of Human Rights to make it easier to deport refugees who have committed crimes in their host nations back their countries of origin—even if those states have been deemed unsafe for repatriation. This summer, the EU Pact on Migration and Asylum is set to come into force. It seeks to fast-track the processing of asylum-seekers at the border. Refugee organizations warn that, in practice, the measure will increase the number of people confined to detention centers and that expedited evaluation procedures will make it far less likely that individuals will be granted asylum upon arrival.

In Europe, the only nation bucking this trend is Spain, which recently implemented a mass amnesty allowing immigrants to legalize their status in the country for the low price of 38 euros (about \$45). Individual applicants will receive one-year work permits, while families will be allowed to live and work in the country for no less than five years. Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez has framed this approach to immigration as a rejection of the



“zero-sum thinking of the far-right” and as an essential element of his country’s economic prosperity and “spiritual development.” The amnesty is the seventh measure of its kind implemented in Spain over the last 50 years. “When social reality outpaces bureaucracy,” a government spokesperson said, “the responsible state is the one that acts to regulate it, not the one that looks the other way.”

If that is the case, responsible states are rare indeed. Looking away from the rights, claims, and sacrifices of asylum-seekers has become the new norm. In many jurisdictions, this “looking away” takes a quite literal form, with immigration officials refusing to see or hear evidence of past persecution and politicians turning away from international laws that their predecessors bound them to follow. In the United States, the right to asylum has been almost entirely extinguished, with the processing of applications from 39 countries—including Afghanistan, Cuba, Iran, Sudan, and Syria—and the Palestinian territories subject to an indefinite pause. (The Trump administration has expanded its refugee program only for white South Africans and capped the total number of refugees admitted this fiscal year at 7,500, down from 125,000 in the previous administration.)

In late April, the U.S. Court of Appeals for the District of Columbia Circuit ruled that Trump’s ban on asylum claims at the southern border was a blatant violation of U.S. law. The majority opinion argued that the right to asylum was the “most protective form of relief” that immigration law afforded. To “unilaterally and heedlessly return individuals even to countries where they will most certainly face persecution,” the court argued, violated the basic rights of refugees to apply for asylum and to be spared the threat of deportation while their applications are still pending.

The decision was hailed as a rare victory over the Trump administration’s draconian policies, but in practice, it will likely have only a meager effect. It upheld the inviolable individual right to seek asylum yet will have little sway over the U.S. government’s apparent commitment not to provide it. If applicants cannot be sent away while their claims are being processed, the United States will only continue to pursue expedited and abbreviated proceedings and will keep asylum-seekers in detention while they do so. A similar dynamic will result from tightened immigration policies across the Atlantic. The right to asylum will continue to exist on paper, but the moral force and memory that once undergirded its meaning will have perished. ■

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## Party’s Over

A new political system will require new groupings.

By Anton Jäger

**“THE AGE OF PARTY DEMOCRACY** has passed,” Irish political scientist Peter Mair declared in a book posthumously published in 2013. He had spent his academic career peering at a specific organism in the life of humans as political animals—the party, with its leaders, members, functionaries, and voters, operating both in parliament and on the street. To Mair, who died in 2011, modern politics was hard to imagine without it; at times, he wondered whether democracy might survive its demise. Yet by the end of his life the verdict became irresistible. The species he dedicated his career to was threatened with extinction. The ecosystem might persist but now without its previously dominant specimen.

Mair’s statement still carried a sense of premonition at the time. Then, the effects of the global financial crisis were still rippling through Europe; Donald Trump’s ruthless takeover of the Republican Party was some years away. In 2026, however, his warning seems anything but trite, with both Labour and the Conservatives wiped out in the last U.K. council elections. In the U.S. and European political systems, it has become apparent that democratic politics will no longer be conducted with parties as traditionally understood.

On both sides of the Atlantic, parties do still appear as participants on election lists. Officially, the party landscape has enlarged rather than shriveled. If the major 20th-century parties were lumbering dinosaurs, their disappearance needs to be read against the rise of new creatures: digital outfits, one-man vehicles, so-called movement-parties, which had a shorter lifespan but could be equally active in their respective biosphere. As Mair already pointed out, however, such new creatures hardly seem deserving of the same name as the older ones they competed with.

To him, parties were not simply pop-up ventures for politicians seeking to win an election. Instead, as membership organizations, they were designed for longevity, persisting beyond a single media or election cycle. They were also the modern era’s emblematic tool for collective action, allowing elites to control masses but also offering a modicum of representation to the disenfranchised. As political scientist Christopher Bickerton notes, they could thereby be compared to corporate bodies under the ancien régime, entities that constituted the bridge between individuals and the state—with the proviso, of course, that parties were

voluntary organizations, unlike guilds or corporations, which coerced membership from cradle to grave.

For this very reason, in the 1930s, Italian Marxist Antonio Gramsci likened them to the modern prince—the only collective actor that could reconcile democracy and complexity. Parties, to Gramsci, stood at the juncture of two quintessentially modern processes: industrialization and democratization. This was the “dual revolution” that British historian Eric Hobsbawm himself dubbed modernity’s driving process. As agents, parties gave content to the form of democratic struggle. They acted as conduits between society and the state, translating popular wishes into policy but also providing personnel for the elite, allowing them to coordinate between factions of the upper class, who not only wanted to buy consent but also sought to reconcile differences.

Politics and parties thereby became near synonyms in the 20th century. Parties were “the organization of democracy,” as Italian politician Palmiro Togliatti saw it, indicating that without them, the body politic would lack a backbone. Later, economically minded political scientists began to cast parties as “public utilities,” or “semi-state organs crucial in the functioning of democracy.”

That parties and democracy would once become synonyms was not a given of political theory in the 19th century. The template provided by ancient democracies, for instance, had little place for them as a concept. Factions and shifting alliances might have existed in Athens, but distinct groupings with membership structures were practically absent. To many modern thinkers, democratic politics was the exclusive province of small polities with slave populations, willing to do the work while actual citizens engaged in the leisurely pursuit of politics. The other precedent for

popular politics was the dictatorship of a Julius Caesar or Napoleon Bonaparte, who sought plebiscitary mandates for their rule. Both shunned parties as dangerous factions.

The modern aversion of the party form took a while to overcome, even for elites who preferred parliaments over kingly rule. Throughout the 18th century, regular voting groups in the U.K. House of Commons were gradually classed together as opposing Tories versus Whigs. But they remained caucuses or clubs rather than clear organizational entities, and only in the 19th century did they begin to register as official institutions. For the most part, they were informal gatherings of elites that coordinated without binding.

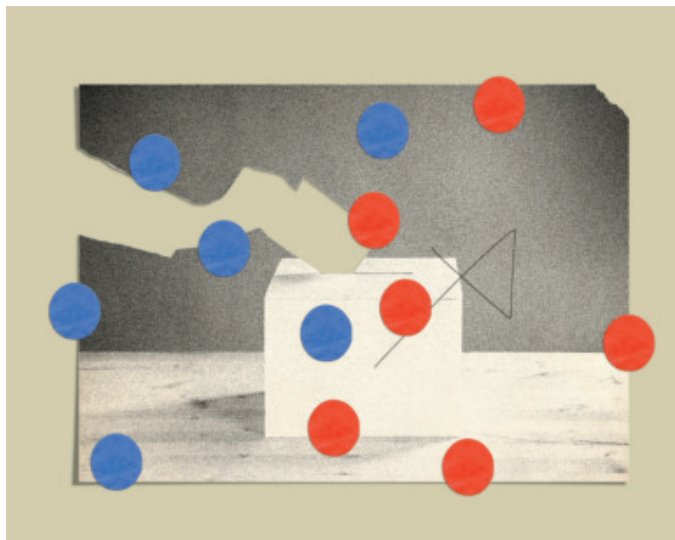
There was one weathered exception to this case: the United States. Already in the 1830s, Alexis de Tocqueville noted how the stability of U.S. democracy came with highly specific preconditions. One of them was the strength of party elites, willing to mobilize an electorate through machine politicking. “The skill of the actors in the political world,” he noted in *Democracy in America*, lies “in the art of creating parties,” and a “political aspirant in the United States” needed a party “to secure his popularity; just as the imprimatur of a King.” Europeans would come to democracy through their own route, Tocqueville insisted. It was simply not possible to re-create U.S. conditions on continental soil. But that parties would have to take on some kind of stabilizing function in European democracies was clear.

On the center right, Tocqueville long remained a lonely proponent of this insight. Instead, the idea that modern democracies required parties to live up to their promise was more prominent on the left. In 1848, Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels named their pamphlet “Manifesto of the Communist Party.” To both radicals, the workers’ movement would

remain trapped in empty protest or conspiratorial meddling if it lacked the steering organ of the party. The latter would give direction and body to what remained powerful but inarticulate instances of struggle. Only a clear superstructure could turn rebellion into revolution.

From the 1850s onward, after long internal squabbles, their call was heeded. Workers’ parties began forming across Europe’s industrial core. To socialists, the party became the indispensable vector for social change. It took conservatives a while to realize that the same might hold for those seeking to halt social transformation rather than accelerate it.

By the 1870s, conservative elites came round to Tocqueville’s admonition that the advent of democracy was inevitable but hardly Jacobin in essence. Instead, masses had to be made loyal to their states and hierarchies through parties,



which would offer ideological guidance and social benefits. If mass suffrage were a certainty, there would be few guarantees against social leveling; the only solution was to build a party structure that could withstand the threat against property that a widened suffrage would entail.

At repeated intervals, parties became an object of ire and ridicule in the interwar period. To many critics, they indicated an oligarchic drift away from popular rule. To figures on the right and the left, they represented a corrupt caste of bureaucrats remote from popular preference. Yet, to contemporaries, it was also nigh impossible to imagine a critique of this “partocracy” that refused the party form, visible in the many far-right outfits that themselves operated on the party model. The left and center saw parties as agents of both revolutionary change and potential stabilization. In Northern Europe’s Low Countries, a system known as “pillarization” enshrined parties as the chief mediators between citizens and states, even delegating tasks such as social security provision to them. In 1960s Belgium, critics could speak of a so-called *CVP-staat*, in which the Christian Social Party monopolized the entire political field.

In the most recent polls, however, the CVP’s successor is hovering at around 10 percent. The three remaining “pillar” parties—liberal, socialist, Christian—have long since lost their joint majority.

Accounts of this extinction event require a double lens—at once passive and active, long- and short-term. On the passive side, a changing political culture in which collective institutions were seen as unduly interfering in citizens’ private lives became prevalent. Yet more important was the economic crisis of the 1970s, in which the state seemed incapable of rendering a return to capitalist normality. The problem was believed to be that citizens’ hold on the state via their parties—their insistence on particular “special interests”—made a return to growth and price stability impossible. Through a concerted class offensive, and an empowerment of unelected bodies such as central banks, the preconditions for capital accumulation were restored, at the expense of parties’ claims to effectiveness. There was a delay between these blows and the death of the parties in question; hollowed out from the inside, the entities still appeared on election lists and in parliaments. Yet their legitimacy, and with it their inner life, had been diminished.

It took a while for the effects of this controlled demolition to become manifest. After 2008, the rot was revealed, and the term “Pasokification”—referencing the quick self-immolation of social democratic parties through their implication with austerity measures—became common parlance. In response, new parties were formed on the left and right, but these populist variants were again hard to compare to their previous mass opponents. They had no clear organizational

structures, appeared only vaguely mandated, and were as easy to enter as to leave. By the close of the 2010s, many left-populist figures had been kept out of power or had collapsed as political competitors.

Both push and pull factors thus deserve discussion here. On the one hand, the new digital era has made the type of political engagement required for parties—patient, banal, at times hierarchical, taking many evenings—much harder to demand. The new structural transformation of our public sphere, as German philosopher Jürgen Habermas termed it, has created a populace both active and fickle, while many parties now prefer to rule without mass membership altogether (as Keir Starmer’s Labour Party has so spectacularly illustrated). These concern the proactive ejection rather than passive retreat of members from parties.

What would a political system without parties look like? In the 19th century, it was said democracy without parties would inevitably result in the rule of strongmen across factional lines. Suggestions of such a system are now amply available across Europe. In the 1990s, Italy’s party system underwent the breakneck collapse from which it has never recovered. Into this void rushed the passively consumed “telepopulism” of Silvio Berlusconi, which replaced the organized involvement in politics typical of Italy’s postwar order. As one historian noted of the collapse of Italy’s Communist Party, “the effect of breaking up the mass parties was in many ways to ‘throw out the baby and keep the bathwater.’” From the center, Emmanuel Macron later carried out a remarkably similar feat in France, building a one-man politics on the burning heaps of the French party system.

By the 2010s, new creatures were starting to appear: digital parties with no clear dividing line between members and nonmembers, with digital consultation tools only vaguely visible to outsiders, a dependence on leaders who were more crucial to winning elections than the previous party platforms that leaders themselves were supposed to execute. These institutions might register as parties for elections and have a semblance of internal functioning. But they were hard to compare to their predecessors.

Announcements of the death of parties nonetheless sound slightly premature. Rather, they will continue to operate in a zombified state—still populating the state and providing a ladder for careerists, public relations jobs to consultants, and the occasional channel for citizens to voice grievances for which they will not find a reliable audience online. Yet as coherent units they seem increasingly anachronistic. One cannot clone a dinosaur, after all. ■

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# China Slows Down

Beijing's economic ambitions are brought down to earth.

By James Palmer

**FOR MANY COUNTRIES**, annual GDP growth of 4.5 to 5 percent would be a very good year. For China, which announced the target this year, it's setting expectations deliberately low. After more than three decades of sky-high growth—regularly topping 10 percent a year—Beijing's economic ambitions have been brought back to earth. And that has changed far more than just the country's economy.

Until the late 2010s, the entirety of Chinese life was shaped around the reality of high growth. People took on painfully high debt, confident that their salaries would rise to match it. They skipped out on jobs after two months because there was bound to be something better out there. In a world of opportunity, chance meetings could turn into life-changing careers—or you might fall victim to one of the con artists who also flourished in an era where easy payoffs weren't always a scam. That risk-taking culture itself helped once small businesses grow into international giants.

Golden decades were relatively common in the 20th century: France's "glorious years," Germany's Miracle on the Rhine, even the "Mexican miracle." But China's growth after 1980 topped them all, both in scale and length. China went from a country poorer than India to one challenging the United States, surpassing rival after rival: France, Britain, Japan.

Part of this was an elastic band effect; the disasters of Maoist policy had held the country back for decades even as Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan boomed. There was a lot of catching up to do: Just 18 percent of Chinese lived in cities in 1978, compared with more than 50 percent in South Korea. Chinese farmers had started to break away from collectivization in the 1970s, a move finally approved by the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) in 1979.

But Maoism's legacy was paradoxical; even as the CCP had stomped on the ambitions of ordinary Chinese, it had successfully introduced

nationwide middle school education that produced the hundreds of millions of literate, numerate workers the global economy needed. Deng Xiaoping and his successors, too, were unusually canny leaders, steering the country successfully through the financial shocks that rocked Asia in the 1990s. The Chinese diaspora steered money back into the homeland, reuniting divided families as Taiwanese or Hong Kong capital sought investment opportunities back in China.

A new prosperity washed through Chinese society at every level. Money reached the strangest places. You could arrive in a southern tea village to find houses sprouting satellite dishes or spot a lone, dusty skyscraper in a desert town. The "Four Big Things" of the 1970s—symbols of a household doing well—were a watch, a bicycle, a radio, and a sewing machine. By the 1980s, those were a tape recorder, a color TV, a washing machine, and a fridge, and by the 1990s, microwaves, VCRs, cars, computers, and freezers were the big-ticket items.

In other countries, economic booms brought carefully developed welfare systems, generous pensions, and universal healthcare. Communist China was far more cutthroat. If you dropped out of school, there were no nets other than family to catch you; parents reminded children at every chance that it was them against the world. Social benefits remained linked to restrictive residence permits: You could move from the country to the city, but good luck getting your kids into schools there or collecting your pension.

One of the biggest boons was the privatization of housing in the 1990s. If you were lucky enough to be assigned Beijing real



estate in the 1980s, you got to own it in the 1990s and watch it grow in value by 15 to 20 times in the next two decades. If you were a farmer, like most of the country, no such luck.

Yet growth meant hope—and risk. “Factory girls” flocked into the cities looking for something better than the fields their families had toiled in for centuries. College graduates skipped from job to job, sometimes four or five a year, confident that something better would come along. Fortunes were made through chance meetings on trains. Opportunity was cheap and failures easy to abandon; if you opened one successful restaurant, why not open another six the next year and then 60 and then 600?

Some advances came slowly and then all at once. Ration books lasted until 1993; by 1997, Chinese were eating more pork per capita than Americans. In 1976, when an earthquake hit the city of Tangshan in the middle of the night, it was easier for local officials to drive three hours to Beijing to tell party leaders in person than to find a landline to call them. In 1986, access to a landline, usually through an office, was still a treasured good, traded for favors.

In 1996, there were just over four landlines for every 100 people, and the fee for installation was several months’ salary. By 2006, mobile SIM cards were being sold on every corner, and students spent hours in internet cafes playing *World of Warcraft*. By 2016, half the country brandished a smartphone.

The end of the golden years arrived the same way as technological changes had: gradually and then suddenly. Throughout the 2010s, growth was slowing every year, from 9.3 percent in 2011—the last surge of a huge wave of government stimulus post-global financial crisis—down to just over 6 percent in 2019.

Then came the COVID-19 pandemic. Fearful of repeating what he saw as the mistakes of the 2009 stimulus, Chinese President Xi Jinping kept the purse strings closed. China’s household support was miniscule compared with U.S. generosity; nearly a quarter of those rural households lifted out of absolute poverty in the 2010s slipped back. Growth in 2020 was just 2.2 percent, and a dedication to the “zero-COVID” policy kept the economy in the doldrums throughout 2022, despite a brief recovery bump in 2021. The numbers started to look dodgy even by Chinese government standards: In 2023, youth unemployment reached such highs that the statistics bureau stopped issuing the figures altogether.

Most painfully, the pandemic burst the real estate bubble. In 2019, Beijing’s central real estate prices were rivaling Manhattan’s (while salaries stayed at around a tenth of New York’s). The implications of the collapse of giant firms such as Evergrande and Country Garden have not yet fully played out; the government continues to prop up nominal prices even as sales slump. Some 70 percent of Chinese household wealth is tied up in housing; to let prices fall to

actual market levels would be a shock to the middle class that the CCP couldn’t tolerate.

For China’s leadership, the slowdown is a political problem as much as an economic one. The legitimacy of CCP rule has rested on three pillars since the end of the Maoist era: the ideological claims of the superiority of socialism, the historical-nationalist claims of revenging past humiliations and restoring China’s global status, and the practical claims of economic growth and greater prosperity.

Economic success has been by far the strongest source of legitimacy since the 1990s. In the post-Tiananmen era, an implicit bargain emerged between the CCP and public: Don’t rock the boat, and the good times will keep rolling. Shaker economic times mean a less secure party in turn and more hope placed in the other two pillars—not always successfully.

As growth started slowing, Xi pushed an even more aggressive form of nationalism, pressing China’s maritime claims and encouraging diplomats to posture as “wolf warriors” online. That has diminished in the post-COVID era, although the drumbeat of “patriotic education”—and the destruction of minority culture—continues.

Efforts to revive Communist ideology have won little public support; Xi Jinping Thought is a tedious obligation and the attempts to make young people take Communist heroism seriously a continuous flop. Xi is protective of the pious fables of martyrs his generation was raised on, imprisoning critics as “historical nihilists,” but he can’t persuade anyone to go see movies about Maoist boy hero Lei Feng.

Xi’s main response to the end of the golden years has been his campaign for “common prosperity,” a failed attempt, replete with Communist clichés, to stop the growth of economic inequality. His chief ideological foe, meanwhile, is “welfarism,” which he associates with Western decadence and laziness; he loves the language of hardness, sacrifice, and austerity.

The problem is that for China’s economic model to shift, consumption needs to rise—the reverse of the golden years, when domestic consumption was deliberately repressed. While the CCP has made this an official priority, it sits uneasily with Xi’s own rhetoric—and with frequent government campaigns against the things people want to spend money on, whether that be private education or video games. The COVID years reinforced a belief in the necessity to save for bad times, and the fresh sense of economic insecurity has only encouraged that.

With each passing year, too, China comes closer to falling off the demographic cliff. The great fear since the 2000s has been that the country will get old before it gets rich. If it were just the workforce of the 1980s entering retirement, China might be able to cope, but the birth rate has also crashed;

for the first time since the devastating famines of 1959-61, the Chinese population *shrunk* in 2022 and has continued to fall every year since. However much the government tries to convince women to abandon their careers in favor of the patriotic duty of childbirth, women aren't listening.

None of this stops China being a world-shaking power. Even 3 or 4 percent growth in a technologically advanced middle-income country of 1.4 billion people transforms lives, from rural migrants still flocking to China's metropolises to Kenyan townsfolk running their new Haier TVs and microwaves off Chinese solar panels. But if you're used to the golden years, ordinary ones feel a lot grayer—and the future a lot darker. ■

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## Breaking the Rules

Dispensing with the performance of international law.

By Rosa Brooks

**THERE WAS A TIME**—not so very long ago—when world leaders felt obliged to lie to us.

They didn't always lie convincingly, but they went through the motions. When they violated international law, their lawyers produced lengthy memos explaining why, if you squinted just right, apparent violations weren't actual violations. When they invaded other sovereign states, they invoked the U.N. Charter's right to self-defense. When civilians were killed, they expressed regret and pledged to investigate. When they tortured detainees, they justified it as "enhanced interrogation techniques." States frequently ignored international law, but they took pains not to dismiss it outright.

These days, major powers often dispense with the performance of adhering to international law altogether. In January, Stephen Miller, the White House deputy chief of staff for policy, distilled the Trumpian view of the world: It's a world "that is governed by force, that is governed by power. These are the iron laws of the world." A few days later, President Donald Trump drove home the

point: The only check on his power, he told the *New York Times*, was his own morality: "It's the only thing that can stop me. ... I don't need international law." Meanwhile, in Russia, President Vladimir Putin declared last year that "no one is ready to play by rules set by someone far away"—certainly not Russia, when it comes to fulfilling the Motherland's "destiny" or completing the task of "gathering the Russian lands." Even China, usually more nuanced, has been abandoning the pretense that international law serves as a restraint. Reunification with Taiwan "cannot be stopped by any force or anyone," President Xi Jinping declared in 2019. Similarly, the Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs last year derided an adverse decision by the Permanent Court of Arbitration as "nothing but a piece of waste paper."

The old vocabulary of international law, with its invocations of universal values, now sounds antique. For all intents and purposes, international law is dead. Like the proverbial chicken with its head cut off, international legal institutions continue their frenzied activity, but no one expects them to matter.

But if international law is dead, who killed it? Was it Putin in Ukraine, with his talk of Russian destiny? Or Xi in the South China Sea, with his artificial islands? Or was the killer Trump, with his tariffs, his threats, and his war on Iran?

In truth, the story of international law's demise looks less like a game of Clue than the plot of Agatha Christie's *Murder on the Orient Express*: Everyone did it, and the victim mostly deserved it. It's tempting to pin the murder on Putin and Trump, but international law has been mortally wounded for decades—and many who claimed to be its greatest supporters struck some of the most devastating blows. By the





time Putin and Trump plunged in the final daggers, international law had become so riddled with internal contradictions that it had, in some sense, invited its fate.

Modern international law traces its roots to thinkers such as Hugo Grotius and Emer de Vattel, who envisioned natural law-derived rules governing war and sovereignty that would transcend kingdoms and faiths. As it matured, international law did at times function to restrain state violence, but just as often, it legitimized state violence, rationalized imperialist conquest, and excluded colonized peoples from the “civilized” community it purported to govern.

After the Holocaust and the stunning carnage of two world wars, the international lawmaking enterprise acquired unprecedented urgency, idealism, and ambition. The U.N. Charter, the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, and the Geneva Conventions all represented, in effect, a wager that sovereign states would trade a degree of freedom for greater security and embrace a vision of a more just and equitable world.

And it worked—almost. For a while. The second half of the 20th century saw a sharp decline in interstate armed conflicts. After a period of Cold War paralysis, the events of the 1990s briefly seemed to vindicate that daring postwar wager: The U.N. Security Council authorized peacekeeping missions, created international criminal tribunals to hold officials accountable for genocide and war crimes, and launched ambitious efforts to grapple with poverty, climate change, terrorism, and nuclear proliferation.

But the rapid expansion of international law and institutions had unintended consequences, supercharging the system’s internal contradictions—particularly the profound disconnect between international law’s commitment to state sovereignty and its commitment to fundamental human rights. Taking sovereignty seriously meant states could not intervene in one another’s internal affairs. Taking human rights seriously meant that such interventions might sometimes be required. As it evolved, the domain of international law became simultaneously vaster and less coherent, giving opportunistic actors ample room to exploit ambiguities and enforcement gaps while still gesturing toward compliance.

A certain amount of hypocrisy became accepted as part of the system. The Cold War powers were prodigious hypocrites: The Soviet Union crushed workers’ uprisings in Hungary while insisting it was liberating the working class; the United States devastated Vietnam while insisting it was defending freedom. When the Cold War ended, the hypocrisy accelerated. In 1999, NATO intervened militarily in Kosovo, then a semi-autonomous province of Serbia, on urgent humanitarian grounds, although most commentators agreed there was no legal basis for the intervention inside another state’s sovereign territory. The Independent

International Commission on Kosovo later judged the intervention “illegal but legitimate”—but once legality and legitimacy were disaggregated, the door was left wide open for an ever-expanding number of “extralegal” moves.

In 2008, when Western powers—despite prior diplomatic assurances that Serbia’s territorial integrity would be respected—recognized Kosovo as an independent state, Putin didn’t let this bit of Western hypocrisy pass without comment. He called it a “terrible precedent, which will de facto blow apart the whole system of international relations.” The Western states that recognized Kosovar independence had “not thought through the results” of their actions, he warned: “At the end of the day, it is a two-ended stick, and the second end will come back and hit them in the face.” He was looking forward to wielding that stick himself.

The United States ignored this, and the hypocrisy continued. The Bush administration responded to the 9/11 attacks by weaponizing legal indeterminacy: Its lawyers argued that torture wasn’t torture, indefinite detention was compatible with due process, and invading Iraq was consistent with the U.N. Charter. At the same time, human rights and humanitarian actors began to argue for a creative new understanding of sovereignty, arguing that the “responsibility to protect,” or R2P, sometimes required states to intervene in the internal affairs of other states. Structurally, this argument paralleled those made by apologists for the Bush administration. Officials asserted that if a state would or could not prevent its territory from becoming a staging ground for terrorists, other states had a right to use military force inside that state’s borders to prevent those terrorists from exporting violence. Advocates for R2P argued that if a state would or could not protect its own population from harm, other states had—at least in extreme circumstances—a right to use military force inside that state’s borders to protect the population.

The Obama administration repudiated many of its predecessor’s legal positions but embraced much of its logic when it came to drone strikes and other targeted killings. The administration also embraced R2P, relying on the doctrine to urge the U.N. Security Council in 2011 to authorize a humanitarian intervention in Libya’s civil war. Russia’s and China’s abstentions during the Security Council vote were initially greeted by many as a positive development for international law. In retrospect, Putin was simply sharpening the two-ended stick—and China was taking notes.

By 2014, when Russia annexed Crimea, Putin was ready to deploy the other end of the stick. He acknowledged that the United States and other Western states “say we are violating norms of international law” by annexing part of Ukraine’s sovereign territory but added: “What exactly are we violating?” The Kosovo precedent—in which Western powers trampled on Serbian sovereignty by recognizing Kosovar independence

—was one “our Western colleagues created with their own hands.” Fast-forward to 2022: To justify Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine, a still more blatant act of illegality, Putin again cited Western recognition of Kosovar independence to justify Russia’s recognition of so-called breakaway republics from Ukraine—and supplemented this by invoking humanitarian intervention to protect Russian speakers and claiming preemptive self-defense against NATO expansion.

China, meanwhile, was wrapping its baseless maritime claims in the South China Sea in the dense jargon of historical rights and administrative jurisdiction—and responding to U.S. criticism by noting, in 2016, that the United States is “always selective ... citing international law when it sees fit and discarding international law when it sees otherwise.”

The hypocrisy endemic to the international legal order wasn’t immediately fatal. In a system rife with unresolvable contradictions, some degree of hypocrisy arguably served as a necessary pressure release valve. And by taking the trouble to lie, hypocrites may paradoxically reinforce the power of the norms they are violating: As La Rochefoucauld famously observed, “hypocrisy is the homage vice pays to virtue.”

A virtuous legal system can survive a certain amount of vice. What it cannot survive is the wholesale withdrawal of homage. When hypocrisy spreads too far, becoming the norm rather than the exception, the law ceases to be viewed as legitimate—and when that happens, actors stop taking the trouble to be hypocritical. Call it the Tinkerbell Theory of Law: When states no longer even pretend to believe in international law, it dies.

So who killed international law? All the passengers on the International Express. The U.S. security state hollowed it out; liberal internationalists overextended it and generated a sovereigntist backlash, one with genuine democratic force. International lawyers spoke more to one another than to global publics. The Security Council immunized its permanent members. The global south, tired of an international legal system that encoded colonial hierarchy while preaching universalism, withheld the political support that might have saved it. Russia struck obvious blows, while China focused on patient subversion. And under Trump, the United States—once the proudest supporter of the rules-based international order—contemptuously rejects the idea of being bound by any law at all.

At the end of *Murder on the Orient Express*, detective Hercule Poirot allows the multiple killers to go free. After all, the victim had it coming. And at least to some extent, the same could be said of the international legal order.

Still, it would be a mistake to celebrate its demise. As a domain for moral reasoning about politics, international law was always imperfect. But it gave us a shared language, a discursive terrain in which states understood they had to

operate. However arbitrary or biased its rules, it offered a mechanism for resolving conflicts and reducing unpredictability in an otherwise anarchic world. The need to make arguments using the normative grammar of international law—even insincere arguments—constrained state behavior at the margins. International law offered focal points that reduced unpredictability, making states’ behavior more legible and crises more containable.

The demise of international law isn’t a moral loss; it’s a structural catastrophe. And it comes at precisely the moment when the collective action problems we face urgently require the coordination mechanisms we are losing.

We may even come to miss the hypocrisy and the lies, for a reversion to the Hobbesian “warre of alle against alle” won’t usher in a better or more honest global order—just a more brutal one. ■

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## The Foreseeable Future

Presentism, even nihilism,  
is the outlook of the age.

By **Jonathan White**

**“THERE’S ALWAYS PROBLEMS** in life. You know, there’s this problem, solve that problem, solve that problem. But, you know, there need to be things that inspire you. There need to be things that make you glad to wake up in the morning and say, ‘I’m looking forward to the future.’” Those were the words of Elon Musk, speaking just after U.S. President Donald Trump’s second inauguration. “I’m super fired up for the future,” he continued. “It’s going to be very exciting.”

In the space of just two and a half minutes, Musk mentioned the future five times. His speech stood out in part for its fervor: Who speaks like this in politics today? As a source of inspiration, the future often seems dead, having been replaced by nostalgia and crisis management.

At the same, it was a reminder of where the future lives on—among the zealots of Silicon Valley. As politicians turn away from the politics of vision, they cede the radical imagination to the corporate sphere, where it serves agendas that resist democratic control.

For two centuries, modern politics took its cue from the

future. Across the 19th and 20th centuries, parties and movements defined themselves by future-oriented programs of change. Short-term goals, such as improved conditions for workers, were paired with longer-term projects of transformation. For Karl Kautsky, a leading theorist of socialism and German social democracy in the late 19th century, it was all about clarity of vision: “All other political parties live only in the present, from hand to mouth; the Socialist party is the only one which has a definite aim in the future, the only one whose present policy is dictated by a general, consistent purpose.” What socialists pioneered, others would copy—the party as the vehicle of a long-term cause. Winning elections meant mobilizing the masses, and a manifesto for progress was crucial.

It was not just partisans but democrats in general who had reason to embrace the open future. Multiparty politics meant convincing those of different views to endorse the same institutions. On what grounds might people accept the results of elections that went against them—how could there be “losers’ consent”? One answer lay in the abundance of time: Those denied access to state power this time might claim it the next. From the perspective of the future, political fortunes could be seen as provisional: The defeated had reason to continue their involvement and hold back from violence when things went astray.

Things look quite different today. One sees politicians peddling backward-looking stories of greatness lost and forever firefighting the latest emergency. Presentism, even nihilism, is the outlook of the age. To the extent that officials do lift their eyes to the future, a preoccupation with quantitative targets and manageable risks tends to displace more encompassing visions of how things could be shaped. Whether it is objectives for growth or for decarbonization, the focus is on particular policies rather than programs of change. The future-oriented concepts that make an appearance—“recovery” and “resilience,” for example—tend to be vague and lacking in agency. No surprise that many tune out, caught between fatalism and frustrated impatience.

So, what led to the demise of the politics of the future? At one level, it is a function of turbulent times—why make plans when the world is in flux? Long-range speculation can look irrelevant. From financial crashes to pandemics and wars, it is the relatively near horizon that can look the most crucial.

Loch Johnson, a scholar of U.S. national security and intelligence, observes that security officials increasingly discount the long-range forecasts that their advisors prepare for them, preferring short-term forecasts that address the pressing concerns of the moment. Rather than peer into the distant unknown, policymakers want to be told “what happened today and yesterday, and what is likely to happen tomorrow.”

Especially for public officials accustomed to avoiding anything that smacks of ideology, a sense of emergency inspires a focus on immediate and practical steps. As international politics becomes increasingly multipolar, this redoubles the sense of a volatile world, too unpredictable to plan in advance for. Such views find their corollary in everyday life. For individuals trapped in immediate concerns—debt, precarious jobs, and on short-term contracts—planning for the future can seem like a luxury.

But this presentism also tracks how politics is now structured. If governments today are marked by the absence of vision, it is because power tends to be concentrated in the least ambitious. Sociologist Stephanie Mudge has traced how parties have evolved to marginalize their activists, where future-oriented commitments are typically strongest, in favor of leaders, electoral strategists, and policy advisors. Operations are run by those most focused on short-term success; opportunism is the name of the game.

The appeal of a more radical stance is evident when politics falls into the hands of an activist base, as with the Zohran Mamdani campaign in New York City. But for the most part, such groups are kept far from positions of influence. Party platforms and manifestos, once the stuff of bold vision, have widely been reduced to a catalogue of small goals, whose achievement or failure matters little.

British Ghanaian author Kodwo Eshun once observed that those who neglect the future cede this terrain to others who may use it against them. To shape hopes, fears, and expectations is to exert a distinctive power. “In the colonial era of the early to middle twentieth century,” Eshun wrote in 2003, “avant-gardists from Walter Benjamin to Frantz Fanon revolted in the name of the future against a power structure that relied on control and representation of the historical archive. Today, the situation is reversed. The powerful employ futurists and draw power from the futures they endorse, thereby condemning the disempowered to live in the past.” In other words: Those who fail to develop visions for the future are condemned to live in a world shaped by the visions of others.

The demise of future-thinking in contemporary politics coincides with its renewed embrace in the world of Big Tech. Consider Palantir CEO Alexander Karp’s 2025 book, *The Technological Republic*, nothing if not grand in its ambitions: “The engineering elite of Silicon Valley has an affirmative obligation to participate in the defense of the national and the articulation of a national project—what is this country, what are our values, and for what do we stand.” Karp writes scathingly of firms that seek only a quick profit, insisting on the need for a higher purpose: “Palantir itself is an attempt ... at constructing a collective enterprise, the creative output of which blends theory and action.”



Peter Thiel, of the same stable, addressed his 2014 bestselling book, *Zero to One*, to budding entrepreneurs, encouraging them to view the start-up as the “largest group of people you can convince of a plan to build a different future.” Corporate monopoly should be the goal, as the basis on which “to make the long-term plans and to finance the ambitious research projects that firms locked in competition can’t dream of.” Such figures cast themselves as seers with eyes on the bigger picture. Among Thiel’s investments today is Praxis, a company seeking to build private cities from the Mediterranean to Greenland, packaged as libertarian utopias for the rich.

Political manifestos may be largely dead, but corporate manifestos are not. Today’s Kautskys work in the private sector. A recent mission statement from Palantir was explicitly political in ambition, with an agenda including compulsory national service and long-term military spending. The text evokes history on a sweeping scale, charting the shift to a “new era of deterrence” built on artificial intelligence.

Another Silicon Valley tycoon, venture capitalist Marc Andreessen, published a “techno-optimist” manifesto in 2023 that likewise extolled the need to build the future on AI. “Technology is the glory of human ambition and achievement, the spearhead of progress, and the realization of our potential,” he wrote. “We believe we are poised for an intelligence takeoff that will expand our capabilities to unimagined heights. We believe Artificial Intelligence is our alchemy, our Philosopher’s Stone. ... We believe [it] can save lives—if we let it.”

These corporate actors seek to ensure that the future is imagined to their benefit, reserving them and their projects a central place. Many are the issues of public concern where social hopes and expectations can have material significance yet on which democratic politicians now seem so reticent. Big Tech and AI are areas where public input and control may clearly be warranted, but it will happen only to the extent that people believe regulation is possible and desirable.

Likewise in an increasingly tense geopolitical context, the old questions of disarmament and nonnuclear deterrence are as relevant today as to the peace movements of the 1960s but will have purchase only insofar as we can look beyond a future of automated systems designed for war. Reordering the economy to serve equality and democracy is as relevant today as in the 19th century, but that depends on seeing trajectories of change that are not those endorsed by corporate elites.

Democratizing the future means building new sites of imagination and collective power. As with the parties of old, politics needs places where people can organize and dream—where they can “look forward to the future” without being a CEO. The rich and powerful are already mapping and making the future they would like to see. Their opponents must do the same.

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An aerial photograph of Georgetown University in Washington, D.C. The image shows the university's historic red brick buildings with dark roofs and spires in the foreground. In the middle ground, the Potomac River flows, with a bridge visible on the right. The background features the city of Washington, D.C., including the Washington Monument on the left and the U.S. Capitol dome on the right.

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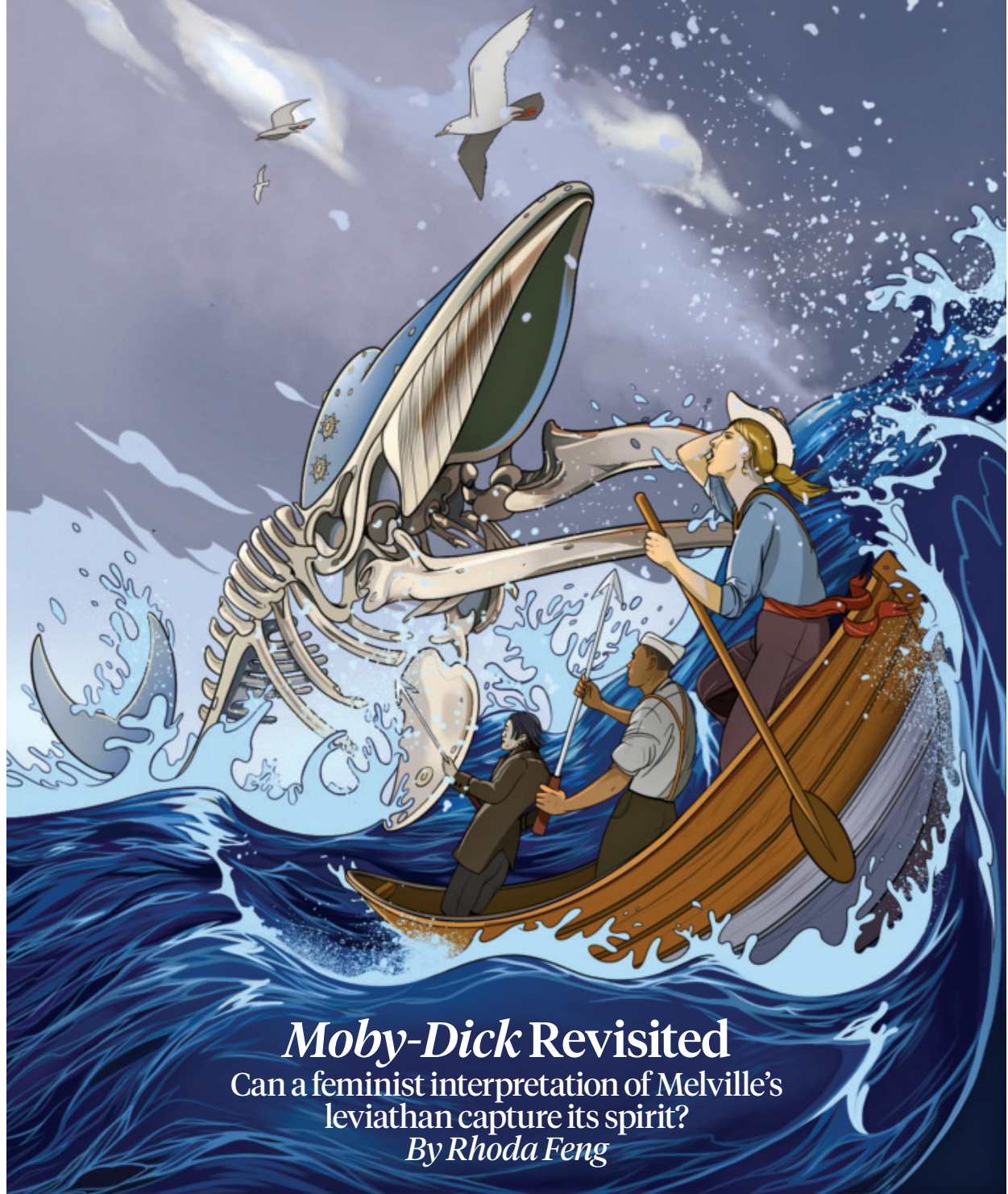


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# REVIEW

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## *Moby-Dick* Revisited

Can a feminist interpretation of Melville's  
leviathan capture its spirit?

*By Rhoda Feng*



The U.S. edition of *Call Me Ishmaelle*, marketed as a “feminist reimagining” of *Moby-Dick*, comes barnacled with blurbs. The Chinese British writer and filmmaker Xiaolu Guo “has gender-flipped this intimidating text with bravura and style,” the *Telegraph* proclaims. She “gives renewed forms of life to [Herman] Melville’s immense novel,” the *Times Literary Supplement* trumpets. And the *New Statesman* assures readers that the novel “defly incorporates philosophical questions about our relationship with nature and gender-dysphoria into the plot, constantly tugging at the heartstrings.”

Blurbs are one thing; seasoned readers know not to take them at face value. A subtler species of promotion lurks in the book’s closing pages. There, you’ll find a five-page list of discussion questions. This suggests not merely that the work deserves attention but that it has already been selected for the curated shelf of an anti-canon canon. One thinks here of calls in recent years to “decolonize” university syllabuses and the proliferation of novels that seek to reimagine classics—works such as Barbara Kingsolver’s *Demon Copperhead*, Percival Everett’s *James*, and Kathy Acker’s *Don Quixote*, which center on secondary characters, bricolage existing texts, and/or update their settings.

Distortion is the name of the game when putting any classic narrative through the Mercator projection of contemporary concerns. But there is distortion that delicately redraws the old coordinates, nudging their lines into newly revealing alignments, and distortion that sends the whole image lurching.

*Call Me Ishmaelle* unfortunately falls into the latter camp. Though reader guides can be useful in focusing discussion around more difficult or elusive books, the apparatus feels unnecessary in the case of Guo’s novel. *Ishmaelle* requires no interpretive scaffolding because it is a novel asphyxiated by clarity. The plot closely shadows that of Melville’s *Leviathan*: A wandering narrator goes to sea aboard a whaling vessel and falls under the command of a captain consumed by the pursuit of a single white whale, the same creature that once maimed him.

Readers familiar with Melville’s original will immediately clock the correspondences between Guo’s characters and those of *Moby-Dick*. The Captain Ahab analogue is Captain Seneca, a free-born Black man haunted by memories of his wife and dead child. He shares Ahab’s monomania, even diagnosing himself as a “single obsessional man.” Ishmaelle, here recast as a 17-year-old girl, serves as the principal narrator.

After recounting the outlines of her past—her self-denying mother (“She never ate before we had eaten.”) and her enslaved father, who labored in a shipyard—the novel

spells out its meanings with dutiful thoroughness. Chapters charting Ishmaelle’s voyage alternate with shorter, sub-Joycean passages assigned to Seneca, which aim for visionary intensity yet land closer to theatrical rehearsal. Clichés crumble off every page: Characters wake up “chilled to the bone”; thoughts stubbornly “lodge” in the mind; Seneca is “tortured by demons from his past.”

Ishmaelle herself often sounds less like a 19th-century sailor than a contemporary teenager in the throes of an identity crisis, lamenting that she feels like “a fraud and an impostor.” She possesses a relentless urge to underline themes rather than leave them to gather resonance on their own: “My existence here was a performance. I just hoped that in time my performance would become nature.” Several pages later, the refrain rears its head again: “And here I was, a phantom woman playing my role as a young burly man as best I could.”

At one point, Ishmaelle observes, “Everything on a whaling ship was reduced to the most rudimentary form.” The remark doubles, unintentionally, as a description of the book’s own method. In workmanlike fashion, the narrative pares down the elaborate architecture of *Moby-Dick* to its structural beams. In an interview last year, Guo described her project in unexpectedly pedagogical terms: “I feel I’m a communist educator. ... My purpose is to allow working-class peasants, farmers just to read this, to know actually this can connect to [*Moby-Dick*].” This tactic may well win her new readers, but it comes at a literary cost.

In casting herself as guide rather than, say, a translator or fabulist, Guo begins to resemble the “consumptive usher to a grammar school” whose notes officially open *Moby-Dick*—a figure more concerned with classification than with wonder.

**GUO’S OWN CONNECTION** to Melville’s classic may be discerned from her roots as a girl who grew up by the ocean in a Chinese fishing village called Shitang. Her father had been imprisoned in a labor camp; her mother, unable to raise her on her own, passed her infant to a peasant couple. That couple, too poor to feed a baby, soon handed Guo over to her grandparents.

Her grandfather, born in 1905, had once owned a small fishing boat painted with dragon eyes. After the Chinese Communist state collectivized fishing and a typhoon destroyed his vessel, he turned to scavenging shipwreck debris, drying seawater-soaked cigarettes salvaged from the Taiwan Strait. Embittered by political upheaval and personal loss, he drank heavily and beat his wife. Such violence, Guo recounts in her 2017 memoir, *Nine Continents*, was not an aberration in rural China in the 1970s. Her grandmother, meanwhile, was the picture of humbleness. A child bride sold at 12 for rice and yams, with bound feet and a bent spine, she moved through life with stoic gentleness.

Shitang itself was a place of salt wind and yellow-brown water, of kelp beds and swordfish, of loudspeakers blaring Communist songs and announcements of executions at dawn. There were no books in the house, no sense of a wider world except through the village stationmaster's tales of Mongol ancestry and Ming Dynasty pirates. Like her grandparents, Guo was illiterate; she would not learn to read until she was 8.

Guo's biological parents reappeared to reclaim her when she was 7. She left the sea for Wenling, where she grew up in a work-unit compound. Her mother, once a teenage Red Guard, was stern and practical. Her father, a soft-spoken painter trained in traditional ink techniques, was her quiet ally. He placed books in her hands—Hemingway's *The Old Man and the Sea*, a biographical novel about Van Gogh—and encouraged her early attempts at writing poetry.

Adolescence brought further trauma. At 12, she was sexually abused by a man in her village, an ordeal that lasted two years. Three years later, while in a clandestine relationship with a teacher, she became pregnant and had an abortion. Determined to leave her roots behind, she left Wenling in 1993 for the Beijing Film Academy, where she studied filmmakers such as Jean-Luc Godard and François Truffaut and absorbed European modernism alongside Chinese classics. After graduation, she set her sights on filmmaking, drafting screenplays that ran aground amid state censorship. Yet soap operas—politically anodyne, emotionally tidy—offered her steadier pay and fewer ideological trip wires. Nearing 30, she realized that if she wanted to make art that felt true to her creative instincts, she would have to leave China.

Guo moved to London in 2002. The transition was disorienting: rain, isolation, the sense of being a second-class citizen. (In a bar she frequented, she was repeatedly mistaken for another Asian woman.) Foregoing formal language classes, she resolved to teach herself English by reading and writing daily. Out of that self-imposed exile came her breakthrough novel, *A Concise Chinese-English Dictionary for Lovers*, written in a fractured English that traces a young migrant's love affair and linguistic awakening. The book announced her as a writer willing to inhabit grammatical vulnerability for the sake of art. Other novels followed, alongside films she

wrote and directed—works that shuttle between China and Europe, memory and reinvention.

**ON A STRUCTURAL LEVEL**, one can see what might have drawn Guo to *Moby-Dick*—a work that refuses containment, braiding together travelogue, philosophical inquiry, cetological taxonomy, and lyrical examinations of topics such as race and slavery and the “masculine sublime.” The historian C.L.R. James observed in 1953 that “the whale and whaling turn out to be a thread on which is hung a succession of pictures portraying the history of the world. ... [Melville] wishes to include in his book everything.” Closer to our time, the literary critic James Wood wrote that Melville, in his encyclopedic work, “nearly touched every word once, or so it seems.”

A sense of Melvillean wandering and restlessness—geographical, linguistic, formal—animated Guo's earlier work. *A Concise Chinese-English Dictionary for Lovers* milks monodegreens and other linguistic errors made by a non-native English speaker for comedy and insight. *Twenty Fragments of a Ravenous Youth* is a bildungsroman of a young Beijinger. *Radical* abandons linear storytelling almost entirely, unfolding as a cascade of fragmentary reflections from the author's time in New York. Part diary, part essay, and part linguistic meditation, the book traces Guo's thinking across questions of desire, migration, artistic freedom, and the constraints on women's lives—revealing a writer unafraid to dissolve narrative form to faithfully map the movements of her mind.

In contrast to those earlier works, *Call Me Ishmaelle* feels curiously contained. If Guo's departure from China once answered a desire for artistic latitude, this novel suggests a different pressure at work, one that leans toward legibility, as though the freedom she sought has been exchanged for a more dutiful accessibility.

The sea has long held Guo's fascination but reaches its own saturation point as a metaphor in *Ishmaelle*. What should feel like a boundless imaginative field often collapses into a narrow symbolic loop. Time and again, the narrative pauses to declare the ocean a mirror of human interiority: Standing at the shoreline near the novel's end, Ishmaelle reflects that “the sea has a great pull, we are of the land but still the sea is within us,” as thoughts flood “like a tide.” In such passages, the sea becomes less a living environment than a rhetorical device endlessly reiterating its own vastness.

Where Guo strives to distinguish her version of *Moby-Dick* is in the way she interpolates the *I Ching*. The ancient Chinese divination text—often translated as the “Book of Changes”—has for centuries served as both philosophical treatise and oracle. Practitioners consult it by casting sticks or coins, generating hexagrams that symbolize shifting patterns in the cosmos. Each hexagram corresponds to commentary about change, balance, and the cyclical nature of



*Call Me Ishmaelle*

XIAOLU GUO, BLACK CAT, 448 PP., \$18, JANUARY 2026, PAPERBACK

events. In the novel, a Chinese sailor named Muzi performs such rituals aboard the *Nimrod*. He explains that they reveal the “movement” of the universe, the unseen flow through which human lives pass.

This device might have provided Guo with an opportunity to stage an encounter between philosophical traditions: Melville’s Calvinist cosmology, haunted by predestination and divine wrath, alongside Taoist notions of flux and harmony. Yet the *I Ching* episodes rarely deepen the novel’s intellectual texture, functioning more as exotic garnish. When Muzi and Seneca perform a divination in the captain’s cabin, the ritual seems poised to illuminate Seneca’s obsession with the white whale. Instead, the moment fizzles into abstraction. The reader is told that the universe is changeable and mysterious, but the narrative itself remains stubbornly linear, bound to the rails of Melville’s plot.

A similar flattening occurs with the novel’s multicultural crew. Guo clearly intends the *Nimrod* to resemble a floating microcosm of the 19th-century maritime world: Sailors from Polynesia, China, Africa, and Europe share cramped quarters, exchanging fragments of macaronic language. At moments, this cosmopolitanism produces flashes of interest. The Polynesian harpooner Kauri, for instance, carries with him burial customs from his homeland. When he falls ill, he asks the ship’s carpenter to build a canoe-coffin in which his body can be set adrift on the sea, according to his people’s rites. The scene is strange and memorable: A coffin fashioned for death becomes an object of speculation among the sailors, even a potential flotation device if someone falls overboard.

Yet even here the writing lists toward the declarative. Cultural difference is explained rather than dramatized; characters speak as if summarizing their own anthropological significance. Muzi patiently expounds Taoist philosophy. Kauri recounts the punitive rituals of his tribe. The most disturbing subplot—the repeated sexual assault of Ishmaelle by the steward Mr. Flaherty—also illustrates this tendency toward bluntness. In one harrowing passage, Flaherty forces himself on Ishmaelle while she debates whether killing him would lead to her own execution by the crew. Ishmaelle curses a world in which men rule through “absurd desires and pointless ambitions,” denouncing God and patriarchy in the same breath. Even the resolution of this storyline arrives in schematic fashion. Flaherty disappears on a stormy night, apparently swept overboard—though the narrative hints that a crew member may have helped the sea claim him as punishment.

These episodes suggest the difficulty Guo faces in adapting such a heterogeneous novel. *Moby-Dick* thrives on digression, contradiction, and linguistic extravagance; its symbols expand outward until they threaten to engulf the narrative



An undated book illustration from *Moby-Dick*.

itself. *Call Me Ishmaelle*, by contrast, is driven by a centripetal force that leaves little room for ambiguity. One can sense Guo’s admirable intention: to open Melville’s maritime epic to readers who might find the original forbidding and to refract its myth through a global perspective. But in smoothing away Melville’s excesses, she also smooths away the friction that gives his book its wild electricity. What remains is a narrative that echoes the shape of *Moby-Dick* while rarely capturing its unruly spirit.

In *Moby-Dick*, Ishmael observes that “some certain significance lurks in all things, else all things are little worth, and the round world itself but an empty cipher.” The phrase “some certain” sounds a note of hesitancy: The significance that “lurks in all things” is not immediately apprehensible or describable. Other recent adaptations of and meta-forays into the novel have tended to work with rather than against that instability or else have sought to distill its sprawl in ways that preserve, rather than foreclose, its interpretive richness.

The behemoth has inspired any number of works across media, including puppetry, theater, and fiction. Sena Jeter Naslund’s 1999 novel, *Ahab’s Wife: or, The Star-Gazer*, for instance, retells the story from a woman’s vantage, using its revisionary premise to spin out an independent life for its narrator that both converses with and escapes the gravitational pull of Ahab’s quest. Jake Heggie’s production at the Metropolitan Opera last year focused on the emotional countercurrents provided by one crewmember’s resistance to Ahab’s obsessive pursuit while translating Melville’s expansive cosmos into choral surges and shifting musical textures.

Artists, it’s safe to assume, will continue to return to this touchstone of American literature because it carts not a single meaning but a surplus of them—an unsettled field that each new version must navigate by deciding what to change, what to heighten, what to de-emphasize, and what to leave eloquently unresolved. ■

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## The Charisma Wars

Why personality now trumps  
policy in global politics.  
*By Bobby Ghosh*

**I**n November 1985, Mikhail Gorbachev arrived at his first summit with U.S. President Ronald Reagan looking and sounding nothing at all like any previous Soviet leader. This was no dour apparatchik in an oversized coat, dispensing dull Marxist monologues. Gorbachev wore sharp suits, smiled for cameras, and spoke in snappy sound bites. The makeover worked: A global audience was wowed by the Russian, arguably even more than his U.S. counterpart. It was the start of a phenomenon that would come to be termed “Gorbymania.”

The irony was rich. Here was the general secretary of the Soviet Communist Party—supposedly representing workers of the world—challenging, even exceeding, the charisma of a former Hollywood actor. It was an early warning that the rules of international politics were changing in ways the cold warriors didn’t fully understand. The medium was becoming the message, and the messenger was becoming the medium.

Soviet leader  
Mikhail Gorbachev  
tips his hat to U.S.  
President Ronald  
Reagan as he arrives  
at a summit in Geneva  
on Nov. 19, 1985.

**HENDRIK W. OHNESORGE’S** magisterial new book, *Soft Power and Charismatic Leadership in German-American Relations*, arrives at precisely the right moment to explain what has happened since. In more than 800 densely researched pages, the University of Bonn political scientist does something remarkable: He takes Joseph Nye’s celebrated concept of “soft power”—the ability to attract rather than coerce—and demonstrates that in the 21st century, the personality of leaders has

become the single-most important variable in how that power operates. More importantly, he shows why this represents a fundamental shift from the 20th century, when ideology, culture, and institutions did most of the heavy lifting.

When Nye popularized the phrase “soft power” in 1990, it was still possible to think of it primarily in terms of culture (Hollywood, jazz, blue jeans), values (democracy, human rights), and policies (the Marshall Plan, international institutions). The personalities of individual leaders mattered—think of John F. Kennedy or Reagan—but they were more like the cherry on top of an already impressive sundae. The soft power of the United States derived fundamentally from what it was, not who led it.

This is why a dour Richard Nixon or a sanctimonious Jimmy Carter didn’t fundamentally damage U.S. attraction abroad. The Cold War binary was so stark, the ideological contest so all consuming, that individual presidential personalities were secondary concerns. Even Leonid Brezhnev’s spectacular dullness couldn’t undermine Soviet soft power among true believers; the ideology carried the weight. It didn’t matter that the man was about as charismatic as a cement block.

But that world is gone. And Ohnesorge’s book—drawing on five centuries of German-U.S. relations but focusing intensively on Bill Clinton, George W. Bush, Barack Obama, and Donald Trump—demonstrates why personality now matters more than ever.

The numbers tell a devastating story. As Ohnesorge shows, when Bush left office in 2009, German approval of the United States had cratered to historic lows. When Obama arrived, approval ratings skyrocketed overnight. The swing had nothing to do with U.S. culture (still globally dominant) or values (unchanged) or even policies (continuity on many fronts). It was pure personality effect. Obama’s charisma became what Ohnesorge calls a “fourth resource” of soft power, joining Nye’s original trinity.

The Trump years confirmed the pattern in reverse. Between 2017 and 2021, every indicator of U.S. soft power toward Germany collapsed—United Nations voting coincidence, public approval—not because U.S. universities got worse or Hollywood stopped making movies but because

**When soft power resided in culture and institutions, it was resilient. But when soft power became personalized, it turned brittle.**

of one man’s spectacular unsuitability for global leadership. As Ohnesorge puts it with characteristic understatement, Trump’s presidency represents “a study in soft power squared”—meaning soft power loss squared, catastrophically multiplied.

Why does personality matter so much more now? The answer lies in the fragmentation of the global information ecosystem and the celebrity-fication of politics everywhere.

During the Cold War, soft power operated mostly through institutions: cultural centers, exchange programs, international broadcasting. These were slow-burn, long-term investments that created diffuse attraction over time. Leaders could be boring because the institutions did the work. The BBC World Service and Radio Free Europe didn’t need charismatic directors; they needed credible content.

Today, leaders are the content. In an age of social media, 24-hour news cycles, and TikTok diplomacy, political leaders have become celebrities whether they like it or not—and the smart ones very much like it. As Anders Wivel and Caroline Howard Gron argue in their pathbreaking work *Charismatic Leadership in Foreign Policy*, modern leaders engage in constant “communicative practices” that make sense of “who ‘we’ are and where we are going.”

This isn’t optional anymore. It’s the job.

India’s Narendra Modi is a master of political theater, Emmanuel Macron positions himself as Europe’s philosopher king. Among those who have recently exited high office, Canada’s Justin Trudeau and New Zealand’s Jacinda Ardern built global profiles that far exceeded their countries’ geopolitical weight. They’ve all read the same playbook: In a celebrity-obsessed age, charisma is policy.

This creates a dangerous vulnerability that the Cold War’s institutional soft power didn’t have. When soft power resided in culture and institutions, it was resilient. But when soft power became personalized, it turned brittle. What Ohnesorge calls a “soft power pendulum” swings wildly with each election: Clinton’s charm to Bush’s catastrophe to Obama’s restoration to Trump’s demolition. Four-year (or eight-year) cycles aren’t long enough to build anything sustainable. Allies can’t plan. Adversaries can wait it out.

Juliet Kaarbo, a foreign-policy scholar at the University of St. Andrews who has written extensively on leader personality



*Soft Power and Charismatic Leadership in German-American Relations*

HENDRIK W. OHNESORGE, SPRINGER, 828 PP., \$219.99, DECEMBER 2025





# Weekend

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and decision-making, warns of an even darker possibility in her research: Leaders' personalities can change over time, usually for the worse. Power corrupts, yes, but extended time in office also makes leaders more authoritarian, more overconfident, more prone to catastrophic mistakes. When soft power depends on personal charisma, and charisma curdles into narcissism, entire nations pay the price.

The solution? There isn't an easy one. We can't uninvent social media or reverse the celebrity-fication of politics. What we can do is understand the game that's being played. Ohnesorge's book offers a brutal clarity: In the 21st century, who leads matters as much as what they lead. Maybe more.

This puts democracy at both an advantage and a disadvantage. Democracies can elect charismatic leaders, but they can also elect Trump. Autocracies can manufacture charisma through propaganda, but the artifice eventually shows. The question is which system can consistently produce leaders who understand that, in an age of celebrity, gravitas matters more than glitz and real charisma comes from genuine connection rather than manufactured spectacle.

On this, Ohnesorge, drawing on Max Weber's century-old insights about charismatic authority, offers a sobering reminder: Charisma is morally neutral. It can serve democracy or destroy it. It worked for Winston Churchill and for Adolf Hitler. For JFK and for Benito Mussolini.

**IN THE LONG RUN**, though, there is reason to hope that democracies will always prove more charismatic. Gorbachev discovered too late that his Western-friendly persona couldn't save the Soviet Union because there was no substance beneath the style. The real lesson isn't that personality doesn't matter. It's that personality without policy is just performance art. And in the long run, audiences can tell the difference.

The irony is that in trying to compete on charisma, authoritarians have already conceded the argument. They've admitted that attraction beats coercion, that being liked matters more than being feared. That's a victory for soft power. The question is whether democracies can field leaders charismatic enough to actually win the competition they've already theoretically won.

In the charisma wars of the 21st century, everyone's a combatant. May the most authentic win. ■

**BOBBY GHOSH** is a geopolitics analyst and commentator.

**The real lesson isn't that  
personality doesn't matter.  
It's that personality without  
policy is just performance art.**



# LIBERIA ON THE GLOBAL STAGE



Investment Reform, UN Security Council Leadership,  
and Multilateral Engagement



# A STABLE ECONOMY, READY FOR INVESTMENT

*After more than a decade of democratic continuity and economic reform, Liberia is entering a new phase defined by stability, peaceful electoral transitions, and a concerted shift toward long-term investment readiness.*

**HIS EXCELLENCY  
JOSEPH NYUMA BOAKAI, SR.  
PRESIDENT OF THE REPUBLIC OF LIBERIA**



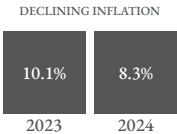
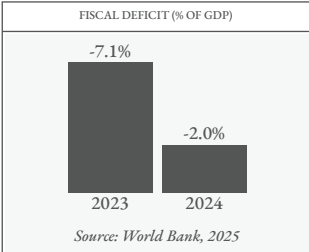
Under the leadership of President Joseph Nyuma Boakai, Sr., Liberia stands at a defining moment, anchored in stability, guided by reform, and open to purposeful partnership.

This report reflects the country’s commitment to disciplined governance, inclusive growth, and credible engagement on the global stage. As Liberia assumes greater responsibility within the international community, including on the United Nations Security Council, it invites partners to join in translating opportunity into lasting progress for Liberia and for shared prosperity.

**L**ocated on the West African coast and bordered by the Atlantic Ocean, Liberia occupies a strategic position within regional and global trade networks. At a time when investors are increasingly prioritizing predictability and institutional credibility, Liberia’s natural resource base, access to regional markets, and improving economic fundamentals place it alongside a group of emerging economies attracting renewed investor attention.

Central to Liberia’s investment case is its recent record of democratic continuity. Three consecutive peaceful elections have reinforced institutional legitimacy and reduced political risk, helping to establish a stable operating environment for businesses and investors. This consistency has supported stronger governance practices and policy coherence, increasing confidence among domestic stakeholders as well as international and private-sector partners.

Building on this foundation, Liberia has pursued focused macroeconomic and governance reforms aimed at improving transparency, strengthening fiscal discipline, and reinforcing policy credibility. International assessments point to stronger macroeconomic fundamentals alongside the need for sustained investment to translate stability into broader economic opportunity.



Source: World Bank, 2025

Within this framework, Liberia’s economic strategy places the private sector at the center of growth and job creation. Policy priorities emphasize employment generation and productive investment as essential complements to macroeconomic stability, reflecting an economic model in which private capital plays a key role in advancing development objectives and economic resilience.

As Liberia enters this next phase, the country is combining the gains of political stability and macroeconomic discipline with reforms designed to support long-term, productive investment. In a more uncertain global environment, Liberia’s emphasis on continuity and institutional credibility positions it as a stable destination for investors seeking sustainable engagement rather than short-term wins.

**“Liberia’s fiscal position has strengthened significantly, moving from a primary deficit in 2023 to a primary surplus in 2024 as a result of tighter spending controls and more disciplined cash management.”**

**Hon. Augustine Kpehe Ngafuan**

Minister of Finance and Development Planning





# GLOBAL LEADERSHIP AS ECONOMIC DIPLOMACY

## *Liberia's Role on the United Nations Security Council*

In a period marked by geopolitical tension and declining confidence in international cooperation, Liberia approaches multilateral diplomacy with a clear conviction that durable solutions emerge from dialogue, cooperation, and collective responsibility. As global systems face fragmentation and uncertainty, the country remains a steady advocate for institutions that prevent conflict and address its underlying causes.

*Liberia approaches multilateral diplomacy with a clear conviction that durable solutions emerge from dialogue, cooperation, and collective responsibility.*

Liberia's historic election to the United Nations Security Council reflects growing international confidence in its political stability and governance trajectory. During the 2025 United Nations General Assembly, President Joseph Nyuma Boakai, Sr., highlighted the need to renew multilateralism as a cornerstone of a just and peaceful world. On the Council, Liberia views its role as a principled bridge-builder, working to strengthen Africa's influence in global peace and security deliberations.

Liberia's international diplomacy and peacekeeping strategy is shaped by lived experience. Having emerged from conflict and navigated recovery and reconciliation, the country brings a grounded and pragmatic perspective to global peace and security discussions. The core idea of this approach is that conflict resolution must be nationally owned and regionally supported through inclusive processes that engage governments, civil society, women, and youth.

**“Liberia's approach to peace and security is shaped by lived experience. Having emerged from fourteen years of civil conflict, we understand that sustainable peace cannot be achieved through military measures alone.**

Hon Sara Beysolow Nyanti  
Minister of Foreign Affairs



Within the Council, Liberia seeks to advance a coordinated African position, recognizing that Africa's credibility is strongest when its priorities are shared and articulated with consistency. Acknowledging that security challenges are often cross-border and interconnected, Liberia advocates for strong regional leadership through institutions such as ECOWAS and the African Union, supporting cooperation that reinforces stability, trade, and investment.

Beyond the Security Council, Liberia views its broader role within the international system as that of a responsible, constructive, and values-driven partner. By approaching diplomacy as a platform for partnership rather than confrontation, Liberia reinforces institutional trust and aligns its global engagement with the same principles of credibility, coherence, and long-term confidence that underpin its economic strategy.

## LIBERIA'S STRATEGIC PRIORITIES ON THE UN SECURITY COUNCIL



# FROM POLICY TO PARTNERSHIP: PRIORITY INVESTMENT OPPORTUNITIES

*Economic Diplomacy in Support of National Development Agenda*

**L**iberia's approach to investment is grounded in clear national priorities. Through the ARREST Agenda for Inclusive Development, the government has identified sectors where private capital can support job creation, generate revenue, and strengthen domestic productive activity. Rather than pursuing capital inflows in isolation, Liberia's economic diplomacy emphasizes partnerships that deepen local value chains and support higher-value production. The result is an investment environment oriented toward sustained economic contribution, where commercial returns and national development priorities are aligned.

## Agriculture & Agro-Processing

Agriculture remains a foundational sector in Liberia's economy, employing nearly 40 percent of the workforce and anchoring food systems, exports, and rural incomes. The country's investment focus is increasingly directed toward agro-processing and related activities that can raise productivity and capture greater value within domestic supply chains. Liberia offers a compelling platform for agribusiness investment, supported by favorable agro-ecological conditions and more than 19,000 square kilometers of land available for commercial expansion. These fundamentals support primary production and higher-value activities, including processing, storage, packaging, and distribution. To support this transition, Liberia has established Special Economic Zones and agro-industrial parks that offer tax incentives, duty waivers, and improved logistics, lowering entry barriers for investors seeking scale. By prioritizing processing capacity, supply-chain integration, and access to regional and international markets, Liberia is positioning agriculture as a commercially viable engine of growth with the potential to deliver both returns and long-term economic resilience.



Sources: National Investment Commission (NIC);  
ARREST Agenda for Inclusive Development (2025–2029)

FP Editorial had no part in the creation of this content.

## Natural Resource Management

Liberia's natural resources underpin a significant share of its economic potential, but the country's investment proposition is increasingly defined by how these assets are governed and leveraged for long-term growth. Natural resource management in Liberia is oriented toward predictability, transparency, and productive use, creating investment-ready systems that extend beyond extraction.

In the mining sector, an established export base sits alongside a growing emphasis on strengthening local linkages and enabling infrastructure. Ongoing mining activity generates sustained demand for reliable power, transport, and logistics, reinforcing the case for investment across supporting systems. Policy reforms have focused on clearer rules of engagement and responsible operations, strengthening confidence for investors with long planning horizons.



Renewable energy represents a distinct and scalable investment opportunity. Liberia possesses abundant, underutilized hydropower potential, alongside strong solar resources suitable for grid-scale, mini-grid, and hybrid systems. Official estimates suggest that more than 2,000 megawatts of hydropower potential remain undeveloped, highlighting significant room for expansion. With low current penetration, the sector offers first-mover advantage, supported by productive demand from mining, agro-processing, small and medium-sized enterprises, and urban services. Renewables are positioned as least-cost, commercially viable solutions central to Liberia's development trajectory. Public-private partnerships remain the preferred delivery model, creating defined entry points for private capital while aligning returns with national priorities.

Image Credit: Agricultural Field by Bokehuh, 2019, istock,  
Solar Panel by PixelCatchers, 2022, istock

## Tourism



Tourism is one of Liberia's most underdeveloped yet high-potential sectors, offering significant opportunity for early, long-term investors. With over 680 kilometers of Atlantic coastline, extensive rainforest coverage, and a diverse cultural and heritage landscape, Liberia is well positioned for eco-tourism, coastal hospitality, and heritage-led development. The Government of Liberia has identified tourism as a priority sector within the ARREST Agenda, recognizing its potential to generate employment, support small and medium enterprises, and stimulate regional economic activity. Investment opportunities span beachfront resorts, eco-lodges, adventure tourism, and supporting infrastructure, particularly in coastal areas with improving air and road connectivity. Land availability near locations such as Buchanan, Marshall, and Robertsport lowers barriers to entry for private developers. Public-private partnerships are the preferred delivery model, with long-term leases, targeted incentives, and regulatory support designed to de-risk early-stage projects and encourage durable, employment-generating investment.

Mr. Michiel van der Merwe  
CEO ArcelorMittal Liberia



**“Even though Liberia has had twenty years of peaceful democratic governance, major international companies still view the country through the lens of its civil instabilities that ended in 2003.”**

Image Credit: Liberia, by Dan-Manila, 2020, istock

FP Editorial had no part in the creation of this content.

## STABILITY BY DESIGN

*Stability, Stewardship, and Economic Confidence*

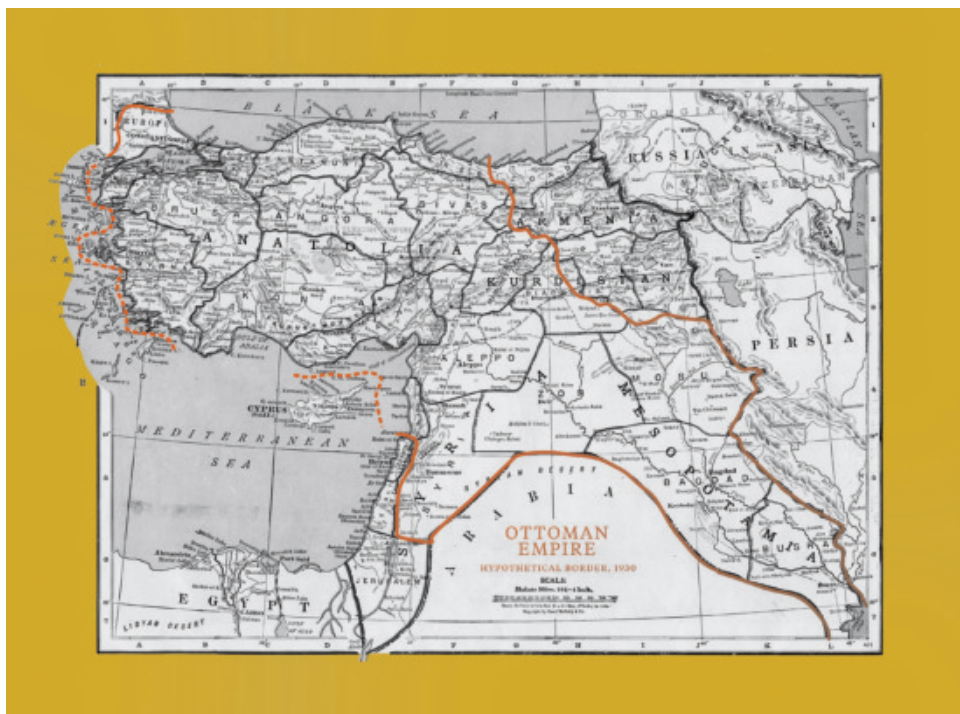
Liberia's recent stability is not accidental. It reflects a series of targeted policies aimed at restoring confidence in institutions and managing the economy with discipline. Through governance reform and fiscal stewardship, Liberia has reduced risk and protected recent gains. This approach signals the country's understanding that sustained stability is essential for long-term investment and economic confidence. Liberia's reform approach is sequenced and credibility-driven, prioritizing continuity over disruption. At its core is an agenda focused on strengthening institutions and improving policy coherence. Clearer rules and a commitment to transparency are reinforcing predictability for economic actors and investors alike, providing long-term partners with greater confidence in the operating environment.

*Liberia's reform approach is sequenced and credibility-driven, prioritizing continuity over disruption.*

Independent analysis underscores the intentional nature of this approach. Drawing on recent World Bank findings, Liberia's fiscal consolidation reflects a dual emphasis on stronger domestic revenue performance and tighter expenditure control. The government reduced overall expenditure from 27.2 percent of GDP in 2023 to 24.3 percent in 2024, driven largely by restraint in recurrent spending. This pattern points to a reform strategy that prioritizes stability and credibility over short-term expansion.

Shaped by lived experience, the country approaches economic engagement with the same principles that inform its diplomacy: prevention over reaction, stewardship over speed, and partnership grounded in shared responsibility. Having emerged from a period of profound national transformation, Liberia brings a hard-earned understanding of how confidence in markets and institutions is built over time. Through the ARREST Agenda for Inclusive Development, the country has articulated a focused pathway centered on job creation, productive capacity, and economic resilience. In an uncertain global environment, Liberia presents itself as a considered, credible partner, committed to building growth that lasts.





## What if the Ottomans Had Survived?

Recent scholarship shows the promise  
—and limits—of a historical path not taken.

By Nick Danforth

**F**ollowing its defeat in World War I, the Ottoman Empire came to an end on Nov. 1, 1922. After six centuries of splendor, stretching from the Persian Gulf to the gates of Vienna, the once-great sultanate stumbled spent into the 20th century and finally collapsed. But what if it hadn't?

The fall of the Ottomans was once seen as an inevitable end for “the sick man of Europe,” especially during a historical moment that left empires from the Qing to the Hapsburgs in tatters. But

a growing number of works by historians such as Donald Quataert and Hasan Kayali argue that the Ottomans’ decline was overstated and collapse was not predestined. In fact, had its leadership stayed out of World War I, or had its German and Austrian allies proved victorious, the empire might well have survived.

Mustafa Aksakal’s *The War That Made the Middle East* offers the latest and most compelling take on this argument. Aksakal, a historian at Georgetown University,

The hypothetical borders of the Ottoman Empire in 1930.

argues that on the eve of the Great War, the Ottoman Empire was not a sick man, doomed to decline by sectarian and national separatist movements. Rather, it was a viable political entity that was destroyed by catastrophic decisions, external invasions, and the profound strain of an existential conflict. As Aksakal writes, “A different future for the empire was also on the table, one that kept alive and extended the empire’s history of a multiethnic and multireligious society.”

What would this hypothetical, postwar Ottoman state have looked like? Perhaps wisely, most historians are hesitant to delve too far into the speculative realm of alternate history. But their scholarship nonetheless provides clues for anyone foolhardy enough to try.

**IN THE DECADES LEADING UP** to World War I, the Ottoman state had seen bold political experiments toward liberal rights and constitutional rule, alongside ugly outbreaks of intercommunal bloodletting. As the historian Ussama Makdisi writes, “Ottoman modernity ... promised both a multiethnic and multireligious sovereign future and a xenophobic world without minorities.” In the course of the war, this contradiction would be resolved, culminating in a tragic moment where, as recounted by Aksakal, a politician named Ahmed Riza spoke out in the Ottoman Senate, citing the constitution to unsuccessfully protest the Armenian genocide as it was being carried out.

But if the Ottoman government had not plunged into a global conflagration and lost, would things have turned out better? Could the empire have emerged as a pluralistic state in which Christians, Muslims, and Jews—not to mention Turks, Kurds, and Arabs—all enjoyed some measure of civic equality within a functioning parliamentary monarchy?

There is some evidence for optimism. What stands out, though, is that by 1914, the empire looked much more promising as a multiethnic society than a multireligious one. If the Ottoman state survived in some meaningful form, it would most likely have been as a predominantly and explicitly Muslim one. Imagine a political entity where Turks, Arabs, and Kurds were granted equal rights and official recognition as the empire’s constituent ethnic communities but where many Christians had been ethnically cleansed and several

key Christian regions had been seized by Western powers.

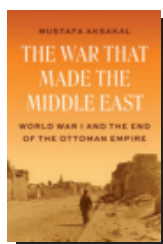
The growing salience of religion in determining loyalty and belonging is evident in the actual history of the Ottoman Empire before and during World War I.

Throughout the 19th century, European powers, particularly Russia, had helped Christian groups, including the Greeks (1832), Serbs (1867), and Bulgarians (1878), secure independence from the Sublime Porte, the empire’s central government. Despite, or because of, this, the Ottoman Empire demonstrated its political sophistication in managing relations with Christians who remained in the empire. According to the historian Eugene Rogan, for instance, after a violent pogrom against Christians in Damascus in 1860, Ottoman administrators sought to identify and punish the perpetrators in order to simultaneously reassure the survivors and avert a French intervention. The historian Michelle Campos, in turn, has argued that efforts to create a religiously inclusive form of Ottoman civic identity came to a head with the empire’s 1908 constitutional revolution. But they proved short-lived.

In 1909, as many as 30,000 Armenians were killed in a series of massacres in the territory of Adana. The Balkan Wars, between 1912 and 1913, cost the empire much of its remaining territory in Europe and led many of the empire’s rulers to conclude that Christians would always represent a security threat. In February 1914, the Porte, under European pressure, signed an Armenian reform package with Russia—an agreement that placed six of the empire’s Armenian-populated provinces under the authority of two European inspector generals. Many Ottoman Muslims worried that it was a prelude to eastern Anatolia’s eventual independence, and Aksakal quotes the British ambassador at the time expressing sympathy with these fears.

By this point, the empire’s leadership had largely lost faith in the prospect of a multireligious future. In 1913, the Ottoman War Ministry called for a nationwide boycott against Christian businesses, calling it an “economic holy war.” In the spring of 1914, the government began a violent campaign of ethnic cleansing against Greeks on the Aegean coast. Only by forcing the Christian inhabitants to flee, they believed, could the territory be secured.

The late 19th and early 20th centuries also saw the rise of Arab national identity, particularly in the cities of the Levant, as well as an increasing attention to Turkish-Arab ethnic differences in the imperial capital. But this took a less separatist course among the empire’s largely Muslim, Arabic-speaking population. Arab nationalism was initially focused on linguistic and cultural revival. On the eve of World War I, its champions generally advocated greater political recognition and representation, pushing for political parties or autonomy instead of full independence. One widely discussed idea was to preserve the Ottoman state as a



*The War That Made the Middle East: World War I and the End of the Ottoman Empire*

MUSTAFA AKSAKAL,  
PRINCETON UNIVERSITY  
PRESS, 264 PP.,  
\$32, JANUARY 2026

Turco-Arab dual monarchy on the model of Austria-Hungary.

Popular accounts of World War I often highlight T.E. Lawrence and Faisal's Arab Revolt in the Hijaz. Aksakal also describes uprisings in Shiite Iraq as well as Ottoman suspicions about the reliability of Arab conscripts. But that's only part of the story. Faisal, for example, claimed that he was rebelling against the specific abuses of the wartime Ottoman government, not the sultanate itself.

What's more, work by the historians Michael Provence, Alp Yenen, and Hasan Kayali has shown that, in the face of widespread famine and persecution, the Arab elite largely remained committed to the empire until the end of the war—and sometimes after. Figures who would later emerge as prominent Arab leaders often still saw themselves as Ottomans until that was no longer a viable option. Many Arab Ottoman military officers, such as Nuri al-Said, who went on to become prime minister of Iraq, only joined the Arab Revolt after ending up in British prisoner of war camps. When the revolt succeeded, Said continued to explore, however opportunistically, political ties with the Ottomans. In 1918, he transmitted a proposal on Faisal's behalf suggesting a federal arrangement where "Arabia" would be "to the Ottoman state what Bavaria is to Germany."

**SO, WHAT DOES ALL THIS MEAN** for speculation about the Ottoman Empire's survival? The question is not so much whether the Ottoman sultan himself might have lived on as a figurehead in Turkey or somewhere else. As the historian Ryan Gingeras argues, the fall of the Ottoman royal family was distinct from the end of Ottoman rule over much of the Middle East.

When it comes to the endurance of the Ottoman Empire as a territorial entity, however, historical events set limits on any speculation. Survival might have simply meant a few more decades of formal empire, with Ottoman leadership still unable to navigate foreign threats and domestic tensions, leaving the Middle East with a different, but still fractured, map of newly made nation-states.

Ottoman leaders entered World War I on Germany's side to secure their sovereignty in the face of threats from Russia, France, and Britain. As Aksakal explains, these countries pointedly refused Ottoman offers to remain neutral in return for a formal guarantee of the empire's territorial integrity—meaning that if the Ottomans had stayed out of the war, they might have been attacked anyway, either immediately or down the road.

Perhaps even in an alternate history, the Soviet government, after recovering from the Russian civil war, would eventually have taken a renewed interest in the plight of the Ottoman Armenians across its border. Perhaps Britain, still worried about the security of the Suez Canal, would have kept eyeing Palestine. Suppose at some point in the 1920s,

an Armenian uprising prompts a Russian intervention in northeastern Anatolia. Following several years of intense fighting, the front lines stabilize at roughly the same place they actually stood in 1917, and a new border emerges.

The war prompts intercommunal violence on both sides, leading many Armenians to flee into Russian-held territory and Muslims to flee toward the Ottoman Empire. Tensions also flare between Muslims and Armenians in Jerusalem. Britain, taking advantage of the disturbance, seizes the Holy Land in the name of restoring order and declares it an international zone. Ibn Saud takes the Hijaz. France, refusing to be left out, launches a campaign to capture the Maronite region of Mount Lebanon. After an initially successful naval landing outside Beirut, French forces eventually advance as far as Maysalun, where they are stopped by an Ottoman force led by Mustafa Kemal Atatürk.

**WHERE DOES THIS SCENARIO** leave the rest of the empire? It's easy to imagine its ethnically diverse Muslim inhabitants rallying together in the face of European invasions. But even in a more fanciful alternate history, nationalism wouldn't disappear. As Kayali has shown, a growing political divide between Turks and Arabs may not have been inevitable, but it wasn't purely a matter of chance—or European instigation—either.

Indeed, as Ottoman leadership worked to build a stronger and more centralized state, this process itself drove resistance. In the early 20th century, the Istanbul government sent out a growing number of judges, gendarmes, teachers, and tax collectors to more effectively govern the Arab provinces. Most spoke Turkish, and some carried distinctly chauvinistic attitudes, both of which registered with locals who didn't necessarily appreciate what these bureaucrats were doing in the first place. Even democratic measures could fuel nationalism. Creating a parliament, for example, inevitably provoked debate about which language or languages should be spoken on its floor.

Notably, the one major multiethnic empire that in some sense survived World War I was Russia, which emerged reconstituted as the Soviet Union. But even though the Soviet government in Moscow kept the vast bulk of the power, it made a point of co-opting national sentiment by reorganizing

**Survival might have simply meant a few more decades of formal empire, leaving the Middle East with a different, but still fractured, map of newly made nation-states.**





A proclamation of the constitution of the Ottoman Empire, dated July 24, 1908.

the empire as a series of nominally autonomous republics and taking steps to at first pander to, and later brutally suppress, their national identities.

It's possible that the Ottoman Empire, if it had survived, would have taken a similar approach, only with Islam instead of communism as the glue. Imagine the government recognizing, even celebrating, the Turkish, Arab, and perhaps Kurdish people as constituent elements of the empire. Each group would be able to use its language in circumscribed local situations, even as the Porte increasingly promoted Turkish as the language of government, business, and public life.

In trying to manage ethnic divisions, the Ottoman Empire, no less than the European powers that actually took over the Middle East, would have been tempted to manipulate borders to its advantage. As Vanderbilt University's Samuel Dolbee has shown, the Ottoman government had previously redrawn internal provincial boundaries to enhance the state's power at the expense of local populations. Postwar Ottoman leaders might well have created new geographic territories in order to break up the empire's Arab population and dilute its political influence. Perhaps, in keeping with some actual proposals for Ottoman decentralization, they would have ended up with Syria and Iraq.

Would this have worked? Maybe. An Ottoman state flush with oil wealth might have had more resources with which to improve the lives of its Arab subjects and win their allegiance. Or maybe not. It's also possible the Ottomans would have eventually faced a determined anti-colonial uprising by Arabs across the southern part of their empire: In the aftermath of World War II, Arab activists grow increasingly resentful as Istanbul hoards the region's oil revenues. They quickly secure Soviet support in their bid for independence. The United States deploys military advisors to assist the Porte in a rapidly escalating proxy war.

Here, fans of the everything-basically-turns-out-the-same school of alternate history might be tempted to imagine the Ottoman Empire's trajectory proceeding something like Pakistan's. Pakistan was founded in a 1947 as a multi-ethnic state for Muslims in the former British Raj. Following a civil war in 1971, East Pakistan, a geographically and ethnically distinct part of the country, split off to become Bangladesh. Maybe in the Bangladesh scenario, Istanbul's loss of the Middle East would prompt a coup against the Ottoman government, ultimately leaving a geographically smaller republic that looked a lot like Turkey.

**ALL THIS, OF COURSE**, is impossible to know. But what makes this foray into alternate history more than a silly diversion is that it speaks to the enduring question of what political futures are possible. From Syria to Iraq to Israel-Palestine, high-stakes debates continue to rage over whether people can realistically be expected to live together in the same political entity or whether they would be better off divided into separate states.

Alas, the best history can do is offer a lot of contradictory examples of what works and what doesn't. Even with the benefit of hindsight, it remains remarkably difficult to parse when religious and ethnic differences will prove insurmountable. People certainly don't need to be divided up. But divisions, once inflamed, can prove nearly impossible to reverse.

What stands out in the Ottoman case is that some of the fundamental problems would almost certainly have endured, even as the specific conflicts might have differed. Alternate history can never offer some kind of panacea—a perfect path not taken. Instead, it offers us a series of lesser evils to sort through. ■

NICK DANFORTH is a deputy editor at FOREIGN POLICY.



## Hard to Resist

An intimate view of Russia's descent into fascism.  
*By Christian Caryl*

**P**avel Talankin, the unlikely star of the Oscar-winning documentary *Mr. Nobody Against Putin*, is, by his own account, a bit of an odd duck. He informs us that he owns precisely 427 books, all carefully arranged by color. He shows us a photo of himself as a little boy with a bright blue floppy ribbon on the top of his head. “As a young student, I knew that I was different from the other boys, even if I had no idea why,” he says. “Maybe this is why I was always alone.”

Having read about Talankin’s film before I watched it, I expected to see trenchant commentary on the militarization of Russian schools in the era of President Vladimir Putin’s all-out war on Ukraine. I wasn’t disappointed. Talankin worked as the events coordinator and videographer for the elementary school in his hometown of Karabash (a town of roughly 10,000 in the Ural Mountains). Using footage he took at the school, he offers a snapshot of Russia’s descent into fascism—from the school’s grenade-throwing competition to a history teacher who professes his admiration for Lavrentiy Beria, Stalin’s serial-raping secret police chief. (Imagine a modern-day German teacher saying, “Himmler and Heydrich were two of our country’s most impressive statesmen.”)

Pavel Talankin, a teacher and videographer at an elementary school in Karabash, Russia, in the documentary *Mr. Nobody Against Putin*.

Appalling as all this was, it didn't come as much of a surprise. Anyone who has paid attention to Putin's public statements about the war would have expected as much. What I didn't expect from this film, however, was a nuanced study of the psychology of resistance told from the viewpoint of a person who realizes that his government is wrong and becomes determined to do something about it.

Talankin doesn't dramatize his own role at all. When he thinks about the anti-war protesters he has seen on the internet, he's forced to admit that he would never be able to do the same: "I wish I could be as brave as them. But I'm not."

Yet for some mysterious reason he just can't help thinking for himself, despite living in a place where the overwhelming majority of people are willing to conform. Just to make things worse, he feels a deep and abiding affection for his community, the school where he teaches, and the people who surround him—all of which makes his own political estrangement, which deepens as the war (and the film) goes on, especially painful. Seeing no other outlet for his frustration, he ends up surreptitiously collaborating with an American filmmaker based in Europe on a project to track the wartime deformation of Russian society from within.

He shows us military drills for sixth graders. He shows us a teacher tripping over government jargon in a statement she has been ordered to read for his camera. He shows us a visit by Wagner Group mercenaries—notorious for the atrocities they've committed in Ukraine and elsewhere—who show off weapons and warn their elementary-school audience to leave helmet straps unbuttoned: "It will break your neck if you get shot in the head." The Beria-admiring teacher informs his class that Western sanctions are hurting Europeans more than Russians: "In France, to fill the tank with petrol, you need more than 150 euros. So the French will soon be like musketeers, riding horses, and the rest of Europe, too."

The ground-level perspective of the footage—which documents life in a provincial backwater far from the well-reported worlds of Moscow and St. Petersburg—would have made this film genuinely compelling in its own right. But it is Talankin's own presence that makes the story truly unique. As he eventually realizes, the point of all the indoctrination is not just to bring the majority into line with government dogma; it's also to intimidate and marginalize the

minority of citizens who, like him, are still able to think with a modicum of independence. "I love my job, but I don't want to become a pawn of this regime," he notes at one point. Forced to film a pro-war rally, he feels an almost palpable disgust about his own role. "I feel like I'm an alien in my own hometown."

In the pre-2022 era, Talankin tells us, he had managed to transform the school into a kind of surrogate family. He turned his own small room in the school into a safe space for pupils. It became a place where no one took offense at the pro-opposition flag on his wall and where venting about sensitive themes raised no eyebrows. But as his isolation deepens, he can't help indulging in symbolic anti-regime acts with potentially devastating consequences—such as playing Lady Gaga's version of the U.S. national anthem on the school loudspeaker during an official event. There is, indeed, a paradoxical lightness to his treatment of depressing material that saves the film from becoming a dreary screed.

The more manifest his opposition, the more those close to him fall away. One of his favorite students, a girl named Masha, loses her brother on the front in Ukraine; Talankin is clearly wounded by her refusal to open up to him about her bereavement. It gradually becomes clear to him that his work with the foreign filmmakers will have inescapable consequences: He is forced to emigrate, not knowing if he'll ever be able to come back. (He left Russia in 2024.)

I've always been fascinated by people who choose to do the right thing despite the rejection and hostility of those around them. For every heroic activist who receives accolades and support, there are uncountable others who face ostracism, isolation, even physical violence. Indeed, as we saw in January in Iran, public dissent sometimes translates into slaughter and a nameless grave. Why, precisely, there are individuals who opt for the high-cost path of resistance remains mysterious. Has Talankin become an oppositionist because he has always felt like an outsider? Perhaps. But he is most certainly not a bitter and vengeful revolutionary. He's actually a dedicated local patriot, which is even more remarkable when you consider that his gritty place of origin has been described as "one of Russia's most polluted towns." One wonders how he will fare in exile. It is not going to be easy.

"Love for your country is not about putting up a flag," Talankin says in a voice-over. "It is not about singing the anthem either. It's not about exploitation and propaganda." Sometimes, indeed, it can mean taking the lonelier path. *Mr. Nobody Against Putin* is a minor miracle. ■

**As his isolation deepens, Talankin can't help indulging in symbolic anti-regime acts with potentially devastating consequences.**

CHRISTIAN CARYL is a columnist at FOREIGN POLICY and the author of *Strange Rebels: 1979 and the Birth of the 21st Century*.



Over the past years, El Salvador has undergone a profound transformation that has made visitors feel welcome and safe, encouraging exploration beyond the capital and into vibrant towns, beaches, and natural reserves. This new context allows travelers to focus on discovery, culture, and relaxation, while enjoying a destination that is compact, accessible, and rich in character.

Safety has become a cornerstone of El Salvador's tourism narrative. Improved public security has restored confidence for international visitors and locals, creating an environment where travel feels straightforward and enjoyable. Cities, coastal areas, and rural communities are increasingly integrated into tourist routes, supported by clear signage, organized services, and a growing culture of hospitality. This sense of security enhances the overall experience, allowing travelers to move freely, engage with communities, and fully appreciate the country's offerings at any time of the year.

Connectivity is another of El Salvador's major strengths. Its international airport serves as a modern gateway with efficient operations and direct connections to key cities in North America, Central America, and beyond.

Once in the country, a well-developed road network allows visitors to travel from mountains to beaches in just a few hours, making it possible to experience multiple environments on a single trip. Digital connectivity has also improved significantly, with reliable mobile coverage, as well as



# EL SALVADOR

## NEW CHAPTER OF OPENNESS AND OPPORTUNITY

El Salvador is emerging with confidence as one of the most compelling tourism destinations in the Americas, combining renewed security, excellent connectivity, and modern infrastructure with a remarkable diversity of landscapes and experiences.

internet access that supports remote work, travel planning, and seamless communication throughout the journey.

Modern infrastructure complements this accessibility. El Salvador has invested in quality hotels, boutique accommodations, restaurants, and tourist services that meet international standards while preserving local identity. Urban areas feature revitalized public spaces, cultural centers, and entertainment options, while coastal and rural regions offer eco-lodges and thoughtfully designed resorts. This balance

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***Renewed security, efficient connectivity, and modern infrastructure redefine the destination, enabling safe exploration, quick travel between regions, reliable digital access, and high-quality services that meet international standards while preserving authenticity, comfort, and a welcoming atmosphere for diverse travelers worldwide.***

between comfort and authenticity appeals to a wide range of travelers, from adventure seekers and surfers to families, couples, and business visitors.

Diversity is at the heart of El Salvador's appeal. Despite being the smallest country in Central America, it offers an impressive variety of experiences within short distances. Lush volcanic landscapes, crater lakes, cloud forests, and fertile valleys coexist with dramatic Pacific beaches and colorful colonial towns. Indigenous heritage, colonial history, and contemporary

creativity intersect in gastronomy, festivals, crafts, and music, creating a cultural richness that feels both deeply rooted and refreshingly dynamic.

Nature plays a central role in the tourist experience. National parks and protected areas invite hiking, bird-watching, and immersion in unique ecosystems shaped by volcanic activity. Scenic routes reveal coffee plantations, waterfalls, and panoramic viewpoints, while lakes and rivers provide opportunities for kayaking and relaxation. The country's commitment to sustainable tourism is increasingly visible, with conservation initiatives and community-based projects that allow visitors to enjoy nature responsibly while supporting local development.

Surf has become one of El Salvador's most internationally recognized attractions. Its Pacific coastline offers consistent waves, warm water, and uncrowded breaks suitable for all skill levels. From world-class surf spots to beginner-friendly beaches, the country has built a strong reputation within the global surf community. Surf schools, competitions, and coastal towns dedicated to the sport have created a vibrant atmosphere that blends athletic performance with laid-back beach culture, attracting surfers and spectators alike.

Beyond surfing, the coast provides opportunities for swimming, fishing, and sunset experiences that define a relaxed tropical lifestyle. Fresh seafood, oceanfront dining, and welcoming communities contribute to an authentic sense of place. Inland, culinary routes highlight traditional flavors and innovative cuisine, while coffee and cacao experiences connect visitors with local producers and centuries-old traditions.

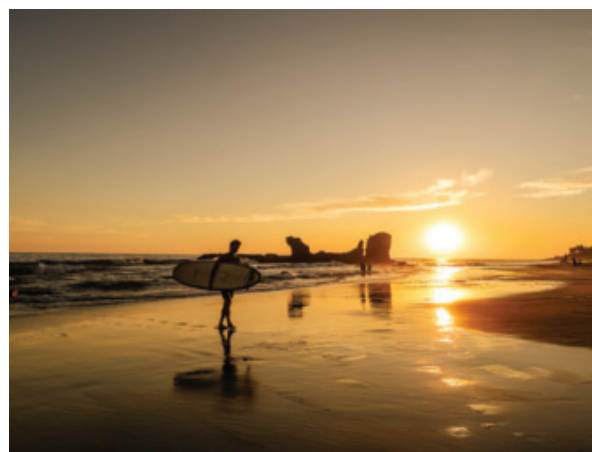
El Salvador's potential as a tourism destination lies in the way these elements come together. Security creates

***Volcanic landscapes, protected parks, and a vibrant Pacific coastline create diverse experiences, from hiking to world-class surfing, coastal cuisine, and community encounters, blending sustainability, culture, and adventure within short distances and memorable journeys for curious global travelers.***

confidence, connectivity enables exploration, and infrastructure ensures comfort. Diversity, nature, and surf add depth and excitement, while the warmth of its people leaves a lasting impression. As the country continues to open itself to the world, it offers travelers not just a place to visit, but a destination to experience with curiosity, ease, and genuine connection.

For investors and tour operators, this evolution represents opportunity and long-term vision, as public and private sectors collaborate to position the country competitively. Events, conventions, and cultural tourism are gaining relevance, supported by improved venues and professional services. At the same time, the destination maintains an approachable scale that simplifies logistics and encourages repeat visits.

Travelers often remark on how quickly El Salvador surprises them, not only with scenery and waves, but with efficiency, friendliness, and authenticity. These qualities, combined with strategic planning and international visibility, suggest a future in which tourism becomes a powerful engine for inclusive growth. It invites exploration, partnership, and meaningful travel experiences for global audiences seeking something distinct worldwide. ■



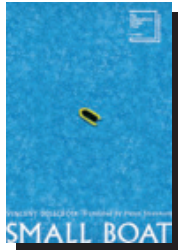
**EL SALVADOR**



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# Global Fiction

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## *Small Boat: A Novel*

VINCENT DELECROIX, TRANS. HELEN STEVENSON  
(MARINER BOOKS, 128 PP., \$25, APRIL 2026)

**ON THE NIGHT OF NOV. 24, 2021**, at least 27 migrants died in the English Channel while attempting to cross from France to Britain in an inflatable dinghy. The boat malfunctioned and began to sink about halfway through the journey; when people aboard called a French Coast Guard hotline, their pleas for help were rebuffed. It was the deadliest such incident ever recorded by the International Organization for Migration, which has collected data on illicit transit in the waterway since 2014. Most of the deceased were Iraqi Kurds.

French philosopher Vincent Delecroix uses this real-life tragedy as the basis for his acclaimed novel *Small Boat*. Originally published in France in 2023 as *Naufrage*, or “shipwreck,” the book was longlisted for the Prix Goncourt—the Francophone world’s highest literary honor—that year. An English translation released in the United Kingdom in 2025 was then shortlisted for the International Booker Prize. Now *Small Boat* is finally making its U.S. debut.

At just 128 pages, *Small Boat* is also a small book. But its slim size belies its overwhelming moral force. Delecroix’s treatise on complacency and culpability in an unequal world has already earned its spot in the modern canon. It is sure to become indispensable for historians looking back at the 21st century, too. As Jeremy Harding, a contributing editor at the *London Review of Books*, writes in an introduction to the translation, Delecroix “raises the unsettling possibility that each of us is complicit in the suffering of migrants.”

The protagonist of the story is the unnamed French Coast Guard radio operator who received more than a dozen distress calls from migrants aboard the dinghy. Throughout most of the book, she is questioned by a police officer about the recordings of those exchanges. One key quote is found in the historical record. The radio operator told the migrants: “Don’t you get it? You won’t be saved. ... It wasn’t me who told you to leave.” That comment earned her notoriety

across France and formed the basis for the interrogation that Delecroix so chillingly fictionalizes. At the heart of the conversation is the question of whether the migrants’ deaths were due to the radio operator’s “error of judgement or murderous intent,” he writes.

According to *Small Boat*, the radio operator repeatedly declined to send rescuers to the dinghy, claiming that the migrants were in English territorial waters and thus not in her jurisdiction, instead outsourcing the operation to an overwhelmed U.K. Border Force. Whether or not she was correct about the migrants’ location, this detail serves as a reminder of how strict adherence to bureaucratic technicalities can sometimes have fatal consequences. The episode led to a “war of words” between Britain and France, which each accused the other of not doing enough to stop migrant deaths in the channel, CNN reported at the time.

The radio operator wonders whether she bears personal responsibility for the tragedy or if she has become a convenient target for a public eager to pin the blame on someone—and to avoid thinking more critically about why the migrants decided to attempt the dangerous crossing in the first place. “So back we came to me again, and the idea that the cause of their death was—me. In other words, not the sea, not migration policy, not the trafficking mafia, not the war in Syria or the famine in Sudan—me,” she says in the book, as part of a long internal monologue.

Central to the novel is the question of whether individuals bear responsibility for the larger, flawed systems that they participate in. “I was a small cog in a machine that had malfunctioned,” the radio operator says. She describes herself as a loving single mother to a young girl, before continuing: “I guess that wasn’t enough, since the guards in the concentration camps loved their families too. And to say that I did my work simply and conscientiously wasn’t enough, either. Because Eichmann did his work just as conscientiously as me.”

This is one of several oblique references to Hannah Arendt. Just as she sought to expose the “banality of evil” after World War II, Delecroix has taken it upon himself to uncover what he calls “the origin of the monster of banality” for our modern era.

At the book’s end, the radio operator looks beyond her workplace and addresses the France that now reviles her. She wonders whether the migrants’ tragedy would have attracted the same level of infamy if the public had not been able to latch onto her “few phrases” as “the true cause of their deaths.” She lambasts her compatriots for performative empathy, which she calls “an idiotic luxury indulged in by people who do nothing, and who are moved by the spectacle of suffering.”

“Who is here on the shore? Who is watching this shipwreck from the mainland? Is it really just me, no one else?” she says. “You are all there. If I turned round I would see you



all, sunk into your sofas on the sand ... watching without watching. ... There is no shipwreck without spectators.” —*Allison Meakem, senior editor*



## *Babylon, South Dakota: A Novel*

TOM LIN (LITTLE, BROWN, AND CO.,  
336 PP., \$30, MAY 2026)

**TOM LIN'S SOPHOMORE NOVEL**, *Babylon, South Dakota*, is so immense in spirit, so imaginatively rendered, that on finishing it, it's hard to believe it rings in at fewer than 350 pages. This strange and spellbinding book is at once a fabulist tale of a quiet homestead, a heart-pounding geopolitical thriller, a multigenerational immigrant saga, a dissection of the American dream, and a meditation on longing and death.

In the years after the Cultural Revolution, a Chinese couple arrives in the windswept plains of the U.S. Midwest to start anew on a 160-acre farm. Their single suitcase and knapsack contain but few possessions—perhaps most importantly, a little silk bag of seeds from the chrysanthemums that once grew in the courtyard of the husband's childhood home, flowers that were “scythed and torched on the night that men—boys, really—had battered down their gates, denounced them as collaborators, and beaten them by firelight.” (Even violence is made beautiful in Lin's prose.)

Despite the improbability of those fragile tea blossoms thriving in South Dakota's harsh climate, a handful survive the first frigid winter under the husband's tender care, and soon, their hybrid varieties blanket the fields, flowering unceasingly and growing like weeds. Early on, the chrysanthemums are synchronized to the lunar calendar, but over the decades, they adopt their own rhythms, even developing immunity to herbicides and yearslong drought.

If the chrysanthemums feel a touch Arcadian, the outer world encroaches on this idyll: Soon after the Hsiu family settles in, the U.S. military identifies a patch of their land as its next missile site. Men from the nearby base of “Babylon”—that biblical symbol of human hubris and depravity—arrive to construct and man the silo, which turns out to house not just a warhead but also a device capable of making the U.S. nuclear program infallible. Explanations of this tool, which has been reverse-engineered from Chinese technology, are

as labyrinthine as the logic of deterrence itself. Tragedy inevitably unfolds as the personal and geopolitical collide.

Lin, who left China for the United States at the age of 4, captures the impossibility of a private life estranged from the realities of borders and statecraft and empire. This does not mean that *Babylon, South Dakota* is governed by a kind of fatalism or hopelessness. In the novel's cosmos, outside forces bring enchantments just as they spell misfortune. By the book's end, not unlike the Hsius, those improbable chrysanthemums have rooted themselves into the earth, far deeper than anyone envisioned, growing “so low and firm where they had once been cut back that they could simply be left alone.” —*Chloe Hadavas, senior editor*



## *Stories: The Collected Short Fiction*

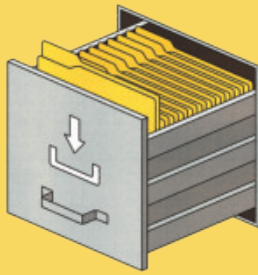
HELEN GARNER (PANTHEON,  
208 PP., \$27, MARCH 2026)

**IN TIMES AS BLEAK AS THESE**, many people may feel a desire to escape into a different era—at the very least, that seems to be the case for the editors and publicists at Penguin Random House. This month, the U.S. publisher released a collection of short stories by celebrated Australian novelist Helen Garner that debuted in her native country nearly a decade ago. She wrote many of the stories in the last century, during the 1980s and 1990s.

“Most of Garner's stories are fronted by Australian women living in the transformative period of feminism's second wave,” American author Jonathan Escoffery writes in the foreword to the new collection. Garner's blunt prose eschews euphemisms and confronts matters of sex and gender head-on. Crossword-playing fathers grow visibly uncomfortable as, across the living room, their daughters and wives muse about tampons and periods. When two female friends discuss experimenting with lesbianism, the one who has only ever had sex with men asks, “[I]f both of you have the same equipment does that mean it's more equal?”

For all her piquant observations of Australian life (“Have you ever noticed,” one character says, “how Australian men, even in their forties, dress like small boys?”), Garner devotes many of her pages to other continents. She takes readers to England, France, Germany, and, briefly, Pakistan.

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A recurring character is from dictatorship-era Brazil; “We don’t have elections,” he says, causing the story’s Australian protagonist to feel ashamed that she has the privilege of casually debating politics with friends.

Of Karachi, Garner writes: “Everything outside was dust-coloured, and shimmered.” In Germany, she takes care to highlight locals’ accents as one describes being “a souzand miles from the ocean!” She spends several paragraphs satirizing the French obsession with food pairings after a Parisian man refuses to eat fish and green vegetables together, even though those are the only things left in his fridge. And she lists the smallest observations with rigid obsession, noting, for example, how “non-European paper” has “horizontal lines instead of squares.” (This reviewer has a strong preference for the latter.)

Garner is at her best when she puts words to intangible sensations, such as feelings of cultural limbo. Upon visiting England, an Australian character who lives in France says: “I hate being able to understand everything that’s going on around me. I miss that feeling of your senses having to strain an inch beyond your skin that you get in places where people aren’t speaking your language.” In another story, Garner describes watching a German man talk: “He looked as if the words he spoke were made of soft, unresisting matter, as if he were chewing air.”

Despite her geographical crisscrossing, Garner never forgets where she and most of her characters come from. She whisks readers from Sydney to Melbourne and Adelaide to Perth, with stops in nondescript Gold Coast condos along the way. One Australian expat in London says that, when homesick, he would routinely “take down the atlas and gaze at the page with Australia on it: I loved its upper points, its vast inlets, its fat sides, the might of it, the mass from whose south-eastern corner my small life had sprung.”—AM

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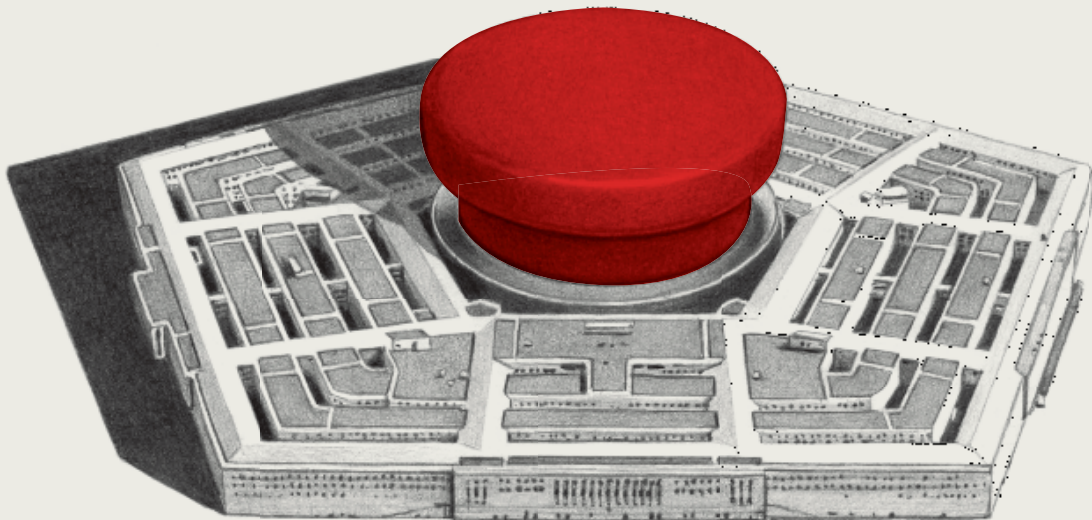
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# Situation Report

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An inside look at the world's most pressing security challenges.

By reporters JOHN HALTIWANGER and RISHI IYENGAR







**Raymond Landveld**  
Minister of Transport,  
Communication and Tourism



**Melvin Bouva**  
Minister of Foreign Affairs,  
International Business and Cooperation



**Stephen Tsang**  
Minister of Public Works  
and Spatial Planning



**Andrew Baasaron**  
Minister of Economic Affairs,  
Entrepreneurship and  
Technological Innovation

## South America's best kept secret, but not for long

Suriname's entire population is smaller than Miami's. Nevertheless, oil is expected to flow from 2028 and is likely to catapult this country into newfound wealth

Suriname is about to be transformed. Long defined by its extractive industries, the country is now attempting a careful transition, leveraging anticipated offshore oil revenues to lay the groundwork for a diversified, resilient and sustainable economy.

The challenge is both urgent and structural. Much of the country's drainage and roads date back to the mid-20th century and are increasingly unable to cope with urban growth. Sea defenses and resilient urban planning are not optional — they are existential.

Years of deferred maintenance have left roads and bridges in poor condition, but the expected inflow of oil revenues around 2028 is already catalyzing new thinking. "Although Suriname is one of the world's few carbon-negative countries, most of our population lives in coastal areas that are vulnerable to rising sea levels. Strengthening

coastal defence and rehabilitating roads and drainage infrastructure are therefore essential," Stephen Tsang notes. Public-private partnerships are being explored to pre-finance critical infrastructure, from rehabilitating the East-West corridor to building new bridges and even a deep-sea port to support offshore energy operations.

At the same time, foreign policy is becoming an important lever for economic transformation. As international interest grows alongside the country's oil discoveries, Suriname is positioning itself as an open and reliable partner for trade, investment and cooperation. Strengthening its diplomatic network and economic diplomacy is central to this effort, ensuring that global engagement translates into tangible outcomes such as investment flows. Active participation in regional and multilateral organizations like the Caribbean

Community (CARICOM), the UN and the Organization of American States gives the country a diplomatic reach that extends beyond its size. Upcoming leadership roles within CARICOM offer further opportunity to shape regional integration and connectivity.

### Local content or no content

Economic policy is evolving in parallel. Under Andrew Baasaron, the government is explicitly focused on diversification. With projections of multi-billion-dollar oil revenues over the coming decades, the strategy is clear: build human capital and productive capacity now to avoid overdependence later. As Melvin Bouva underscores, "Suriname's export base remains highly concentrated in gold, which brings strong revenues but limits broader value creation. This is why economic diversification is a national priority. The government is developing a post-2026 development roadmap focused on reinvesting gold and future oil revenues into new growth sectors."

Technology is key to that ambition. "We are designing a national strategy for digital technology and

AI, learning from global leaders and regional partners like Brazil, Chile and Colombia," Baasaron says. At the same time, policymakers are seeking to position Suriname as a regional hub, strengthening trade links within CARICOM and neighbors, while leveraging its unique geographic position as a bridge between South America and the Caribbean.

Connectivity, both physical and digital, is equally critical. For Raymond Landveld, the integration of transport networks, ICT infrastructure and tourism development reflects a broader vision of economic transformation. Investments in fiber-optic connectivity, port expansion and airport modernization aim to reduce isolation and improve competitiveness, while reforms in public transport — including potential digital ticketing systems — seek to increase efficiency and inclusion. "Investing in infrastructure is essential to unlock growth in agriculture, tourism and business. This means strengthening logistics, roads and energy systems, while also expanding renewable energy, which can stimulate other sectors of the

Prisma Reports wishes to thank its esteemed partners for their contribution to this project:





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**Suriname is building more roads to make its vast interior more accessible**

economy. Infrastructure is the foundation for sustainable development.”

Tourism, however, may represent Suriname's most underappreciated opportunity. With roughly 90% of its territory covered in pristine rainforest, the country offers something rare: a high-value, low-impact model centered on nature, culture and authenticity. This is explained by the minister: “Suriname is off the beaten path — an opportunity for investors willing to develop sustainable, high-value tourism. Improving transport, both inland and internationally, is key to making this vision possible.”

There is a cautious optimism in this part of the world. If managed effectively, oil revenues could finance the very diversification Suriname seeks — transforming infrastructure, enabling technological leapfrogging and unlocking a tourism sector that remains largely untapped.

### No Dutch disease here

As Suriname prepares for growth, the effectiveness of its logistics and aviation platforms will play a decisive role in translating ambition into execution. Companies operating on the ground — at ports, airports and supply chains — will determine how well people, goods and capital move.

For Integra Marine & Freight Services (IMFS), the evolution of Suriname's logistics sector mirrors the country's broader economic trajectory. As Remy Vyzelman explains: “In 2017-2018, we made a decision to integrate and create an end-to-end perspective, which



**Vijay Chotkan**  
CEO, Airport Management Ltd.

was ideal for clients, reflecting a growing demand for seamless, single-provider solutions in a complex operating environment.”

As offshore exploration accelerates and large-scale industrial projects take shape, the ability to manage complex, time-sensitive cargoes is vital. IMFS has already demonstrated this capability through projects ranging from the chartering and transport of heavy industrial equipment to Suriname, to the full logistical coordination of offshore seismic surveys involving multiple vessels, crews and supply chains, thereby demonstrating technical and nautical expertise and coordination with international partners.

More broadly, integrated logistics providers are becoming platform businesses for the wider economy, helping to build the connective tissue of a more diversified economic model. As Vyzelman emphasizes: “Everyone has a shared responsibility, no one player can do this alone.” That collaborative



**Remy Vyzelman**  
Chairman Supervisory Board  
Integra Marine & Freight Services

approach — spanning private operators, port authorities, customs and regulators — will be essential to sustaining growth as volumes increase and new sectors emerge.

A similar dynamic is visible in aviation. Airport Management Ltd. is tasked not only with handling current demand, but with anticipating a sharp increase in passenger and cargo flows linked to oil and gas, tourism and business travel. The company is prioritizing digital transformation as a first step toward improving efficiency and passenger experience.

“The airport is transitioning out of a congested operational phase. Rather than investing heavily in aging infrastructure, our strategy prioritizes digitalization to improve operational efficiency and significantly enhance the passenger experience,” explains CEO Vijay Chotkan. The introduction of integrated digital systems — connecting airlines, immigration and ground handlers — is expected to reduce queuing times, stream-

line processes and create a more seamless travel experience.

At the same time, physical expansion remains unavoidable. Passenger volumes are projected to exceed one million shortly after 2030, driven by both tourism and energy-sector activity. Plans for a new terminal, with a capacity of up to 1.5 million passengers, are therefore advancing in parallel with digital upgrades.

Cargo is another area of significant potential. Current export flows — including seafood shipments to the U.S. — already demonstrate strong demand, but structural gaps in the supply chain limit the country's ability to fully capitalize on this.

Critically, aviation development is being approached as part of a wider ecosystem. Improvements in road connectivity between Paramaribo and the airport and potential public-private partnerships for airport-related infrastructure such as hotels and coordination with government ministries point to a integrated planning framework. As Chotkan notes: “Air connectivity serves as the foundation for broader development. Without it, sectors such as tourism, business, and infrastructure cannot grow.”

There is a central theme here: whether through more efficient ports or smarter airports, Suriname is steadily building the platforms required to convert future oil revenues into sustained, broad-based growth. Its time has well and truly arrived.





## Saffron's Last Gasp

Geopolitics threatens supply  
of the world's most expensive spice.  
*By Kamran Yousuf*

**M**ohammad Altaf Dar arranges tiny glass vials on a wooden shelf inside his shop at Lal Chowk, a city square in Srinagar, in the Indian union territory of Jammu and Kashmir. Each vial contains crimson threads of saffron, worth more than their weight in silver.

For three decades, this shop has supplied Srinagar's households and tourist hotels with the world's most expensive spice. Now Dar faces an unprecedented predicament.

Iran produces more than 90 percent of the world's saffron in the vast fields of Khorasan. It has long been a quiet backbone of supply for traders across South Asia. In Kashmir, where local saffron harvests have declined in recent years, many retailers have increasingly relied on Iranian imports to keep their businesses afloat and meet demand from tourists and export buyers.

Dar's last shipment of Iranian saffron sits delayed at a port in Dubai, caught in the crossfire of a conflict that exploded across the Middle East in February. The Strait of Hormuz has become a dangerous chokepoint, and Iranian exports have slowed down.

Meanwhile, Kashmir's own saffron harvest all but collapsed last year, yielding barely 20 percent of normal output, according to farmers in Pampore, the saffron bowl south of Srinagar.





**OFFICIAL FIGURES PAINT A GRIM PICTURE:** Production slipped to 19.58 metric tons in 2024-25, down from 23.53 metric tons in 2023-24. Some growers say the reality was far worse, with many fields producing almost nothing during the October-November flowering season. The Karewa plateaus, where purple saffron crocus blooms have colored the landscape for centuries, offered only bare soil last fall.

Kashmir contributes less than 1 percent of the global market by volume but commands respect among connoisseurs for an entirely different reason. Kashmiri saffron contains higher concentrations of crocin, the carotenoid pigment responsible for the spice's distinctive color, measuring 8.72 percent compared with the Iranian variety's 6.82 percent.

The local Mongra grade displays a dark maroon-purple hue that indicates potent flavor and aroma. Iranian saffron is drier, more commercially available, and historically much cheaper than the Kashmiri variant. This quality distinction matters enormously in Kashmiri kitchens, where saffron functions as an essential foundation of culinary identity.

The spice threads through the region's most celebrated dishes. It imparts both golden color and earthy sweetness to *rogan josh*, the crimson lamb curry that anchors any proper *wazwan* feast. Cooks soak threads in warm water to release their essence into *yakhni*, the delicate yogurt-based mutton stew flavored with fennel and cardamom.

During Ramadan, the spice sweetens *modur pulao*, a rice dish studded with dried fruits and nuts that breaks the daily fast. *Phirni*, the creamy rice pudding served at weddings, would appear pallid and incomplete without the threads scattered across its surface.

And without saffron, *gushtaba*—pounded meatballs simmered in creamy yogurt sauce—would lose their royal status as the traditional finale to Kashmiri banquets.

Even the morning ritual of *kahwa* depends entirely on those crimson strands. This traditional green tea, brewed with cinnamon, cardamom, and crushed almonds, receives its medicinal reputation from saffron. Families measure their hospitality by the strength of the saffron they add to the teapot.

Shahnawaz Khan understands this cultural weight intimately. The 28-year-old agricultural entrepreneur left a corporate procurement job in Mumbai four years ago to return to his family's 3-acre plot in Pampore. He now works with 50 farming families to supply authentic Kashmiri saffron

directly to consumers, bypassing the middlemen who have long exploited growers.

Khan spent November 2025 watching helplessly as his network harvested meager quantities from parched fields. The rainfall deficit reached 29 percent last year, with October temperatures soaring above seasonal norms.

"The flowers bloomed for barely two hours each morning, instead of lasting through the day," Khan said while seated in his store at Lethapora, once a thriving saffron marketplace along a Kashmir highway. "By 9, the heat had already withered them. Our total collection came to barely 6 kilograms, whereas in my childhood, we gathered nearly 100 kilograms each day."

The shortage has pushed local prices toward 500,000 rupees per kilogram, equivalent to roughly 35 grams of gold.

Dar, the Srinagar trader, confirms that retail prices have jumped 20 percent since February, with some grades commanding even higher premiums.

The irony cuts deep for farmers who have watched Iranian imports undercut their market for two decades. India consumes approximately 100 metric tons of saffron annually, while Kashmir produces approximately 20 metric tons. The gap has traditionally been filled by Iranian saffron entering through Delhi or Mumbai, often mixed with Kashmiri product or repackaged entirely as local goods.

Traders could purchase Iranian saffron for roughly 200 rupees per gram wholesale, while Kashmiri saffron commanded 400 rupees or more. Many Srinagar shops sold the imported variety to tourists seeking "authentic Kashmiri saffron," pocketing the difference while degrading the region's reputation.

Mushtaq Mir, who heads a Srinagar-based saffron seller group, has fought this practice for years. The 45-year-old farmer owns 5 kanals of land (equivalent to a bit more than half an acre) outside Pampore, land that his family has cultivated for four generations. He describes the Iranian presence as an organized deception that harms genuine growers.

"Large quantities arrive through Dubai, get processed locally, and enter markets under our name," Mir said. "This mafia has destroyed price structures. Now the conflict has turned that dependency upside down."

**THE DEPENDENCY EXTENDS** beyond economics into agricultural infrastructure.

The National Mission on Saffron, launched by the Indian government in 2010 with a budget of roughly \$42 million, promised bore wells and sprinkler irrigation to combat increasingly erratic rainfall. Sixteen years later, 77 of the 124 planned bore wells remain largely nonfunctional, according to government data from February.

Farmers cite disputes over land rights, stolen pipes,

**The Iran crisis has exposed vulnerabilities that extend beyond economics into cultural preservation.**

and absent maintenance. Without reliable irrigation, the crop remains hostage to weather patterns that have grown increasingly hostile.

Ghulam Nabi, a 60-year-old farmer from Lethapora, has abandoned two of his three saffron plots, converting the land to high-density apple orchards that promise more reliable returns. He remembers harvesting 20 tolas (roughly 230 grams) of saffron annually from those fields, but this past season yielded barely 1.

“The corms have grown thin and exhausted,” he said, referring to saffron crocus bulbs. “Replacing them requires investment we cannot afford, especially when Iranian imports keep retail prices depressed.”

The geographical indication (GI) tag awarded to Kashmiri saffron in 2020 was supposed to solve this authentication problem. The certification verifies origin and quality through laboratory testing at the India International Kashmir Saffron Trading Centre in Pampore. GI-certified saffron fetches premium prices, up to 220,000 rupees per kilogram at government auctions compared with 80,000 rupees for noncertified product.

But only 87-odd kilograms of GI-certified saffron moved through the facility last year, a fraction of total production. Most farmers lack awareness of the certification process or cannot afford the associated costs.

At his shop in Lal Chowk, Dar now faces a dilemma that would have seemed absurd a year ago. His regular customers, including hotels preparing wazwan feasts for tourists, bakeries making saffron-infused pastries, and families stocking up for cultural celebrations, demand volumes he cannot source locally. On March 3, following escalating conflict with Israel and the United States, Iran banned the export of all food and agricultural products, which severed his traditional supply line. Iranian saffron sits in warehouses in Tehran, blocked by a government prioritizing domestic food security during wartime.

Some traders who stockpiled Iranian saffron before the

conflict have begun releasing their stashes at inflated prices, creating windfall profits for a few while squeezing legitimate businesses.

Dar refuses to participate in this speculation, instead rationing his remaining inventory and advising customers to reduce portion sizes. “We tell housewives to use five threads instead of 10,” he said, measuring out precious strands into paper packets. “The flavor remains, even if the color proves lighter.”

The crisis has exposed vulnerabilities that extend beyond economics into cultural preservation.

Saleha Rashid, a fourth-generation farmer completing her Ph.D. in agricultural sciences, researches the phytochemical compounds that make Kashmiri saffron distinctive. She explained that crocin provides the color, picrocrocin the bitter flavor, and safranal the honeyed aroma—compounds developed through specific soil chemistry and altitude conditions found only in the Karewa plateaus.

“When you lose the crop, you lose centuries of selective cultivation,” Rashid said. “The corms adapt to this specific terroir. Move them to Himachal Pradesh or elsewhere, and within two generations, the chemical profile changes.”

Rashid’s own family harvested 6 kilograms of flowers this past season, down from 20-odd kilograms the previous year and 100 kilograms during her childhood. She documented the failure with scientific precision, noting how unseasonal warmth caused flowers to wither before releasing their stigmas.

The data confirmed what she said her grandmother had intuited while staring at empty fields: The land is changing faster than the crop can adapt.

At sunset in Srinagar, Dar locks his shop, leaving behind questions without answers and a spice that has no substitute.

He walks home carrying a heritage that grows lighter with every harvest. ■

**KAMRAN YOUSUF** is a multimedia journalist based in India.



A woman holds freshly picked saffron flowers on a farm in Shahn Abad village, near the town of Torbat-e Heydarieh, Iran, on Oct. 31, 2006.

# What in the World?

By Drew Gorman

The following is adapted from past editions of FP's weekly online news quiz.  
Test yourself every week at ForeignPolicy.com.



**1. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on March 7 accused the United States of striking a facility on Qeshm Island, in the Strait of Hormuz. What is that facility's purpose?**

- a. Oil refinement
- b. Water desalination
- c. Hydropower production
- d. Anti-air defense



**2. On March 11, José Antonio Kast was inaugurated as president of which Latin American country?**

- a. Peru
- b. Guatemala
- c. Colombia
- d. Chile

**3. As the war in Iran escalated, what did Bangladesh seek permission from the United States to do in early March?**

- a. Import fuel from Venezuela
- b. Buy more electric cars from China
- c. Import fuel from Russia
- d. Buy fuel directly from Iran

**4. An Italian referendum failed in late March, delivering a blow to Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni's government. What did the vote address?**

- a. Judicial reforms
- b. Immigration restrictions
- c. Access to abortion
- d. Reorganizing Italy's voting districts



**5. U.S. President Donald Trump said on April 1 that he was considering doing what, in response to U.S. allies' reluctance to enter the war against Iran?**

- a. Cutting off military aid to European allies
- b. Obstructing support for Ukraine in its war against Russia
- c. Stopping oil and gas shipping to allies
- d. Withdrawing the United States from NATO



**6. Pope Leo XIV landed in Algeria in mid-April on the first stop of his 11-day tour of Africa. Why did he choose to visit the Muslim-majority country?**

- a. One-fifth of its population is Catholic.
- b. Pope Leo XIII also visited.
- c. It was the birthplace of St. Augustine.
- d. St. Peter cited it as a holy place for Christendom.

**7. In late April, China blocked Meta's acquisition of Manus, a Singapore-based firm founded by Chinese entrepreneurs. In what field does Manus specialize?**

- a. Virtual reality
- b. Artificial intelligence
- c. Messaging encryption
- d. Biometrics

**8. Britain's Labour Party suffered losses in local elections in early May. Which party made major gains?**

- a. Reform UK
- b. Green Party of England and Wales
- c. Liberal Democrats
- d. Conservative Party

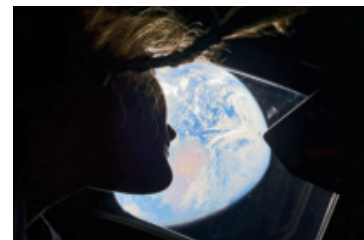
**9. Ugandan runner Jacob Kiplimo set the world record for which race distance on March 8? (Hint: His finishing time was 57 minutes and 20 seconds.)**

- a. Marathon
- b. Half-marathon
- c. 25 kilometers
- d. 10 kilometers



**10. The first photographs from the Artemis II voyage around the moon were released on April 7. One of the shots, titled *Earthset*, depicts what?**

- a. The moon rising over Earth
- b. Earth shadowed by a lunar eclipse
- c. Earth setting behind the moon
- d. Earth appearing to sit beneath the moon



ANSWERS: 1. b; 2. d; 3. c; 4. a; 5. d; 6. c; 7. b; 8. a; 9. b; 10. c



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